

Numina

Campaign Guide

2025 Update



INTRODUCTION

This book is intended to be an introduction to the world of Numina LARP and specifically the third major campaign arc, Numina III. It describes the world and its geography, history, nations, cultures, and religion. If you're looking for more practical information about how the game works, you may want:

The Website: <http://www.numinalarp.com>

The Rulebook:

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1xusB6VTBpFyFQ6yGAOGDL13pHEDJvPu8/view>

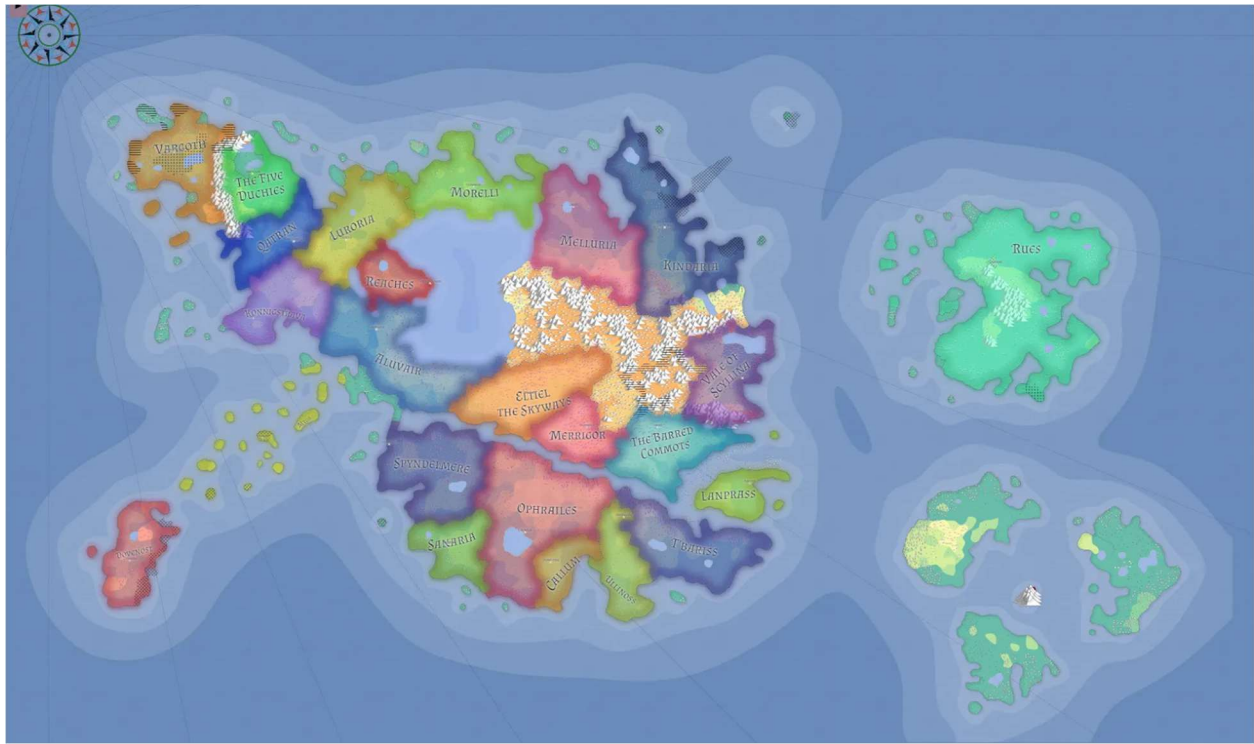
The Discord: <https://discord.gg/YUbmyK4Ehb>

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THE WORLD OF AELEDD



Numina is set in the world of Aeled (EYE-leth, /'aɪ.leð/). Previous Numina stories were focused on the island-nation of Rues and an earlier age. But the current campaign spans much of the world and is set in the Age of Works beginning in the year 123.

Fortune's Bend

Throughout history there are legends of Fortune's Bend - the home of heroes and the site of Death's gate. Throughout the ages the town has been in many locations, and taken many shapes, but it is always a crossing point between the worlds of the living and the dead, and most importantly, it always draws heroes who shape history with their great deeds. Every appearance of Fortune's Bend was called by that name at some point, but most are better known to history by other names --

The Map is Not the Territory

One can look at the common maps of Aeled and imagine that it is a civilized, settled place, neatly covered in nations and borders. Nothing could be further from the truth. Aeled is a vast world. While most parts are claimed by one country or another, there are some large areas which are not easily accessible and have no thresholds to allow easy travel. Many areas, both within national borders and between them, are functionally wilderness. True cities are few and far between. Smaller settlements are more common, but away from roads and thresholds, much of the world is uninhabited and not fully known.

Avrillus, Sarrako, Hekatesh, and other names famed throughout history. The last time Fortune's Bend appeared, on the island of Rues, it gathered heroes who restored cosmic forces to their true balance, stopped a divine conflict, and revealed to the world secrets it had long since forgotten. But that was almost three hundred years ago, and now Fortune's Bend has appeared yet again. What heroes will it gather? And what adventure awaits them?

CHARACTERS

Creating a Character

The Numina III rulebook covers the nuts and bolts of how to create a character. This chapter isn't intended to duplicate that step-by-step process. Instead, it provides some insight on what makes an interesting and appropriate character concept.

Character History

Why Submit a Character History?

A character history can be a helpful tool for both the player and the staff. It is a shared point of contact on a collaborative story, and those can be invaluable in a smaller, narrative LARP like Numina. When it comes to telling more personalized stories, a character history is similar to documents like culture packets that help establish important things about the world which staff and players can build on.

A character history can help staff understand two broad strokes of important character information: your characterization, such as motivations, fears, and goals; and your character's sense of place, such as where they have been, and who they may count as important. Both characterization and sense of place are excellent starting points for telling a collaborative story. Additionally, it can provide the player with some points to fall back on when they need to make decisions or need some inspiration to role-play a scene.

There is no one right way to create a character history. Some people prefer narratives, while others prefer dossiers or bullet lists. Regardless of format, we hope that we can inspire you to create a character history, provide you with some good things to include, and suggest details for those who wish to add more.

Below, we have provided an in-depth guide with helpful tips and guiding questions for creating a character history. Covered in the guide are some good things to have in a character history, including:

- A reason your character is out and about in the world and a reason they will stay on in Fortune's Bend. These reasons may not be explicitly stated or even known to the character.
- Loose ends, questions, and things left behind. This gives both players and staff some interesting things to consider, think about, and maybe use in a story.
- How important events or people impacted your character. Even if it was just their opinions, this will help tie your character into the world and might even provide a starting point for a story!
- Contacts, family, and friends. Who are the major figures in your character's life?

- Basic characterization such as a strong belief, a motivation, a hatred, a fear, or a weak point.
- Information for staff about characters or themes you might like to see brought into game or avoided.

Happy reading, and happy writing!

Helpful Tips and Guiding Points:

Is it time to write/build a history for your character? Well, here are a few ideas and guiding points to help you along the way. None of this is required; it is just a good place to review to see if you have things fleshed out enough to portray the character when it comes time for “Game On.” While you may have a feel for how the character will behave in a given situation, you might not have the history that led to that behavior yet. It is a fine line between character and history, so hopefully these tips and questions help.

When making a character, we like to think of three distinct areas: Major goals, Significant people, and Quirks.

Major Goals:

When you think upon the past and present of your character, what were/are some major goals they had that have shaped them? How did those goals come about as goals? Are they still working towards those goals, or have they moved on to something else? If they moved on, what spurred that change? If they are still working on them, what are those goals, how might they work on them? If they completed them, how did they do it? There will probably be a mix of completed goals and in progress goals.

An example of a completed goal could be that they already learned how to be a spell caster. A working-on goal is that they want to expand what spells they know. A passed on goal could be they thought they wanted to be a healer but realized they didn't like it so they moved on to throwing fire.

Significant People:

There are people that shape any life, be it a character or a real person. Think about who those people might be for your character. Are they still alive? How old are they now? When did they enter your character's life? Are they still around to influence it, or has there been a parting of ways? Was the influence something that has negative connotations or positive connotations? What link, if any, do these people have to your major goals? Significant people can be both friend and enemy, maybe even filling both roles.

It is a good idea to name at least one family member, one friend and one mentor type person. For example: my sister Jane and my best friend Frank learned how to cast magic from Mistress Formila at the same school, but I am pretty sure the Mistress held Jane as a favorite pupil and we haven't spoken in years because of the Mistress' obvious partiality.

Quirks:

Quirks, oddities, exceptions tend to be what help distinguish a character as well as help with the characterization and presentation. They make them seem more real than just the “knight in shining armor.” If the knight’s armor has a random heart shaped dent in it, people will talk about it. So what is something small but impactful that would be easy for you to role play? It doesn’t have to be obvious to the world, just something to make your character more real in your own head. Then think back to how these quirks might link back to the previous two categories.

Do you always need to have gloves on your hand before you will shake hands because someone once burned you with a poisoned ring? Do you try to collect every lonely plush animal and “give it a good home” because you once lost your favorite plush and were convinced that it was sad because it didn’t have a home with you anymore? Do you have to go pet every cat you see because the one time you didn’t you took an arrow to the arm? Do you wave at every passing procession because you once caught a Reel after waving at one as a child?

Other Stuff:

Outside of these things, you can flesh out a lot or a little about your history. You could know your lineage back 10 generations or you could just know you have one sibling. Some other good questions to ask yourself about your character are the below:

- Where is your family from?
- How long have they lived there?
- How big is your family? (parents, grandparents, aunts/uncles, siblings, nieces/nephews, etc.) Are they all still living? If they aren't, when did they die?
- How old is your character? (are any siblings older or younger and by how much?)
- Socio-economic background? (rich, comfortable, poor)
- Upbringing? (nurturing, neglected, other)
- Any schooling?
- Anecdotes from growing up or traveling?
- Places visited or did your character stay in their home town until they started adventuring?
- Why are you adventuring?
- Any known enemies? Known allies?
- What are any formative events in your life?
- What are your skills in-game and how did your character learn them?
- What large cultural or world events have happened in your character’s lifetime and how might they have impacted them?
- Do you have a favorite color? Food? Animal?
- Do you have a nickname? Who uses it?
- Do you have a hated color? Food? Animal?
- What do you always carry on you?
- What is your favorite form of art? (Songs, books, drawing, paintings, spoken stories, all, etc.)

Final Notes:

Remember that this is the start of your adventures in this vast world; maybe the middle, but definitely not the end. You are an entry level character with the skills to match. While you may have aspirations to be a mighty hero known throughout the world, you aren't quite there yet. Leave room for that in your history. Also, leave loose ends. Things that you could work on or things that staff can use to help build your character into the hero you want them to be. You never know what path the story will take and leaving loose ends in your history helps open up more paths for the story to take. Overcoming a few things in the past is fine, but your character shouldn't be a fully formed hero with no room to grow.

In regards to people named in your history keep a few things in mind. First, are any of these people going to be portrayed by another PC? If so, please let us know as soon as you do. Second, are there any that you would love to see or not love to see show up in the game itself? While we don't guarantee specific NPC appearances, it is nice to have an idea of which would be welcome and not.

Should you like the idea of having someone from your history portrayed by an NPC, it is best to have a way to recognize them should they come into the game. Something easily represented. Vague descriptions with one firm piece of identification that is easily representable. "Mistress Formilla had long hair, but I remember her timepiece that always hung from her shoulder on a chain. What most didn't know was that the other end of the chain held a small dagger."

Finally, remember that the story is just beginning. Saying that you know all the rulers of the world is not going to be accepted. If you wish to have a personal connection with anyone named in the information given out by staff before your first event, please contact staff about that before you settle your history.

Your history should allow you to have fun with your character in the game and add depth beyond what happens during events. Because we as a staff and community want you to have fun with both the character and the game, don't write anything that won't be or lead to fun for you.

Thank you for reading through this guide, I hope that it has helped spark some kind of inspiration to help you get to know your character a little better. While character histories and characterizations are not required, they are a great tool for staff and players alike. If you choose to share your history with a friend, they may have a better understanding of how to interact with your character in game just as you get to know a character in a story when you learn more about them. We as a staff can't wait to meet your character!

A "Heroic Game"

Numina III is designed to be a heroic game, which is an easy thing to say, but not as easy a thing to define when someone asks what that means. The staff of N3 would like to take this opportunity to express in more detail what sort of game we are hoping to run and more specifically what we mean when we say "heroic game."

Character Choice and Players in a Heroic Game

Not every character in Numina III will be the classic ideal of a hero, and we hope to delineate a difference between a heroic game, and a game in which all the characters must be heroes. It is definitely not our goal to severely limit our players' creativity and choice of character traits. Some characters will be flawed, and in the course of the stories we tell together, they will grow and change. Some characters may be heroes at times, but at other times their resolve will fail them. Our goal in the running of a heroic game is to give every character the opportunity to make heroic choices.

Sometimes these heroic choices will be explicitly presented as part of an ongoing plot or story, and sometimes they may be an inspiration that comes to you and the other two people awake at 5am. These opportunities for heroic choice, whether they come from the minds of staff or the minds of players, will have the power to drive the stories, and change big and small parts of the game world.

We would like our game to be a place where being a hero isn't about always doing the right thing, it's about the desire to do the right thing being a guiding force in the choices that drive the story. And while characters may not always succeed, and in some circumstances may even fail to let "doing the right thing" guide them, there is no place in a heroic game for characters that try to do the more harmful thing. Player characters in a heroic game don't try to make the world a worse place, and players avoid creating a situation that is not fun for other players.

Shared Responsibility and Storytelling in a Heroic Game

We believe that creating a heroic game is a shared responsibility. Some of the contributions of staff toward this common goal is providing heroic choices, and to avoid passively forcing a certain choice. In our view, a heroic game does not mean that making the most noble choice will result in good outcomes, and making any other choice will result in bad outcomes. Numina staff is not interested in creating a game where you just have to click the right option to get the "good ending." We equally appreciate players with stories about imperfect characters who do not always succeed at their personal and external goals. Heroic choices will ultimately have heroic outcomes, but your character not being ready to make that choice will become a different story of its own, with more opportunities for heroic choice.

There may also be times when your character makes that most noble choice, and in-world bad things still occur. It may sometimes appear that your character's heroic choice has failed or even backfired. Staff is often in the business of making bad things happen to empower an even more heroic conclusion, so we hope that you will stick with us through these more fraught collaborative storytelling moments.

Community Culture in a Heroic Game

Finally, we also want to touch upon the out-of-game element of a heroic story. It is the fabric that allows for a wide variety of characters to make a wide variety of choices and still maintain

a fun play environment for everyone. We like the phrasing adopted by several other games out there, and that is “Play to Lift.”

Playing to lift means that there is a behind-the-scenes focus from both players and staff on the impact of our actions and choices on other folks in the game. Playing to lift encompasses a wide variety of things but generally boils down to trying to make our impact on other’s games, if we choose to have one, a positive impact.

Playing to lift encourages a conscientious community culture that allows for things like the “Redeemed” foundation, where a player may choose to embody a morally imperfect character and yet also make the game and the community a better experience by when and how they choose to display that imperfection. When not every character has to be a classic save-the-puppies hero, this kind of consideration for others will be the bedrock of running a heroic game.

We’d also like to cover a few questions we have gotten in the past, with those answers intended to reveal even more about what a heroic game looks like to us.

FAQ

Q: Can I play a villain?

A: No. Our PvE antagonists may see you as villains, but they’re the real bad guys. We love playing villains and if you absolutely need to play one, come NPC for us! While playing the game as a PC though, we ask that any nefarious activities have a good intent at their heart, and that some out-of-game consideration has been taken to avoid a negative impact on other players.

Numina III is explicitly designed as a PvE game because we feel that players targeting other players for villainous activities such as theft, assassination, gaslighting, and deceit does not serve our goal of a positive community culture or of a heroic game. We welcome characters with an edge to them, but ask that you design your character so that those edges are always pointed in a PvE direction.

Q: Does that mean PvP is not allowed?

A: Correct. This seems like a great time to try to delineate the difference between character conflict and PvP. Character conflict is certain to come up at times when characters in the game have different ideas about how to resolve something or have conflicting desires. Character conflict can be a part of a good story and a good community culture when underneath the conflict, the players who choose to be involved are still conscientious about not letting the conflict make the game less fun for others.

Character conflict becomes PvP when it gets violent (this has never failed to negatively impact player fun at a game like Numina which is not built to support physical character conflict), or when the character conflict becomes a player conflict in which the people involved do not prioritize keeping the game fun for others. It’s the responsibility of players to discontinue their

character conflict if it starts to turn toward PvP, and the responsibility of staff to help find a solution if asked by the players involved in the conflict.

Q: Can I play a criminal?

A: Yes, so long as the above goals are kept in mind. Your character should be a criminal if that is the best way to accomplish their good-at-heart goals, and as a player you should design them so that their chosen criminal activity is not intended to negatively impact the fun of other players. As with playing a villain, please make sure criminal activities are pointed in a PvE direction, and give out-of-game consideration to the impact of your criminal actions on the fun of other players.

As a singular example, it may be possible to be an assassin if you work for a guild whose goal is to better the world by removing awful people from it. Part of our shared responsibility on staff will be to include these sorts of organizations in the world.

Q: Can I play a former villain?

A: Indeed! There is even a foundation for it. Just be sure to write your redemption arc into your character history and, if your villain pulls a few tricks out of their past self's toolbox, to make sure that they are pointing them at NPCs.

Q: ... What is a villain?

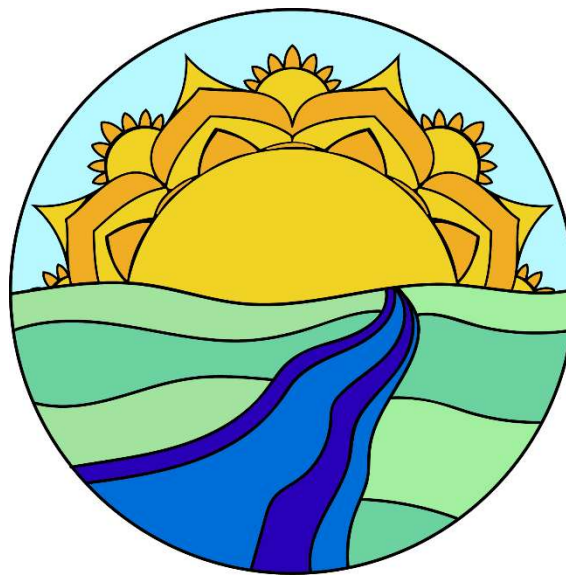
We mean someone who does harmful things for selfish or malevolent reasons. Some of our NPC antagonists will be villains, and some may not be. We feel that this type of character would make a poor PC for our game due to their negative impact on plot options and the fun of other players. Additionally, we on staff have more fun and enjoy the game more when we feel that we are supporting stories about making things better.

NATIONS & CULTURES

Aluvair

"The present is here only for a moment, the future unknown. Why then would you place all this value on an object when it will eventually depart?"

Aluvair is a vast alluvial plain of fertile soil crossed by rivers flowing south from the inland sea and down from the mountains of Eltiel. Lying almost entirely at sea level with a scant few rocky and inhospitable plateaus, Aluvair is most known to other nations for both the bounty of its crops and for the floods that wipe out entire years' harvests. These floods define the geography, politics, and culture of Aluvair, making for a people of unparalleled resilience and determination. Loss is such a part of life to the people of Aluvair that it is greeted as a friend and companion instead of a danger to be avoided.



Geography, History, and Climate

Lying at sea level south of the Inland Sea and at the foot of the mountains of Eltiel, the plains of Aluvair are gentle and hospitable terrain crossed by countless rivers and streams. This has created an ideal fertile land for the cultivation of crops and a land easily traveled both on foot and by boat. All the pastoral bounty of this land comes at a price however, with the low-lying nation vulnerable to the extreme to floods that inevitably come, though with no predictability to their schedule. The floods are not always the same in scale, but for every minor flood that washes away only a few animals and fields there is another that covers entire settlements and changes the course of rivers. The only difficult terrain in Aluvair occurs in the three areas known as the Tors, large plateaus where generations of floods have deposited rock and debris to such degrees that they now stand solid against the very waters that created them - dry but miserable plateaus barren of life standing in contrast to the water and growth below.

As a floodplain, Aluvair is temperate in the winter and can drift toward unbearably hot in the summer. Humidity is a way of life when one lives at the level of the sea. Close to the largest rivers and along the north and south coasts the breezes off the water keep the climate most consistent, and as a result most settlements are found in these places. It helps that the soil is best closest to the largest rivers as well, making their banks the ideal areas for living. Only on rare occasions has Aluvair suffered extreme cold in years where storms from Eltiel have been extreme through the winter and lingered westward over the plains.

It is said that in ancient times another nation stood in the plains of Aluvair. In the tradition of Aluvair, the name is not known, as it has washed away along with the buildings they built to fight against the floods. The legends of this nation say rituals and prayers were offered from their people to Eilona to provide land that would always be bountiful and rich - a land of easy plenty. And Eilona responded true to the deal. But in nature growth requires change and Eilona made the land certain to provide in a natural way - floods to till the soil and enrich the land. The people of this land fought against these floods building dikes, levees, dams, and channels but all to no avail. In time each settlement washed away, and all cities were eroded and washed beneath the soil, lost in time. Those who survived in this land were those who chose not to fight against nature, but to accept it and adapt to it. Thus did the people of Aluvair come into being as a people who know that all things can change, and all things can end. The only certain thing is that nothing is permanent.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Off the southern coast of Aluvair is found something that seems grossly out of place with the rest of the nation. A single city, small by the standards of other nations, built on an island close enough to shore that a determined and fit swimmer could easily cross in an hour. This city has walls and enchantments that protect it from the ravages of time and salt water, and buildings are built of stone in contrast to the wooden and natural structure of all other buildings in Aluvair. This is Durade, the capital and center of politics for the nation of Aluvair. A remnant of the nation that came before, Durade hosts the government of Aluvair for the simple reason that it is easiest to maintain a government if outside governments can reliably and safely visit. Found here are the major ports of trade and the largest Threshold of Aluvair, as well as the People's Forum. The People's Forum is the governing body of Aluvair, made of one representative from each settlement over 50 members strong. These representatives are called Tributes and are chosen in various ways to travel to Durade and serve in the Forum for 5 years, after which they may never return to sit the Forum again. The Tributes arrive not on a schedule determined by the Forum, but rather by their home so changes of membership are frequent, which serves to prevent large, segmented blocs from forming and helps to preserve the democratic nature of the body. The power of the People's Forum mostly lies in their ability to regulate foreign relations, and domestic matters are very often left up to the settlements to handle. Normally only irreconcilable conflicts between settlements come to the attention and decision of the Forum.

Within the settlements, economy is a strange subject. The people of Aluvair recognize a division of public and personal property, but also maintain a sense of obligation and moral responsibility to assist one another in times of need, especially in the times following the floods. Turning a profit in coin from the sale of excess crops or the findings from the floods serves little purpose, as stockpiling coin is simply asking for your wealth to be washed away to no benefit. Better by far to have wealth in animals, seed, or lumber that can make life easier for you and yours in the times between floods and maybe even give a greater chance that some will still remain after the next flood. This means that most settlements band together to export their excesses and import community needs rather than try and become individually wealthy.

For the nation of Aluvair as a whole, economy is handled in a similar way but on a much grander scale. Often a settlement will trade their goods to the Forum instead of attempting to find a nation or merchant to sell to, allowing the Forum to trade and deal on a much grander scale and maintain stockpiles of needed things for the settlements to purchase. This often gives a mistaken perception from the outside world that the economy of Aluvair is under government control when in fact they act more as a brokerage.

Everyday Life

Though it has been said many times, the lives of the people of Aluvair are defined by floods. While it is easy to leave that as a surface thought about loss and rebuilding, it in fact goes much deeper than that.

Impermanence as a concept guides most people of Aluvair. Though they are a determined people, working to produce an excess almost never happens. When enough has been done, there is no point in continuing a task at the expense of another task or even a diversion or simply rest. A stockpile will wash away, so why make one bigger than absolutely necessary? Likewise, loss, breakage, hardship, and even death are seen as simple inevitabilities, not things to be feared. That is not to say that they will not save someone in danger, repair a broken tool, or give aid to those suffering, but instead it means that when the fight against these things is over, failure is the same as success. You worked, you tried, you lived, but one cannot always win and one cannot always live. All things in life are impermanent, and that is why life is beautiful and precious.

Settlements in Aluvair range in size from under 100 to around 1000 people but rarely larger. Size of settlement is defined by what can be done in a given space by the available people, so when a settlement gets too small it often vanishes as the people leave and when it becomes too large it fragments off into another settlement. This means that along the largest rivers you will never travel far from one to the next and often an outsider would not recognize that they have moved between large settlements as they pass down the river. A person's lineage and history are tied up in who they are, not in something as ephemeral as buildings, so patriotism felt toward a settlement is rare, replaced with a friendship and sometimes kinship with those who live and work within the same settlements.

The way the people of Aluvair live is very different from people who have not defined themselves by being ready to lose all their possessions. Construction is almost always done in ways designed to never fight the flood. Houses are not dug on pylons but instead built almost as ship's hulls. Pens for animals are made of interlocked timbers and not of stone. Art is seen as an indulgence, but one nearly everyone chooses to indulge in. Favorite mediums are things that are designed to be destroyed easily, even without a flood. Drawing in chalk, sculpture of sand, pouring colored sand, and anything fragile are loved works, reminders that beauty is in the present, not the future. Following along with defining themselves by the floods, the people of Aluvair often mark time by floods as well. Contracts, Loans, and sometimes even Marriages can be marked by a count of floods. Though these things are rarely written down (a piece of paper

does not survive a flood), a promise made “until the next flood” is thought a good solid promise and one made “Through the next 10 floods” can be an entire lifetime.

The Aftermath

Of course, in a place where floods are so common there must come a time after the flood where the people rebuild. This is commonly referred to as the Aftermath and is a rare departure from the general behavior of the Aluvain people.

As the waters recede, the people begin to scavenge immediately. Even before shelter is restored, they will take to the fields searching for what materials have found their way nearby, which people, houses, and animals have been lost, and what Findings have appeared. This is all gathered in the settlement so rebuilding can begin in earnest. This is often the time where the smallest settlements vanish, as if few enough people remain and few enough materials are found, then they simply turn and leave, seeking a new place to begin again.

Two things are always resultant from this time that are alien to the culture of Aluvair: Findings and the raids. Findings are relics and pieces of the ancient kingdom that stood in Aluvair long ago. These objects are often made of precious materials or empowered with magic and are found only in Aluvair after a flood - some strange and ancient magic prevents them from ever being found when outsiders have attempted to dig for them. Old legends say that the Kingdom was laid low by the waters, and only the waters can return them on high.

Raids are the second and more dangerous occurrence. On top of the Tors live the people who simply can't accept the loss that comes with the floods. While some who feel this way leave, many instead move to the Tors and live a hardscrabble life of scant resources but one where what they have, they keep, and what they take is theirs. In the times after the floods, they band together to scavenge from the Aftermath and take what they can, even when what they find already belongs to the settlements. Findings are of course their primary target, but when you live on barren rocks even construction materials, tools, animals, and simple food can be precious beyond all else. While some raiders care only to make their life better, some are more aggressive, and it is not unheard of for raiders from the Tors to kill for what they want.

Current Events

The last two floods came only 18 months apart, and Aluvair has been in a lean time for the last year. This has placed a strain on even the largest settlements and has caused chaos in the People's Forum as the membership has dropped significantly with the disappearance of many settlements. Into this chaos, Merchants from Myos have come seeking profit, knowing that two floods mean more Findings and more chance to trade the necessities of life for priceless artifacts.

From the Tors the raiders appeared both times but with little to be found after the second flood, the raids came more for the settlements than for the scattered flood debris, and many in Aluvair have for the first time began to speak in the Forum for an organized response to the dangers that the Tors represent. While the voices opposing this far outnumber the supporters, the fact that it is said at all is a dangerous departure from the norm.

Notes for Players

Demonym: Aluvain (singular and plural)

Cultural Plot and Theme

To be from Aluvair is to be accepting of the fleeting nature of life and possessions. A player who chooses to be from Aluvair should consider what has given them a cause to travel out and seek another life. Perhaps they left their settlement and simply found themselves wandering in search of a home. Perhaps that famous Aluvain acceptance of loss has created a warrior who doesn't fear their own death. Perhaps they even found themselves unable to bear the loss anymore and have sadly turned from Aluvair in search of a more stable life. Whoever you are as an Aluvain, impermanence and loss has shaped you into that person.

Many times, when someone who has left Aluvair for a life of adventure is sought by those from home, it will often be because the aid of a more worldly individual is needed to assist at home. The majority of the folk of Aluvair are not prepared to take arms physically or in battles of politics, so when such things threaten Aluvair they are often ill equipped. Likewise, there is a great mystery surrounding the ancient civilization that came before Aluvair, and many would seek to exploit that for good or ill. Aluvain often accept whatever the world throws at them, so when they seek help there is always a difficulty that simply can't be accepted and moved beyond.

Costume and RP Themes

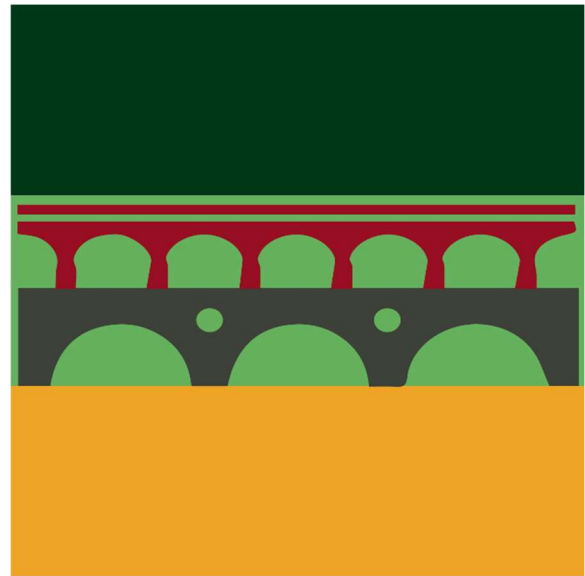
While the acceptance of impermanence is central to the Aluvain way of life, not all residents are calmly at peace with the universe. Many folk of Aluvair will fight hard for their friends and family and hard for their way of life but be accepting when things are taken in the end. In fact, many folk of Aluvair live life with an almost aggressive passion, knowing that anything can be snatched away at any time so living to the fullest now is wise. On the flip side, one of the dangers that many face is drifting into Nihilism, believing that if nothing is permanent then nothing matters.

Clothes in Aluvair are often made for warm weather, favoring breezy fabrics and short sleeves. In colder weather they will often layer up rather than wear heavier single garments. While traditionally wools and animal fiber fabrics have been most common, those who live life largely will choose to sport more garish and rare garments, since they are fine to have while they last. Either way, styles that will not restrict movement in the event of a sudden flood are always preferred. Garments are almost always dyed brightly, and recently a trend toward Ombre styles has become popular to show the fading of color as a reflection of the Aluvain outlook.

Tattoos have become popular among young Aluvain, though they usually pick fewer more meaningful designs. This is in contrast to the more traditional outlook where skin inks were used as a decoration that would fade over time and could be treated as a temporary work of art.

Dovenost

Even before the Lattice broke, the ancestors of the Dovenosti tended to hold themselves aloof from the rest of the world, and when Threshold travel was completely cut off, Dovenost settled in happily in its isolation. Over the centuries, they built a rich culture bound by a strong sense of personal honor and autonomy and dedicated to attaining mastery in any number of crafts and trades, most notably carpentry, weaving, and smithing. When international contact was reestablished sixty years ago, Dovenosti goods caught the attention of the world, leading to a high demand for trade. This has caused mixed reactions among the populace, with some feeling invigorated by new ideas, and others concerned about what traditions may be lost. Dovenosti who choose to leave their home country often find themselves feeling like fish out of water as outsiders seem to see them as pathologically self-sufficient and rigidly honorable. In reality, the Dovenosti have strong communal bonds and a desire to improve the world around them by using their skills to the utmost.



Geography, History, and Climate

A large island far to the south, further south than even the Myos Islands, Dovenost tends to have mild summers and snowy winters, with snowfall accounting for the majority of the island's precipitation. The topography has very few mountains, including a few mostly dormant volcanoes in the southwest. The land is covered with a blend of forests and plains and is mostly devoid of lakes and rivers. However, most of the land is suitable for farming, owing to multiple aquifers across the island that allow for good irrigation. In places where the aquifers do not run deep, the Dovenosti have built reservoirs and aqueducts to hold and move rain and snowmelt.

There is only one true city in Dovenost, the capital: Glavni, which sits on the southeast tip of the island's one large lake. Glavni is small, only about six square miles, but it hosts a population of nearly 10,000 people. Most Dovenosti live in rural villages of about five square miles, with populations of fewer than 2,500.

Dovenost is a country with a long history, so long that most of its citizens do not bother with trying to establish when their ancestors arrived on its shores - whether by Gate, ship, or some other means - preferring to say, "we have always been here." For some families, this may be literal truth; for others, only a small exaggeration, as Dovenost was isolated from the rest of the world for centuries after the breaking of the Lattice. Generations of Dovenosti lived and died with only tales of other places.

The country's history is marked by long stretches of Metioch and Istarum-pleasing stability, punctuated by brief (but often intense) periods of chaos and civil strife, as the Dovenosti believe that all Purposed beings are equal, and being born to wealth or privilege does not entitle one to any perquisites of birth. Therefore, the Dovenosti head of state, known as the Arbiter, can come from any walk of life, and ascends to the throne as the victor in a multi-factioned civil war. There have been sixty four Wars of Ascension in Dovenost's history; the longest - also among the earliest and bloodiest - lasting nearly twenty years, and the shortest being decided within a month. The most recent War of Ascension lasted fifteen months.

The eighteenth War of Ascension ended after seven months when one of the western volcanoes erupted, killing or incapacitating over half of the faction leaders and prompting the survivors to rally behind Leyla Maral, a civil engineer who had quickly distinguished herself among the combatants for her cool head and logistical aptitude, trusting her to deal fairly with all parties during the state of emergency.

The forty second War of Ascension marked the last time when the winner was decided by single combat. In the final duel, Martin Henrik had clearly bested opponent Ivan Goran, but Goran refused to yield, until Henrik finally had to take his head. Since then, being dangerously stubborn has been referred to as being Goranesque.

The only truly bloodless war was the forty ninth War of Ascension, which occurred in the middle of one of the worst famines to ever strike Dovenost. Most of the citizenry was too weak or weary to fight, and so the few who wished to vie for the throne did so through diplomatic means. The chosen winner, Tomasz Bosko, is viewed as one of the worst Arbiters Dovenost has ever had.

Contact with the rest of the world was established sixty years ago when a young mage, Sona Zoric, after reading about the Lattice, Gates, and Thresholds in an ancient text, decided to attempt opening a Gate between her house and her paramour's. Instead, she opened a Gate to a spice shop in Myos Cori, which immediately closed behind her. Once she had found her way to a Myosian mage and sorted out what had happened, that mage, Claudia Corlevaro, returned with her to Dovenost, bringing along a delegation to discuss trade with the Arbiter at the time, Aleksandra Fiala. Those early overtures were received with a great deal of hesitation, but Arbiter Fiala eventually granted the Myosians permission to create Gates within Dovenost and to negotiate directly with Dovenosti individuals living in the few coastal fishing ports for docking rights.

The flag of Dovenost is three wide horizontal bands of dark green, light green, and gold for the forests, fields, and pastures of the Island, with a stylized aqueduct in dark red and gray across the middle band.

Politics, Government, and Economy

While the wars to select an Arbiter form the most notable portions of Dovenost's history, most Arbiters have relatively sedate reigns. The primary role of Arbiter is not really to rule, but to adjudicate conflicts that arise within the populace. Even then, most conflicts are resolved by the

parties themselves, or with the assistance of Circuit Magistrates who travel from village to village. Circuit Magistrates are nominated by their home villages, confirmed by the Arbiter, and sent to travel a route that does not include the Magistrate's home territory. In the event that parties dispute a Magistrate's ruling, or the Magistrate does not feel they can fairly make a decision, they appeal to the Arbiter whose ruling is final and absolute.

The secondary role of the Arbiter is to administrate projects that will benefit the country as a whole. This is the legacy of Leyla Maral, who, in the later years of her reign, saw to the expansion of roads and aqueducts and helped pioneer a system of sewers and waste removal. To assist the Arbiter in this aspect, Magistrates are also tasked with reporting any expansions or repairs needed to the national infrastructure that local Dovenosti craftmasters and engineers either do not have the expertise to handle or that are far enough outside any local jurisdiction that the Arbiter must appoint someone to the task.

As Dovenost broadens its associations with other countries, the Arbiter's role has expanded to encompass international diplomacy, although both Arbiter Fiala and her eventual successor, current Arbiter Ilia Stolarz, have shown little interest in the task, passing most trade negotiations off to the craftmasters whose goods will be traded and otherwise doing only what is demanded of them.

The Arbiter holds their seat for life, though many Arbiters abdicate as a matter of honor when they feel they can no longer manage the job. When the death or abdication of an Arbiter is announced, any citizen over fifteen years of age may declare their intention to try for the throne. Those who choose not to declare are then bound by honor to remain completely neutral in the conflict for as long as it lasts. There is then a short period during which those vying for the throne duel or negotiate with their neighboring fellow contenders to form local factions. Once a contender has a faction of at least one hundred behind them, the real battles begin. Each time a faction wins, the loser - if alive - must either join the winner or declare their complete neutrality. Whatever a living faction leader does, the members of their side must follow suit; to do otherwise is a grave dishonor. In the event that a faction leader dies in battle, their coterie must likewise join the winner or commit to being neutral.

When the most recent War of Ascension twenty-two years ago brought with it the possibility of seeking international allies, the few contenders who attempted to obtain foreign aid quickly found other factions immediately halting their own conflicts to stand in opposition to anyone who would so dishonorably bring in outsiders. It is rumored that Arbiter Stolarz won the right to head their faction in a game of chance, their rivals being unable to decide who was best suited to lead, but absolutely unified in the conviction that Donatas Wincenty, a wainwright who had sought the backing of several Myosian merchants and a handful of Ophralian nobles must not ascend to the throne.

Outside of the Arbiter and their Magistrates, there is very little active Government in Dovenost. The people keep to their villages and handle their business as honorably as they can. When an individual is found to be in the wrong in a conflict, the most common punishment is that they

must correct their wrongdoing. If that is not possible, a period of ostracism is enforced. Egregious transgressions may result in banishment from society or, rarely, death, but these sentences can only be handed down by the Arbiter. Banishment is enforced by a magical sigil placed on the perpetrator.

As to the economy, within Dovenost, most goods are obtained through barter. The early days of outside trade were marked with Dovenosti crafters often feeling cheated in transactions involving coin. Those craftmasters quickly added a year abroad to the responsibilities of their apprentices, and the current generation of craftmasters are far more conversant in the worth of their wares.

Everyday Life

Dovenosti life is centered on providing for oneself through one's chosen craft, and in the perfection of skill within that vocation.

Young people in Dovenost do not marry until all parties are able to earn a living for themselves and provide for at least one child. Children from birth to three years of age are reared by their parents. From three to five years of age, they spend most of their days with the village creche, where they are allowed to play under the watch of a rotating handful of teacher-apprentices and retirees. From five to ten, they attend school in the mornings to master basic literacy and mathematics and spend the afternoons visiting the various craftmasters at work to begin recognizing where their interests and talents lie. From ten to twelve, they are fostered for a week to a month at a time with the local craftmasters, furthering their ability to make an informed decision about what path they would like to take. For the next two years, adolescents narrow their choices and spend longer periods fostering with the different masters that they hope will choose them as apprentices.

Every year, villagers gather to celebrate Calling Day, when the craftmasters publicly select the fourteen-year-olds that they have chosen to apprentice them. In smaller villages, there have been years without a Calling Day. Rarely, especially in larger villages, a youth may not be selected. When this happens, that young person goes on a journey-year seeking a master elsewhere. Usually, they are either successful, or return home having gathered enough additional maturity to be selected in their hometown.

It is also during the term of one's apprenticeship that a Dovenosti serves in the local militia. For one day a week, apprentices receive martial training to defend their villages in the unlikely event of invasion. Unspoken is the understanding that this training is to equip every Dovenosti to participate in an Ascension War if they so choose.

Apprenticeships officially end at the master's discretion, usually within ten years. It is not unheard of for a Dovenosti to remain an apprentice while still supporting themselves with their work. One of the most common cases for a Magistrate to hear is that of an apprentice who feels their master is holding them back. However, often, when the Magistrate finds in favor of the apprentice, it is determined that the master did not hold them back maliciously, but rather in

hopes that their apprentice could first demonstrate ability beyond themselves. The two highest compliments in Dovenosti society are "I have nothing more to teach you" and "today you have taught me something."

The various crafts that one might apprentice to include - but are not limited to - alchemist, apothecary, baker, blacksmith, carpenter, cabinet-maker, farmer, healer, herder, mage, mason, printer, tailor, teacher, thatcher, wainwright, weaver, wheelwright, etc.

All Dovenosti crafters build first for strength and permanence and then for beauty and detail. They place great value on how well something is made, and plain but solid work is esteemed far above craftsmanship that is ornate but slipshod. A small cottage made without a hint of draft or leak is deemed superior to a mansion with corners that aren't quite square or floors that aren't quite level. An unadorned shirt, perfectly tailored with even stitching is thought to be of greater worth than one with lace and ribbons that catch and fray. Certainly, if one has the means for a large home or adorned garb, these flourishes can reflect status, provided they are well-made.

While most masters are relentless perfectionists in their chosen crafts, there are vocations where one cannot completely control one's outcomes through skill alone. Farmers, fisherfolk, trappers, teachers - these individuals still excel at what they do, but they accept that there will always be times when circumstances mean they are less successful. If ever a Dovenosti complains about a perceived failure due to elements that were not their fault, the common sympathetic response is, "You cannot force the sun."

A large part of the Dovenosti code of honor is that one does not owe one's neighbor. This means that in bartering negotiations, one does not take or offer goods on the promise of future bounty. It also means that their family structures are exceedingly egalitarian. As mentioned above, all adults within a family are expected to be able to provide for themselves through the goods or services they create; therefore domestic tasks must be divided fairly to allow everyone to practice their craft. Lastly, the Dovenosti have a strong sense of "the common good," but a limited sense of charity. They will not allow a neighbor to freeze or starve, but help is somewhat predicated on a circumstance - an accident of birth or nature - wherein an individual is truly unable to help themselves.

The idea of not being beholden to anyone extends to their customs of inheritance. Dovenosti tend to write lengthy wills, leaving one only one heirloom apiece to as many people as they can name. Should any of their personal possessions remain after the disbursement of the will, any of the deceased's neighbors omitted from the will may request an item for remembrance, and a Magistrate is brought in to oversee the claims. Any items remaining after this process are burned.

The Dovenosti express their humorous side with the annual celebration of "Shoddy Day" in which masters and apprentices of one skill set attempt to complete challenges set by masters of another skill set. Elaborate cakes attempted by tailors and shepherds, horseshoes smithed by teachers and weavers, and shirts sewn by bakers and apothecaries and the like are subjected to good-natured criticism from those who actually know how to accomplish the tasks they set, and general merriment is had by all.

Beyond “shoddy day,” it is accepted that one does not need to strive for perfection in one’s hobbies. Through their years fostering with different masters, the Dovenosti pick up a wide variety of skills, most of which will not inform their lives, but which they otherwise enjoy. In a similar vein, while the Arts are too impractical for the Dovenosti to devote themselves in the pursuit of art, music, or theatre, they deeply enjoy music and will sing along lustily to any tune they know, paying little heed to how well they sing.

Current Events

The civil improvement project of the last three Arbiters has been to pipe the country’s supplies of natural gas into every Dovenosti home for better, reliable lighting and cooking. The project is nearly complete, and all Dovenosti agree that it is a vast improvement over wood fires, candles and torches.

More interestingly, there is a growing call for Arbiter Stolarz to either take a larger role on the international stage or create a council that will. This has met with pushback from many of the populace who feel that too many Gates and ports were opened too quickly and that Dovenost should instead cut back on its dealings with the continent. The busiest port of Zaljev has seen small outbursts of violence on its docks as isolationist bands have attempted to disrupt trade. The perpetrators were quickly stopped and shamed by others in the port who reminded them that they were interfering unbidden in the honorable business of Craftsmasters who were willingly engaging in the international market. The largest concern is that while Arbiter Stolarz is relatively young and healthy, when they die or abdicate, the growing divide on international trade could make the next Ascension War an intense and drawn out affair.

Notes for Players

Names for Dovenosti characters will tend to have an Eastern European/Slavic flavor. Most people have a first and up to three middle names followed by a family name, which may come from either the maternal or paternal side. The Dovenosti tend to use whichever family name sounds better with their first and middle names. Children are addressed by their first names (unless they’re in trouble). Once one is apprenticed, during formal interactions, one is addressed as Apprentice [Last Name]. Masters are formally referred to by their craft and their last name: Smith Broz, Miller Pavlovic, Weaver Novak, etc.

Cultural Plot and Themes

Dovenosti characters may find themselves being drawn into trade negotiations or diplomatic dealings. Their experiences with the world beyond Dovenost means they could be of service to Arbiter Stolarz should they choose to be of use.

While common sense suggests that there could be twenty or more years until the next Ascension War, there is always the possibility that one could occur sooner.

Costume and RP Themes

Dovenosti clothing is well-made; both practical and comfortable to move and work in. Garments tend towards clean lines and simple styles more in keeping with medieval-fantasy than renaissance-fantasy. Leather and fabric are equally prominent depending on how practical it is for one's vocation [character class]. Trim, embroidery, and adornments are rare, but not unheard of.

How one chooses to play their character may be informed by how happy their character was in Dovenost and how long they have been outside the country. A character who found their village too small and too hidebound, who left as soon as they could, and who has been adventuring in other places for a decade will behave very differently from the happy apprentice who has just been sent out on their year abroad.

Consider the following questions when choosing to play a Dovenosti: How long have they been abroad? How excited are they about Dovenost being part of the international community? Do they share the Dovenosti propensity to value plain quality over detail and decoration? Do they struggle with the emphasis on honesty and honor? Are they of an age where they participated in the last War of Ascension, and if so, how did that experience shape them?

The Mists of Eltiel

The Mist of Eltiel is the shrouded remains of the great nation of Eltiel, the Skyways. While much of what happened to the land and its people remains unknown, there are survivors that carry the culture and lineage of Eltiel who have by one method or another outlasted their homeland.

The land is located in the high, cold peaks of the mountains near the center of the continent. A few poles and broken cables from the Skyways lay just outside the edges of the mist, marking the boundaries of the former nation.

Apart from these scattered survivors and paltry landmarks, all that remains of Aeled's impervious masters of Arcaneering are a few museum items and the awe-inspiring tales of their technological prowess.

Geography, History, and Climate

The mist of Eltiel clings to the land with a chilling permanence. At first glance, it seems benign—grey, unassuming, even serene in its stillness. Yet the fragmentary reports from the first few explorers speak of a stifling heaviness within, a presence that gnaws at both body and soul. Those who entered, whether bold scouts or foolhardy adventurers, did not return.

For all its ominous qualities, there has been no sign that the mist has corrupted the land it cloaks. From what can be seen outside the mist, the rivers that flow from Eltiel's heartlands are clear and untainted. Shadows of crops and standing trees can be seen in certain places when the mist is thin, still tall and unbroken.

Historically, Eltiel the Skyways was the peerless pinnacle of Aeled's Arcaneering prowess. Its bastions stood as the envy of empires, its towers and skyways a marriage of artistry and technological genius. For centuries, the Eltiel defensive network—the Aegis Perpetual—kept the realm impervious to invasion. Their Arcaneering technology, drawn from the deepest mysteries of the elemental veins and arcane alignments, promised an age where even the whispers of calamity would be but shadows on an impenetrable wall.

The fall of Eltiel and the obliteration of the Aegis Perpetual has sent ripples of unease across Aeled. Nations that once relied upon Eltiel ingenuity now scramble to reconfigure their own defenses, fearful that a similar fate might befall them. Trade routes have shifted, with merchants avoiding even the borders of the mist-shrouded land. With no concrete answers yet available, debates rage in taverns and offices alike over whether their destruction was divine retribution, arcane hubris, or something more ancient and unknowable.



Speculation about the origin of the lingering mist is likewise a popular topic in the absence of any facts. Some whisper of a failed experiment with aetheric resonance—an ambitious attempt to merge the Arcane, Shade, and Void gone catastrophically awry. Others suspect external tampering, a rival nation such as the Vargoth exploiting some fatal flaw in the Aegis Perpetual defense system. A darker theory posits that Eltiel's own leaders, in their relentless pursuit of perfection, inadvertently unleashed a force they could neither contain nor comprehend.

Of the people of Eltiel and of their great cities, there is no sign. The mist allows no view beyond a mere ten or twenty feet most of the time, leaving all to imagine if the population perished in the initial calamity or lingers transformed within the grey, unforgiving shroud.

Politics, Government, and Economy

In its day, the government of Eltiel the Skyways was run by the military. The court of officers acted as the highest governing body in the country, being made up of the Six Majors in charge of transportation, supplies, defense, invention, commerce and foreign relations. This tradition began at the foundation of the mountain kingdom, when the Rappnos held a bloodline monarchy. Under their governance, the nation gained its foothold in Arcaneering and gained great prosperity. Eventually, the Rappnos bloodline was widespread among the people of the peaks, and the elite royal guard became an equally widespread military that watched over all of the citizens.

Though the monarchy seemed to run out its time peacefully, Eltiel had occasional trouble with a terrorist group known as the Revenants of Rappnos. They were one of a few threats that could impact a kingdom so well protected from the outside world.

The other well-known threat to Eltiel came from the mining tunnels bored into mountains. It was said that fierce, highly adaptive monsters occupied certain mines, and became increasingly harder to keep at bay. As with so many things in Eltiel, it is unknown if any part of them survived the fall.

In recent times, the Arcaneering of Eltiel was on a meteoric rise, spurred on by breakthroughs in refining Sky Metal into Cloud Gold. The properties of this material was believed to be the keystone that allowed some of their most incredible innovations to become reality.

Eltiel's largest export was manufactured goods. Their wood, metals, and other raw materials were imported from other nations and transformed into useful goods via the application of their Arcaneering processes. These have now become artifacts, as most can not be replicated without the proprietary machines and manufacturing that Eltiel guarded closely.

Everyday Life

For survivors, a keen reminder of life as a citizen of Eltiel is their periapt, a trinket that contains some of their essence. Every citizen had one of these and they would keep it close to them. The periapt was created as part of coming of age or naturalization into the culture, and used an Arcaneering ritual to pull some part of a person's essence from within. It is not clear if this

essence is spirit, soul, Purpose, or something entirely different. The Eltiel called it Vulder, or the Unspoken Self.

Some citizens enshrined their periapt and rarely interacted with it, but it was far more common for the periapt to be a significant part of a person's daily rituals. Some Eltiel used their periapt to meditate, others treated it as a conversational partner, and still others as luck charm or soul gem. Periapts can not be taken from the person whose essence they contain, but in some cases individuals may exchange periapts to show the strength of their relationship. It was also known that some historically significant figures, or those who had broken the trust of the nation would willingly give their periapt to the military.

Current Events

Among those who have attempted to aid in the aftermath of Eltiel's fall, Merrigor agreed to send a small force of Revenants into the Mist to see if anything could be learned. As of the start of the year 125, those Revenants have not returned.

A Note from a Historian, published in a Mellurian newspaper in Winter of 124-

As I pen this account, I cannot help but feel that Eltiel's story is not yet finished. The mist, though silent, speaks to a mystery that demands resolution. Whether the answer lies with the return of the Revenants, the ingenuity of those who dare to study the mist from afar, or the courage of a new generation of explorers, the truth must one day be uncovered.

For now, Eltiel is a scar upon the face of Aeled— a stark reminder that even the greatest heights of civilization can crumble into shadow without warning. It is a chapter unfinished, a question unanswered, and a wound unhealed.

We must remember Eltiel not just for its fall, but for what it might teach us about the limits of ambition and the fragile line between brilliance and oblivion. Until the mists part—or until we dare to step into them once more—we can only wait, watch, and record the echoes of a vanished world.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot and Themes

Eltiel as a nation does not exist anymore, and so players looking at this should be prepared to play a displaced culture. If your character escaped Eltiel around the time of its fall, they will not know anything of the Mist or what is within it. Please contact staff if you need help determining what happened during your experience, and how you escaped.

If you plan to play a character who spent a lot of time in Eltiel, your experience in that nation was one of invention and glowy pipe plot combined with a bit of military drama, mysticism, and

some small-scale shenanigans. When it came time to combat the undead who inhabited the lower mines, it was more of a zombie shootout with ever-changing prototype technology.

Individual family lines and private organizations didn't have much meaning in Eltiel, but service in the military or individual invention were meritorious.

Costume and RP Themes

Eltiel costume mixes steampunk with 1800s western military uniforms. Lots of brass, goggles, buttons, braids, festooned with medals and decorations. Uniforms of a specific company are often tied together by a military patch or insignia worn on the uniform jacket sleeve, often in the shape of a mechanical crafted version of an animal or other natural object.

Eltiel was known for finely manufactured textiles that could not be replicated by hand. No more of these are being manufactured, and those that still exist are being preserved for posterity, or are being worn and maintained with care by survivors.

The Five Duchies

Hearty. Steadfast. Iron-forged. These are the folk of the Five Duchies.

The Five Duchies are independently-managed locales with unique land features; each is presided over by a Speaker. Their primary activities involve industry and commerce.

The Duchies mostly depend upon each other for their goods and services, but the amount of sheer exports they send to other countries via both the Lattice and their system of roadways is dizzying. The roads and ports of the Duchies are constantly humming with trade and the people there live simply but very well. Their pursuits might only be disrupted by a development as serious as war, and with the threat of a Vargoth invasion, this does indeed seem imminent. Five Duchies folk are strong and kind-hearted, generally sparing anything they can for someone truly in need. Their infrastructure—centered on trade—is healthy, but they do not offer fine crafts or lofty educations within their territories. That was what Valarmore was for, after all.

In matters of war, even if they cannot always boast high-quality training, Five Duchies fighters are ferocious for the simple reason that they have something they believe is well worth protecting: their land and their loved ones.

Geography, History, and Climate

The Five Duchies is part of a large peninsula surrounded by a few small islands and bordered at the Northwestern corner by the land of the Vargoth, formerly known as Valarmore, also once spoken of as the Jewel on the Sea.

The Five Duchies and Vargoth are bisected by the Howling Cliffs Mountain Range, through which a pass called the Howling Gate once offered access. Tributaries running down from these mountains feed into two big lakes, Terrapon Basin and Lake Una. The general climate of the Five Duchies is temperate, with both deciduous vegetation and evergreens. The people there experience wind, rain, snowfall, and enough sunshine to ensure bountiful harvests and yields for their many farmers. The land features are dynamic; some duchies are more heavily forested than others, and some boast rolling hills and valleys.

Early Five Duchies history is passed down by the telling of stories rather than the writing of books. Its origin story unfolds thus: that in the early days when the peninsula was new—and empty—a brother and sister, Berolt and Elysande, had set out to claim land for themselves and build great cities that would become their legacy. Originally planning to carve out these settlements together, they quarreled and parted, and Elysande went north. Her keen mind and talent for recruiting others to her cause led to the establishment of Valarmore, her finest accomplishment, her great Jewel. Berolt was stout and steady, but didn't have the resources or inclination to plan great cities. Together with a fiercely loyal group of warriors, he founded what would become the Five Duchies. In later years, the siblings put their grievances behind them and ended up treating and trading with one another. They both lived well into old age and died

peacefully, but they always wondered what would have happened had they stayed together in their youth and built their legacies together rather than separately.

Historical figures of note that Five Duchies folk may have heard tell of:

- Berolt and Elysande, brother and sister credited with founding the Five Duchies and Valarmore
- Galifel Dyneley, major donor and original benefactor of the Atheneum at Valarmore
- Zephora Peckham, current oldest living inhabitant ever of the Five Duchies at 122 years old
- Margus Heyworth, ranger who discovered the Howling Cliffs and first hiked the pass
- Olive Molyngton, first homesteader and founder of Northfield in Hare Duchy
- Captain Easten Fawkes, credited with establishing the Foxfall Mercenary Company

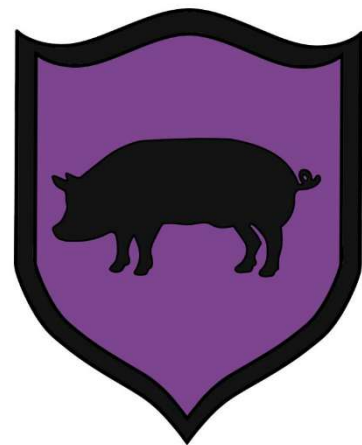
Politics, Government, and Economy

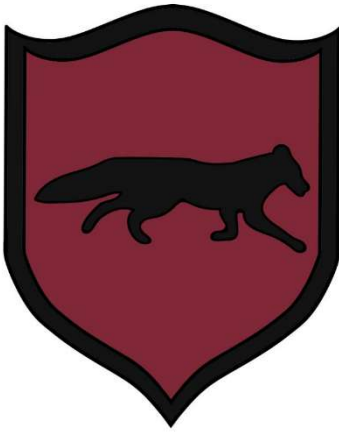
The governing structure of the Five Duchies may be tidily summed up by calling it a meritocracy. Each duchy is represented by a Speaker, someone appointed regardless of status or necessarily experience for their acumen and good sense. Speakers may have different management styles; some are more casual, some more ceremonious. In all cases however, they govern until someone more worthy to hold the office is found. Changeovers are usually quick and peaceful, though one or two stories are told of more fraught situations—people are people, after all.

Every duchy has their own colors and crest, and the people wear these with pride.

- Bull - brown and yellow, the image of a bull
- Boar - purple and black, the image of a boar
- Hare - yellow and blue, the image of a hare
- Stag - green and white, the image of a stag
- Fox - bordeaux and black, the image of a fox

The Boar Duchy has served as the council seat of the Five Duchies since its inception, each representative traveling there to discuss current affairs. It not only houses the council chambers, but it is home to Boar's Run Township, the Boar's Run Bank, and a major Lattice Node. The people of the Boar Duchy are known for their candles and soaps and make excellent tallow for cooking. Bristle brushes and simple leather clothing are also notable exports of the Boar Duchy. Finally, this duchy is known for its excellent road system that makes travel to and from the other duchies safe and simple, even without the help of the lattice.





The Fox Duchy is the least habitable region of the Five Duchies. The ground is more clay than soil, and with the exception of a few tall trees, very little grows there. It is said that this landscape fosters the hardiest of soldiers. While the fighters from the Fox Duchy may not be as well equipped as some soldiers in other lands, pound for pound, you will not find better trained soldiers in the Duchies. Barracks in the Fox Duchy regularly train officers from other lands. Stonekeep stands as the capital of the Fox Duchy. Its walls house numerous blacksmiths and an armory that can supply all the Five Duchies in a time of need. Though this proud city was once a busy hub for soldiers near and far, it is now quiet and sparse as many of its citizens are at the Howling Gate

preparing for the impending Vargoth invasion. Many have noted that the birds of prey overhead seem to outnumber those who are left.

The Bull Duchy is made up of rolling fields graced by herds of cattle. Many of the people here are content to raise their livestock and live simple lives. Cattle Ridge could be called the capital of this duchy, although it is little more than a well-appointed ranch run by an established and respected family. In the past, the Bull Duchy saw little excitement—other than travelers going to or from Valarmore by way of the Howling Gate, which lies in the Northern part of the Bull Duchy and among the Howling Cliffs Mountain Range. Now, the folk nearby watch in dread for what horrors might come through the Gate. It is all that stands between the Vargoth and Bull Duchy. The blacksmiths here are busy! They can easily turn out weapons—swords and shields of all kinds. If pressed, the farmers there might even bring out their pitchforks and scythes to defend their families from enemies.



The Hare Duchy is the breadbasket of the Five Duchies. Farms of every sort blanket these lush fields. Hare Duchy farmers are known for their hospitality and are always happy to take in a weary stranger and feed them cabbages, carrots, potatoes—simple but delicious farm-to-table fare. The capital, Northfield, is in the northern part of the lands, and it was once home to Spring and Harvest festivals each year, though these have been effectively put on hold since the fall of Valarmore. No Valarmorian families of privilege trek down through the pass to experience the fresh air and wholesome atmosphere of the festivals anymore, and the Hare folk are tired and worried over the threat of war. Northfield houses the leaders of the duchy, and

many healers come here to practice their medicinal arts with the abundance of healing herbs and roots that are available each season. If it can be grown, it can be found here, perhaps to the exclusion of some of the rarer herbs. Wonderful potions and salves are made here, especially with the import of grease from the Boar and Bull Duchies. People give gifts of heirloom bulbs and cuttings to their friends and children. In addition, this region is known for their fine tailors.

At first glance, the Stag Duchy appears distant and isolated from the other four. The roads here dwindle from cobblestone and hard-packed dirt down to meager paths, and it is easy to lose one's way. Some structures have been seen cradled high in the trees and it is believed that denizens of Stag Duchy sometimes expand their quarters into the air to avoid forest predators. Deep in their forests, these carpenters and woodworkers do not mingle often with strangers. But despite appearances, these people are known for their gruff compassion and big hearts. When disaster has befallen the Five Duchies, the Stag Duchy has mobilized and traveled to the affected place with tools in hand. Within days, new houses are erected, roofs repaired, and bridges rebuilt. With no words of acknowledgement expected, the folk of Stag Duchy are content to pack up and return to their lands, living deep in their forests. Those who have traveled to their capital of Oakdale do not speak of amiable people, but they do tell stories of the quiet way that their needs were attended to and the serenity the forests brought them. Fletchers here do a brisk business and most of the duchies' ranged fighters come from here.



In addition to internal and external trade, bartering is a rather common way to handle business in the Duchies, especially with neighbors. Nearly everyone has something of value that someone else wants or needs. Why not barter a quart of milk for some woven cloth or a few cakes of soap?

Everyday Life

Most of day-to-day life is concentrated around work for the folk of the Five Duchies, whether that means crafting, study, or growing things. Family and relationships with loved ones are of utmost importance, though, and time that is not spent in toil is spent heartily enjoying what pleasures can be afforded; fine weather, good food, and good company. There were a number of festivals that Five Duchies people observed pre-fall of Valarmore, some major and some more auxiliary, depending on the amount of time and energy they had to allot to such celebrations. Though the Spring and Harvest festivals are on hold right now, the Walk of Lights Festival still takes place on the last major gathering each year.

There is a game that nearly every person from the Five Duchies is taught from childhood—Four in a Row. Players take turns placing game pieces on a grid until one of them is able to declare, “Four in a row!” vertically, horizontally, or diagonally, or until no other tokens can be played. Almost everyone has taken the time to make their own game board, and there are all sorts of

creative ways to do this: embroidered cloth grids, wooden ones, grids drawn in the dirt. There are huge grids, played with thrown stakes, and small ones, played with two sets of matching stones, or with whittled twigs. It is a fun little game for Duchies folk to come up with clever new ways to realize Four in a Row and they constantly seek appreciative comments from others on their innovations.

In addition to their Genesori, it is customary for Duchy folk to invoke the idea of their “land,” particularly when emphasizing a point and especially when swearing—probably because it’s one of the most valuable things they can conceive of. One might hear:

- “By the Land, what are you doing!?”
- “By this Land I stand on, I swear I speak the truth.”
- “This secret is bound between you, me, and the Land.”
- “Good Land!”

And in fact, many people carry a pouch or vial containing resources from their home territories—dirt, sand, twigs, rocks, etc. as a talisman, so that home never feels too far away.

Current Events

Life in the Five Duchies changed drastically just over a decade ago. Their close ally Valamore fell horrifically to a Vargoth invasion almost overnight, and an influx of Valarmorian refugees has made its way to the Duchies, telling tales of violence and death. The Five Duchies rallied armies from nearby lands and attempted several times to retake Valamore, but were unable to breach the Howling Cliffs each time. The hope of retaking Valamore began to fade in the citizens' minds. It has been noted that the number of surviving Valarmorian refugees is relatively small considering the great size of what was once Valamore, and for a long time, folk wondered what happened to the rest of its citizens. It seems many of them have been Turned into servants of the enemy, but new information points to the discovery of some few refugees hiding out in underground caverns. The Vargoth have strengthened and organized themselves in the last year, unleashing attacks on the Howling Gates in northern Bull Duchy and even conspiring with other nations. Soldiers from each duchy and their foreign allies have come together to man the Howling Gates. But a palpable tension can be felt throughout Aeledd as a full-scale Vargoth invasion seems imminent.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot and Themes

The plot for the Five Duchies and Valamore will deal heavily with military tactics, so players should be ready to track company movements and make decisions about how, where, and when to defend their points of interest. Additionally, there is a good deal of heavy emotional, story, and character-based roleplay planned, especially including tough ethical questions. Some of this will be quite dark, but will be tempered with lighter problem-solving tasks, like improving communication between important NPCs and helping townsfolk with their day-to-day

problems. Duchies and Valarmore PCs are encouraged to find story threads that seem interesting and pull at it, even if they're small.

The Five Duchies folk are tied strongly to their homeland and many carry with them soil from the Duchies when they travel. This centers them and reminds them what they are fighting for. While they are not all career soldiers, it is said when defending their homeland, they are as fierce as any in Aeled.

Costume and RP Themes

With the Vargoth firmly ensconced in the Northwest as a particularly nasty foe, the folk of the Five Duchies have begun to shutter their windows and bar their doors at night; no one knows what fell things roam the land in the dark. The people of the Five Duchies are constantly attempting to prepare, reinforce, out-think, and out-plan the enemy. They are canny, but this way of life is new to them. Everywhere, there is talk of this new horror and of ways they might ensure their families and loved ones are safe.

Death is an inevitability, whether from danger or from the cycle of aging, and the folk of the Five Duchies meet these difficulties with dignity. It is extremely important to them that they mourn those they have lost, and, as many other cultures do, they erect memory stones and light candles to honor them.

Costume inspiration is pseudo-medieval with a gothic horror flair. Folk of the Five Duchies tend to dress in well-made fabrics. The designs are simple, but their tailors are good. Each duchy has a crest and colors to represent it, and the people wear these proudly. Pants, dresses, corsets, all are typical. All types of armor as well—leather, metal, etc. Players choosing to play as Valarmorian refugees may wear an elevated form of the same dress, but with more lush fabrics, prints, and designs, especially with Art Nouveau influences.

Kindaria

Kindaria is a remote land with vast expanses of wilds shot through with deep chasms. These chasms are home to some of the most large, strange and dangerous creatures in the world. Life in Kindaria is largely defined by whether one lives in the various homesteads or calls the Timeless Bazaar home. Most Kindarians are rustic but proud homesteaders who band together to work the fertile farmland and protect themselves from monsters. On the other hand, the Timeless Bazaar is a city built to cater to travelers and adventurers seeking to explore both the chasms and the mysterious Deep. The Deep is a vast complex of caverns and chambers that underlies much of Kindaria. Climbing and mountaineering are facts of life in Kindaria and various straps, belts, hooks and loops are incorporated into common clothing to facilitate this.



Geography, History, and Climate

Kindaria is bordered by Melluria to the west, the sea to the north and east and by a largely unexplored volcanic wasteland to the south. The entire landmass of Kindaria is a vast, gently sloping plain. The southern and more inland reaches of Kindaria are cool, comparatively dry and dominated by prairieland. As one travels northward or towards the coast, the prairie gives way to tree-dotted savannah and eventually to dense jungle.

However Kindarian geography, and indeed much of Kindarian life, is dominated by the chasms. The grasslands and jungles are shot through with deep canyons and ravines. Separating Kindaria into hundreds of “islands” of land. In addition to being a physical barrier, these chasms are home to strange and dangerous wildlife.

In a few places, the canyons provide access to a vast underground complex of unknown origins that seems to stretch under much of the grasslands. This enigma has become known simply as “The Deep.” The Deep remains to this day only partially explored, and there are rumors that it can never be fully explored because it is changed by the whim of Garioch himself. Within the Deep are traps, treasures, and monsters at every turn, and an equal number of would-be explorers find their deaths as find their fortunes.

In common, smaller chasms, the environment feels rather primordial. In the dim light, few green plants grow despite the fertile soil. Instead, fungal forests proliferate, inhabited by creatures resembling giant spiders, scorpions and centipedes. In the deeper chasms, especially those that provide access to the Deep, even stranger creatures live - dwellers underground who exist largely independent of the surface world.

Most of the structures in a typical Kindarian homestead are homes and barns, but it's not unusual to see a smithy or mill. By tradition and necessity the tallest structure in any homestead is the watchtower. Most watchtowers are a simple wooden scaffold, though some may be enclosed by thatch or reed or even made of stone blocks. The purpose of the tower is twofold, to offer a platform where people can watch for danger and to hold a beacon fire that can be lit when danger is detected. An elevated fire can be seen at great distances at night over the relatively flat Kindarian terrain and provides valuable warning to adjacent settlements as well as any passing travelers.

The Timeless Bazaar is the only large city of Kindaria. This name is misleading, as the Bazaar is just as affected by time as anything. It simply never stops functioning, trading at all hours and remaining lively and active every day and night of the year. The chasms of Kindaria as well as the Deep draw adventurers, explorers and monster hunters from all over the world, and the Bazaar's main industry is catering to these travelers. The Bazaar was first established when explorers discovered a major threshold that overlooked a particularly deep chasm. Upon examination they discovered that this chasm broke into the Deep. Over time this opening was widened and made more accessible, giving any who wish it, access to the Deep.

Politics, Government, and Economy

The basic unit of life in Kindaria is the homestead, a community that blurs the line between a family group and a farming village. Under normal circumstances each homestead is largely independent and largely lacking in what an outsider would call government or economy. Everyone shares in the chores of the farm and looks out for each other. Guidance is provided by a small homestead council, or occasionally by a single elder. The appointing of leaders is democratic, done by formal vote in some homesteads and general consensus in others. When a situation arises that is of concern to multiple homesteads, a conclave is called, with representatives from each homestead meeting to discuss the issue and vote on a course of action. There are stories of great conclaves involving every homestead in Kindaria, but one on that scale has not been called in living memory.

Minor crimes in Kindarian homesteads are dealt with socially as befits a family. For serious breaches, the typical punishment is exile. A criminal sent on their way with supplies in broad daylight stands a good chance of finding a new home in the Bazaar or in another land. Exiling someone at night is a far more serious matter, traditionally reserved for the most serious situations and has fallen out of favor even for them in recent years. However all this is largely academic; most homesteads are, barring the occasional monster, peaceful places that spend little time thinking of crime and punishment. That said, Kindaria has a certain appeal for those who prefer to avoid the formal structures of government in other lands, and a few homesteads are notorious for being willing to take in those who are unwelcome elsewhere.

Though the climate varies in different parts of the region, a common theme throughout Kindaria is extremely fertile soil. Because of this, the dominant business is farming. Staple crops, especially grains and tubers are grown in great quantities. Kindarians also raise livestock, mostly

in the form of goats and pigs. Large animals are fairly rare and cattle in particular are prized for the amount of milk they can provide. A few homesteads are lucky enough to be located along one of the few major roads in Kindaria or near a lattice threshold. These are only a little larger than the average homestead under normal conditions, but host periodic market days when caravans arrive from other regions via road or lattice and people come from all the neighboring homesteads to trade with them. In particular Kindaria enjoys a robust trade with neighboring Melluria, who are always willing to barter refined metals and constructed goods for basic foodstuffs.

The Bazaar is an anomaly in Kindaria, a place that thrives on trade, travel and commerce. All manner of things are available for sale night and day, but the focus is on things that might be needed as an adventurer, treasure hunter or monster hunter venturing off into the wilds, the chasms or the Deep. A common trick, usually regarded more as a prank than a scam, is to sell newcomers an “Authentic Map of the Nearby Deep.” Anyone who has spent any time in Kindaria knows that such maps are worthless. Some say the Deep is touched by Thiacris so that its shape cannot be understood. Some say that it was Garioch who made it ever changing. Still others claim one need not invoke the Genesori to explain why a huge and incredibly complex structure isn’t mapped correctly. Regardless of what you believe, maps are worthless. An experienced guide is better, but you should be prepared for even them to get lost occasionally. The most significant political and economic forces in the Bazaar are guilds. From rope-braiders to armorers to healers, every profession an adventurer could need has a guild in the Bazaar.

Everyday Life

The average homesteader has little interest in martial pursuits and doesn’t think of themselves as an adventurer. They regard those who actively seek out danger as foolish, but that doesn’t mean they are any stranger to hazards. Incursions from chasm-dwelling creatures are rare, but an ever-present risk. A simple journey to the next homestead involves crossing the chasms. With a little luck, via a crude rope bridge, but failing that by venturing down into the chasm, crossing it and scaling the far wall as quickly and quietly as possible.

Any journey in Kindaria is a significant expedition and the small homesteads don’t have luxuries such as inns. Even if they were large enough to support them, the typical homesteader would never make a business of hospitality. A visitor to the homestead is a guest of the family, greeted and welcomed as one might a distant cousin. Most homesteads maintain a guest house specifically for visitors; even those that are too small or have fallen on hard times go out of their way to put a roof over travelers heads and a warm meal in their stomachs. It’s a difficult place to travel, and no one wants to spend the night in the open if they can help it, especially near the chasms. As such, it’s an unwritten rule of Kindaria that hospitality is not lightly denied. Conversely, requesting hospitality under false pretenses is a deep taboo. Visiting a homestead with the intent to do them harm is one of the most serious crimes imaginable, followed closely by failing to mention any risks that hosting you may bring. Even this is not grounds for refusal of hospitality though. To say “I seek shelter, but I am a wanted criminal in another land” and be

told “We will shelter you, and feed you, but if authorities come, we will give you to them” is certainly not commonplace, but it is very Kindarian.

Occasionally a visitor is invited to stay for one reason or another. This is an occasion for great celebration. There's little to recommend one homestead over another other than the people, so such an occasion is usually accompanied by a wedding, adoption, or apprenticeship, but the more private event is typically eclipsed by the welcome feast and the preparing of a home for the new resident. Sometimes such an occasion for feasting aligns with the availability of an unneeded bull or a milk cow that no longer produces, creating an opportunity to make a local delicacy. While the available beef is old and tough, and the local wine is not considered quality by more “sophisticated” nations, the combination of the two along with local vegetables, pork and a complex, multi-step cooking process creates a unique stew. Due to the set of circumstances that has to occur for the dish's creation, consuming it is almost a rite of passage for homesteaders. Of course, a version of it, often made with higher quality ingredients, is available at any time from any of a dozen taverns in the Bazaar, but those in the know will tell you that without the love, care, and cause for celebration, it's not “real.”

The vast majority of homesteaders spend their days tending to the homes and the surrounding farms, but a few specialists are exempt from day-to-day chores. A skilled blacksmith or weaver may be excused from farm duties to focus on their trade, and there is one uniquely-Kindarian specialization, the mountaineer. Even by the standards of Kindaria, mountaineers are masters of climbing, ropework and search and rescue. Their duties include building and maintaining bridges and climbing paths, but they are expected to spend most of their time training themselves and their apprentices, to be ready in the case of an emergency. Most homestead tradespeople are locals who apprenticed with the closest thing to a local expert, likely someone from the next homestead over, but mountaineers who trained with the guild in the Bazaar are prized. Should a homestead's mountaineer fall afoul of the many dangers of their profession, many homesteads will request aid from the Bazaar rather than giving the job to one of their own.

Art, as it is regarded in many nations, is rare in Kindaria. One seldom encounters a painting, or a sculpture, or a formal performance. Rather Kindarians tend to prefer the embellishment of necessary items. Embroidery, pottery, woodcarving and the weaving of patterns into thatch all bring beauty to items that are needed for everyday life, and this fusion of practical and aesthetic resonates for most Kindarians more than “pure” art. A popular craft in Kindaria is the shaping of trees. Living, growing trees are tied, twisted and bent into specific shapes. This is used both to craft living trees into structural elements of homes and other buildings and provide decorative touches to homes and their surroundings.

To an outsider all homesteads look simple and rustic, but they are quite varied if you know what to look for. The signs of a prosperous homestead aren't gold and jewels but stability and permanence. A watchtower made of stone rather than a simple wooden scaffold, a small herd of cattle rather than a single dairy cow, large, shaped trees that needed several generations to grow into their current pattern, a well-maintained house set aside just for guests -- to a Kindarian homesteader these are the things that represent wealth.

Current Events

Kindaria is rather timeless. Life in the homesteads continues much as it has for generations and the Bazaar is an always-changing flurry of constant activity. But despite this, there have been a few noteworthy events of late. In the Bazaar, the Illustrious Kindarian Society of Delvers and Excavators (called the Delver's Guild by those in a hurry) has done something unprecedented. They have taken a permanent position in the Deep, complete with fortifications, patrols and encampments. Their goal is to "pacify" a small part of Deep, allowing travelers less eager to risk their lives an opportunity to experience the adventure of the Deep. Thus far, their camp is not exactly safe, but certainly safer than most of the Deep.

Meanwhile, far to the North, in the jungles of the far reaches of the Kindarian peninsula, homesteads have been reporting sightings of Skourrigal. A chasm-dwelling creature not unlike a giant centipede, they are considered commonplace by adventurers and mountaineers. However, the few that leave the chasms tend to stick to dark places. They're a grave threat to small groups traveling at night, but until recently one approaching the lights and noise of even a small homestead was almost unheard of.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot and Themes

To be a Kindarian is to face danger and be part of a community. Consider whether you want to play a citizen of the tumultuous city of the Bazaar, a resident of a tight-knit homestead, a traveler who hasn't found their permanent place yet, or an exile who lost theirs. Do you want to actively seek out danger, or (unsuccessfully) try to avoid it. When you do fight monsters, is it for fame and fortune, to protect your people or simply when cornered?

Folks in the Bazaar make their livings on seeking adventure in the chasms, wilds and deeps or by serving those who do and so that sense of excitement pervades everything they do. To a homesteader the focal point of society is family, though not always blood. They regard those who go looking for danger as foolish, but they also accept it as a fact of life. When monsters rise from the chasms, sometimes you have to run, sometimes hide and sometimes fight. You won't meet an adult homesteader who hasn't done all three at some point. And while most don't tend to think of themselves as warriors or adventurers, even the simplest farmer knows they've survived in a place where many couldn't. There's a bit of swagger in even the humblest Kindarian, and they know they've earned it.

Costume and RP Themes

Since climbing cliff walls and navigating crude rope bridges, often while carrying farming equipment or weapons, is such an integral part of life, wearing various straps, hooks and buckles is the norm. Over time this has evolved from a practical necessity for attaching tools, weapons, climbing gear or ropes into simply an element of the culture. For homesteaders belts and straps of leather, canvas and rope bearing steel hooks, rings and clasps are normal wear. Some

merchants and artisans of the bazaar, and some travelers to Kindaria have adopted the form without the function, wearing brightly colored straps with brass or gilded hardware.

Kindarians are fond of embroidery and decorative stitching. It provides an opportunity to add both reinforcement and aesthetic touches to otherwise simple clothing. Loose garments or hair are always worn in styles that can be easily secured if needed, especially below the knees or around the face. Shin wraps and pulled-back hair are common sights.

Konnigstrava

Konnigstrava is a kingdom in ruins. Once it was a prosperous feudal monarchy, ruled by benevolent kings and queens, and overseen by a noble class that was by and large fair and virtuous. The kingdom was by no means opulent, but most people lead a comfortable life without want or need. All that came to an end with the coming of the Pestilence.

Geography, History, and Climate

The Kingdom of Konnistrava is composed mostly of gently rolling plains and moors, dotted here and there with forests and rocky hills. The southern shoreline is more protected and has many harbors and fishing towns large and small. The northern shoreline tends to be more rocky and rough, with cold waves crashing on tall stone cliffs.

The weather is generally mild year round, but also a bit cool and damp. Rain and fog are common in all seasons. Snow is uncommon in the winter but it will occur particularly along the northern shoreline which is affected by the wind coming off the cold northern currents.

Konnigstrava was settled in antiquity by people moving south and west from the main continent. The land was not particularly rich and fertile but it supported some farming and sheep herding on the plains. Over time noble houses formed and a hereditary line of kings was established. Things ran fairly smoothly in the sleepy rural kingdom for years until the time of the Pestilence .

No one is exactly certain where the Pestilence came from, what caused it, and why it settled in the Kingdom of Konnigstrava. But its effects were immediate and widespread. It began in the slums of the coastal port of Schonnenburg, leading some to believe it came by way of ship from some far off land. But within a year it spread across the entire length and breadth of the kingdom, and no town, city, hamlet, or estate was left untouched.

The Pestilence is nearly always fatal. It starts as a cough, but quickly results in sores and rashes over parts of the skin. Generally within a few days the coughing gets worse and the victim becomes weak and bedridden, and then dies. In some rare cases people recover, though often they will have marks on their skin for the rest of their lives. For reasons unknown some people seem to be impervious to it.

The Pestilence spread quickly, and soon the dead and dying were everywhere. In short order as people panicked and became desperate, society frayed and then utterly collapsed. Peasants and serfs looked to their Lords for help. Some tried to offer what little aid they could. Others



walled themselves within their castles and manors and tried to hide from the Pestilence with varying degrees of success and disaster. Cities became depopulated and lawless. Whole villages and towns were deserted as people fled to the countryside in hopes of escaping the Pestilence.

The Pestilence has begun to subside in recent years as the population of the kingdom has plummeted and cures and measures to combat the Pestilence have been discovered. The borders of the kingdom are still officially closed on both sides, but people have been known to slip across in each direction. Some of the ports are now open to very limited and regulated commerce.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Much like everything else in Konnistrava, the government is largely in shambles. The King is nominally still in charge of the kingdom, but his rule barely extends beyond the gates of the capital city of Alberstadt. There is some semblance of normalcy within the capital city, but life there is stressful and dangerous. The Iron Guard carefully controls who does and does not enter. Any sign of illness will get you thrown into the Sanitarium, which is usually a ticket to the Charnel Fields outside the walls. The Iron Guard and what human City Guard that remain ruthlessly enforce the will of the king within the walls, which over time has become stricter and more repressive.

Those towns that are still functioning have largely given over to self rule by mayors and town councils. Some rule justly and benevolently, while others are little more than warlords ruling through fear and thugs and enforcers. A few towns especially hard hit from the Pestilence are in ruins, and home only to madmen, the dying, doomsday cults, Plagued Undead, and Undead Hunters.

Noble holdings run the gamut. Some noble families and estates are either dead or so depleted as to be unable to administer their lands and provide for their people. Others have weathered the Pestilence and still provide for those under their protections. Still others have turned their backs and fortified their estates and castles and allowed the lands around them to fend for themselves.

The common folk in the countryside have in some cases are still supporting and being supported by their liege lords. Most however have been left to fend for themselves. Nearly all large scale farming and herding has ceased, and people are given over to subsistence farming and foraging. Barter and charity take up as much commerce as coin.

Everyday Life

For most people in Konnigstrava everyday life is about survival. People are as a rule scared, suspicious, and paranoid. Finding food to get through the season and protection from Plagued Undead, brigands, and monsters are high on the list of concerns.

When the Pestilence first struck there was a lot of hysteria. Everyone was scared of getting the Pestilence from everyone else. Conspiracies and rumors washed over the land as to the cause and culprits. Many people felt the Pestilence was supernatural in origins, and claims that it was a plot by heretics, Black Witches, foreign agents and the like were common. Demagogues arose who convinced people that it was all the fault of one villain or the other. No one trusted anyone else, and this sped up the unraveling of society. While much of that is now in the past, cults and gangs and companies of witch hunters still prowl the countryside and can be found in nearly all towns and cities.

Some towns and cities are abandoned, but people have started coming back to the main and important ones. The population, or at least the living portion of it, is a bit less than half of pre Pestilence levels. Basic business and trade is beginning to come back, but urban areas are still full of ruins, poverty, and slums.

Farming and sheep herding still exists in the countryside, but not to the scale it was once practiced. The rural population is much more spread out with many people living in lonely cabins and houses in the woods and hills and moors. Vegetable gardens, small amounts of livestock, and hunting and foraging allow people to get by.

The Pestilence is still around and people still die from it, but it no longer rages the way it once did. Over time people began to discover folk remedies and medicines and tonics to either aid those that catch the Pestilence or fortify people against it. Many were produced by alchemists, apothecaries, hedge wizards, and cottage witches experimenting in primitive conditions over boiling pots and cauldrons. There are as many different elixirs, potions, and remedies as there are people inventing them. These cures are often peddled by traveling Plague Doctors, though unscrupulous ones also sell basically snake oil.

The noble houses and estates that have not walled themselves in and secluded themselves are struggling. Some struggle to administer their lands and aid their subjects. Others seek to regain lost glories and stature. The small class of questing knights attached to the noble houses has grown smaller still. Many were taken by Pestilence, or slain trying to combat the Undead and Monsters that have spread in the land as civilization has retreated. A few currently roam the lands with no lord or master left alive.

One difficulty Konningstrava faces in coming back from the Pestilence is to find a way to fill the depleted ranks of guardsmen. With everyone focused on surviving this is no spare manpower. To compensate for this the capital city rolled out a force of constructs to keep the peace and guard the wall. Called the Iron Guard they are a formidable if slightly erratic force. The practice has spread to towns and noble estates outside of the capital city, though often constructs there tend to be of lower quality.

Over time people in Konningstrava has grown very superstitious. With no clear cause for the Pestilence it is common for people to wear charms, talismans, fetishes, and wards against the Pestilence, ill omens, the evil eyes, and so forth. Often this takes the form of trinkles hung from a belt. Seals and ribbons attached to clothing are often widely seen. A folk practice that

predates the Pestilence but which has become much more common is to build scarecrows to protect your household. Even in urban areas a cornhusk doll will often be seen over a fireplace.

Home life everywhere is simple. Luxuries and finery are largely a thing of the past. A staple of Konnigstrava households is that they will always have a pot of soup or stew on the fire. This is usually a simple root vegetable broth or basic stew. The smell of soup usually greets visitors to a house even before the door is answered.

Current Events

The current king remains locked in seclusion within the royal palace in the city of Alberstadt. He has not been seen in public since the start of the Pestilence. He rules the city and his decrees are enforced by the Iron Guard, but the people of the city begin to grow restless until his increasingly harsh decrees. Many people long to return to the days before the Pestilence when life was simple and laws were few.

Notes for Players

Konnigstrava provides players with a setting in which to explore a society in crisis. While the worst of the Pestilence is over, the future of the kingdom is uncertain. Depending on how current events are resolved the kingdom may be on the road to recovery, or it could fall further down the spiral towards chaos and anarchy.

Cultural Plot Themes

Much of the plot set in Konnigstrava will deal with how the various elements of society have dealt with the disaster of the Pestilence. The relationship between the nobles and those they have been charged to protect will likely play into many plotlines. The lands of Konnigstrava are profoundly unsafe. The threat of the Pestilence still remains, but there are also dangerous cults conducting bloody rituals by moonlight, deserted town overrun with Plagued Undead, dangerous monsters and the Monster Hunters that seek them traveling the roads, and starving brigands who would murder for a loaf of bread.

Konnigstrava also provides players with an opportunity to explore growth for characters rooted in profound poverty and a lack of safety. While life as an adventurer is likely to be relatively comfortable for characters, it might be seen as “roughing it” for players coming from more privileged backgrounds. However, for someone with a recent background in Konnigstrava, adventuring life might seem to be a huge improvement compared to conditions at home. This can be used as a way to provide contrasts between characters.

Elements of horror and the supernatural will certainly be present in storylines. Monsters roam the countryside, Undead are everywhere, and ghosts linger in the halls of cold deserted castles. Even in places that are seemingly safe like the few towns and cities that are still populated the people are under such stress that there is always the danger of being accused of black sorcery or spreading the Pestilence, or running afoul of underground cults looking for victims.

Costume and RP Themes

Costuming for peasants, serfs, townsfolk, and rural dwellers tend to be simple and drab. Dark colors predominate. Clothes are often old, tattered, and patched due to hard living and not much in the way of wealth. Simple pants, long shirts and tunics, wide leather belts, peasant blouses and skirts in simple flat colors are common. The cool weather means that coats and vests are often worn, along with knitted or crocheted scarfs and hats and sweaters. Wearing hats is the norm among all classes and professions. Pointed wide brimmed felt hats (i.e. witches hats and pilgrim hats) are popular and worn by both men and women.

Well to do townsfolk and nobility dress much nicer. Again, dark blacks, browns, and reds predominate. High collars, vests, and lace at the cuffs were the current fashion when high society collapsed with the Pestilence. Corsets are seen, but not for everyday wear. Haute Couture is a thing of the past, so all but the most well to do are wearing clothes long past the point where they would normally be retired and replaced. A certain amount of frayed edges and scruffiness has come to be accepted by all.

The martial class of knights, though small, had a particular style about them that they still retain. Purity seals denoting their devotion to faiths and churches were common, and while still seen they are being replaced by seals, wards, and talismans against the Pestilence and ill omens. Heraldry is typically displayed.

Konnigstrava allows for players to portray the characters who enjoy the simple comforts of rural and rustic living. Players can come from a lifestyle of rural or woodland homes with simple comfortable features, a warm pot of soup on the stove, and a simple garden. Players may achieve success by acquiring and sharing simple homey comforts and not seek riches or influence.

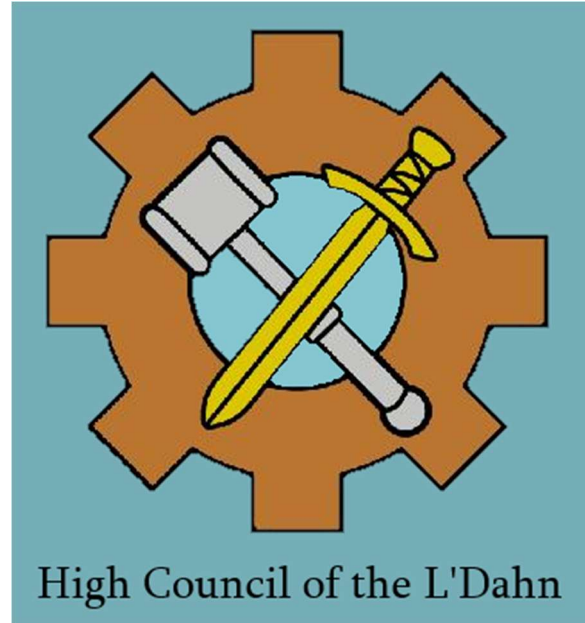
If someone wishes to portray a character from the nobility there are a number of opportunities to explore stories in crumbling castles, failing family lines, and doomed quests. Characters might seek to find ways to return their families to the glories of the past, or they might seek to find new ways to form a society and relationship between the landowning and peasant classes. A questing knight could be seeking most anything.

Do you wish to be a witch who brews potions in a cabin at the edge of town? A hedge wizard who experiments on Pestilence cures? A hunter or woodcutter who must travel in dark dangerous forests? A blue blooded noble who runs through castle halls at night with a candelabra? A refugee from a cult trying to escape a traumatic past? A questing knight trying to regain faded glory for your house, or who is on a noble but doomed quest? A Pestilence survivor who still bears the visible scars of the illness? All these archetypes fit in well in Konnigstrava.

L'Dahn Lination

The people of the L'Dahn Lination are known across the world as people of great patience, knowledge, and understanding. They can be found living and traveling through all of the known countries. From childhood they are brought up to believe in "service to others for the betterment of all." Because of this mantra and their wandering lifestyle, many L'Dahn see themselves as caretakers for the world.

The Journey of the Lines that each L'Dahn must complete to become a full member of their society is what helps them achieve that reputation. While many L'Dahn choose to travel from place to place their whole lives, there are some who choose to settle in either their home city of Dahnhelm or in the various places that resonate the most with them from their own Journey. The minimum amount of time each person spends in their set travel to become a full member of society is based on which group they choose to belong to: Fixers, Guardians or Advocates.



No one knows exactly where their home city lies as it is cloaked in mystery. Part of the reason for this secrecy is that there can only be a certain number of L'Dahn in their home city at any time. While no one knows exactly what will happen should too many L'Dahn be present in Dahnhelm, most believe it would mean the utter destruction of the city and choose not to make their permanent homes there and only visit for specific occasions.

Geography, History, and Climate

While the L'Dahn are an open and honest people, their home city's location in the world is unknown. The only way to get in and out of Dahnhelm is through the Lattice. There are whispers of special rituals known only to senior L'Dahn that would bring people to Dahnhelm. It is thought to be impossible for anyone to point out where the city is on the world map. The only clue to its location is that mountains can be seen in the distance from the top of the city's epicenter, Skytower Observatory.

The city itself is a large size, with buildings that are kept in good repair by the local Fixers. Notable structures within the city are the Salma Archives, the Skytower Observatory, the Lyceum Major, the Lyceum Minor and the Fanum Catacombs. The Lyceum Major is where the High Council of L'Dahn meet and make decisions; Lyceum Minor is where performances are done and art is displayed. The Fanum Catacombs, which stretch in many paths below the city with

multiple entries, are where many L'Dahn choose to be remembered by their loved ones and are tended to by Remembrancers when the families are away.

The Salma Archives is known for its eclectic collection. The only requirement for an item's entry into the Archives is that a L'Dahn found something they wanted to share - be it from their Journey or their everyday lives. It is a lot like their game Quadrum that is an amalgamation of different items from around the world.

There are farms outside of the city proper but still considered part of it, and just beyond the farms is a long stretching dense forest. The L'Dahn do not travel deep into the forest even when they are hunting and foraging there. If a L'Dahn travels too deep into the forest, they feel the urge to return. Most don't want to know what would happen if they go too deep into the darker parts of the forest.

History

The bards and storytellers of the L'Dahn share the origin story of their people starting with Archibald Dahniley, his partner Lestor Leshon, and their adopted daughter Dihnora L'Dahn. The three of them, and their journey across the world assisting people, were the basis for the groups of the L'Dahn. The journey they went on was the first Journey of the Lines. Those who joined them in their travels were the beginnings of the L'Dahn as a people.

At some point in every L'Dahn's life, they must take The Journey of the Lines. The start of every Journey begins at the center of Dahnhelm and is marked with a ceremony called the Linking to the Lines. The Journey of the Lines is a time when L'Dahn are not allowed to return back to the place they call home. Its purpose is to help them learn their chosen skill set in as many forms as possible but also to learn more about those in the world around them.

During The Journey, the new and learning L'Dahn are also not allowed to stay any place for longer than 6 months. This requirement is to ensure those Journeying learn and see as much as possible during their individual adventures. Permission must be granted by the High Council of the L'Dahn to stay somewhere longer than six months. Some L'Dahn choose to migrate all of their lives, staying only a few months to years in one place.

The L'Dahn Journey is seen as a rite of passage. In order to be a fully participating member of the Lination society, the Journey and the conclusion Ceremony of the Circle must be completed. Once finished, the member is considered to have Crossed the Lines. Some of their rights as members of the society include serving on the High Council and having their own dwelling in Dahnhelm. While there are rare instances of a L'Dahn choosing to not make The Journey, they typically do not remain with the L'Dahn and join other nations.

L'Dahn that are on their Journey are considered "Linked to the Lines"; marked by the emblems that they wear in the open to mark the type of L'Dahn group they belong to and to confirm what stage of their Journey they are on. Each L'Dahn bears a mark of their type somewhere on their person to signify who they are and what type of work they do. If they are on their Journey, the emblem is surrounded by one straight line for each year they have completed. Once their

minimum time is completed, they are no longer “Linked to the Lines.” Their crests are changed from straight, disconnected lines surrounding their emblem into one solid shape. That shape includes the same number of lines as the number of years it took for them to complete their Journey.

The L'Dahn generally divide themselves into three groups:

The Fixers are the tradespeople of the culture. The bakers, tinkerers, blacksmiths, healers, traders, merchants, etc. If something needs fixing or adjustment they are the ones to be called. If the Council needs some timber for a new roof on a building, or a building is broken and a stone mason is needed to repair it, or the stone mason drops a brick on his foot and needs a healer, a Fixer will be there. They have the mark of a silver cogwheel. Fixers must Journey for a minimum of 3 years. Because they tend to be in the center of the varying cultures of the world, they have the shortest Journey. When they have completed their Journey the silver cogwheel is outlined by a silver equilateral triangle.

The Guardians are the soldiers and sentinels of the culture. They are guards for various caravans, for the other L'Dahn, for the trade routes, for important meetings between nations where one nation may not trust another, and even the Lattice. They are highly skilled warriors known for their prowess in a variety of situations. Many Guardians know a myriad of fighting styles that vary from martial weapons to magic. They have a mark of a gold sword. Guardians Journey for four years. While they are more involved with basic needs of a community, long parts of their Journey may be disconnected from communities. When they have completed their Journey the gold sword is outlined by a gold square.

The Advocates are the politicians, priests, and ambassadors of the culture. They are the most visible to the other nations as these are the ones who tend to broker trade agreements, peace treaties, land disputes, etc. They have the mark of a copper gavel. Advocates, because of their need for understanding all people and spending less time with the day to day running of a place, must Journey for five years. When they complete it, their gavel is outlined by copper pentagon.

Politics, Government, and Economy

“Service to others for the betterment of all” is one of the core structures of L'Dahn society. Because of this philosophy, based on the teachings and life of Archibald Dahniley, people of the Lination are generally respected and welcomed wherever they travel. Be it in trade, land disputes or political negotiations, the L'Dahn are often seen as the people who are both a part of all nations and separate and might be called on for assistance in a dispute.

The L'Dahn are ruled/supervised by the High Council of Lination that does everything from grant permissions for a longer stay in one location during a Journey to passing judgment on the rare L'Dahn who breaks the laws. The Council meets in the Lyceum Major regularly. They are also regarded as an impartial entity throughout the world and many rulers will seek their counsel when troubled.

Every L'Dahn must go to Dahnhelm, the sanctuary city, to be Linked to the Lines when they begin their Journey and must return to participate in the completion ritual, the Ceremony of the Circle. The rituals to start and end the Journey are closely guarded secrets of the L'Dahn and it is something they take great pride in, though rumor has it some special outsiders have been allowed to view the ceremonies given unique circumstances. When a L'Dahn completes their required Journey time it is a cause of great celebration.

The High Council is made up of 15 members. Nine are Elders, those who have passed the trials of Wisdom, Community, and Balance. The other six are those who have completed their Journeys within the last 3 years, known as Primes. Of the Nine Elders, three are Fixers, three are Guardians, and three are Advocates. Of the Primes, there are two each from the three various groups. Terms for Council members are a minimum of two years with no more than five consecutive years. In order for most judgments to be passed by the Council, a two-thirds majority must prevail.

Some of the current standing Elder members of the Council include Landry Hale (an Elder Advocate), Sol Elfrish (an Elder Guardian), and Arden Lockland (an Elder Fixer). A few of the Primes include Sybil Driffen (year three Prime Advocate), Cedar Wuveth (year one Prime Fixer), and Lianie Oshuni (year two Prime Guardian). Lianie Oshuni took up the Prime Guardian slot left vacant after the death of Clay Raynar. While some who serve on the Council only do the shortest time possible, others vary time served including choosing to serve the full five years. Hollis Lowtrow, who served as a Prime Fixer on the High Council for three years, stepped down after the completion of their three years instead of taking the Trials and decided to leave Dahnhelm and go to T'barris.

The L'Dahn get a lot of their goods through trade from members on their Journeys. The visitors who come to Dahnhelm usually come to visit the galleries and concert halls in the Lyceum Minor or do research in the Salma Archives. Those who come are welcomed with open arms, and many provide monetary donations or tangible gifts.

Everyday Life

When a L'Dahn moves to a new place, they browse through the town's posting boards and listen to word of mouth to find where they might be of use or where they can learn more of their chosen trade. Most tend to do small jobs that the locals are either unable or unwilling to do. They find lodgings in the town and live the same lives as those around them; though they try to keep an open table for anyone who is in need.

Many L'Dahn will keep journals of their daily experiences so they can remember what they see, but not all of them are bookish in that sense.

Current Events

The Council has recognized the turmoil in Aeled in regards to the Vargoth, especially with them declaring themselves as a sovereign nation. At this time, the stance of the Council is that the

L'Dahn as a nation will remain neutral. As always, the Council will never dictate the specific actions of the people of the Lination.

Something strange has been going on within the home city. There have been whispers and echos in the catacombs. Strange beings with glowing eyes on their hands have been said to have been spotted within the depths.

Many of those who had made homes in Dahnheim have been leaving unexpectedly to Journey again. Most with little notice to their loved ones.

There have been expeditions exploring the still broken parts of the Lattice to learn more about its constructions, repair, and maintenance.

Notes for Players

All L'Dahn, because they do not hold power in any nation are often but not always, the ones that other people turn to when easy conclusions are not found. While the L'Dahn have no power to make any final resolutions, they are honored for their impartiality and neutrality. This means they will often be asked to step in as mediators to make sure all sides in a conflict are heard. The request for assistance from a L'Dahn can be from two farmers arguing over livestock or two nations arguing over trade routes. The request can always be declined. Declining to be a mediator is seen as a mark of self-awareness and is respected. Once the mediation is completed it is up to the arguing parties to decide if they are amenable to the suggestions provided.

Anyone from anywhere in the world is welcome to join the L'Dahn, but those not born into the culture are expected to take a much longer Journey of the Lines to become a full member.

Cultural Plot and Themes

A common phrase of exasperation or swearing that many L'Dahn use is “by the lines.” Also used frequently is the phrase “square up” for needing to watch your back or guard something. “Cogs be with us” when there are a lot of things that need to be fixed in a situation is also used.

It is also thought that the LoreKeeper, one of the gargoyle guardians created by Fate long ago, has a special bond with the Salma Archives because of how things are added to it. All of the gargoyles’ tenets are followed as a way of life for the L'Dahn.

Notable L'Dahn:

- Archibald Dahniley: the proposed founder of the L'Dahn way of life. He traveled for most of his long life after his home was destroyed in a great war. While he started to travel in order to find a new home, he was never able to find a place where he could settle.
- Lester Leshon: Partner and protector of Archibald, proposed co-founder of the L'Dahn way of life. Helped establish Dahnheim after Archibald passed.
- Dihnora L'Dahn: Adopted daughter of Archibald and Lester, made a point of expanding the kindness and fairness of the L'Dahn.

- Honor Dante: Honor is a Fixer who is known for spending a lot of time after the completion of the Journey of the Lines in Melluria. Using expertise gained while Journeying, Honor was able to refine some of Melluria's mining practices. The efficiency of large machinery was so well improved by Honor's engineering innovations that an invitation to join the Machinist's Guild was issued, something rare for those not part of Mellurian Society.
- Clay Raynar, who nearly finished his three years as a Prime Guardian, was killed in the line of duty when attending a council in Fortune's Bend. He had completed both the Trials of Wisdom and Community and was expected to face and complete the Trial of Balance. This would have allowed Clay to continue as an Elder of the Council for 2 more years. Had he been able to complete the Trials he would have been the first Prime in 25 years to choose to serve the full five years and the first Prime Guardian to choose to do so in more than three times that length of time. His aunt, Viatrix, was made an ambassador between Fortune's Bend and the L'Dahn High Council after his death as she has served many times on the High Council and is a respected Fixer.
- Kit Jantith: Known throughout the Myosi Islands as fair but shrewd, Kit became renowned at many Myosi trade negotiations for bringing balance and liked compromises as a L'Dahn Advocate. Kit is also well known for embracing the Myosi celebrations and over indulging in the parties after the negotiations were settled.
- Devan Khoarst: Devan is a Guardian of old who was known to establish a combined form school of fighting for young L'Dahn and anyone who wished to join. Some even say that all L'Dahn learn the basics of Devan's forms as part of their cultural heritage.

Because of the varying nature of the L'Dahn as a culture, a PC can expect anything from a field fight to a negotiation, or a research task to a mystery for adventures that they might be called to assist on. Also, these adventures can take place anywhere in the world. If you want a primarily nomadic culture, the L'Dahn are an option. Some L'Dahn choose to not move around as much once their Journey is completed, but will also move as they desire.

Themes for stories dealing with the L'Dahn can include but are not limited to conflict negotiation, cracks in a tight knit society, mysteries and fighting for balance in an unbalanced world. Some scenarios that players could see as a L'Dahn could vary from protecting trade caravans, to helping settle disputes, to research in the Salma Archives or even exploring the catacombs.

Costume and RP Themes

For many L'Dahn the more utilitarian the better for their clothing, however, even they have their preferences on some styles. Because of their Journey of the Lines, lines and geometric shapes hold a strong presence in their culture so they show up a lot on their clothing. Many fabrics, while durable, will have geometric patterns in the weaves or embroidery. Stripes of varying widths are also a common sight. Their weapons, shields, bags, and tools are also often marked with the symbol of their group. (Fixers with the triangle and cogwheel, Guardians with the square and sword, Advocates with the pentagon and gavel) Coloring varies by personal taste

but many who are still on their Journey or who Journey throughout their lives tend to choose more neutral colors for simple ease of acquisition.

Melluria

"The mines give to me so I give back to them; no one stands alone."

This is the motto that every citizen of Melluria is taught from a young age and takes to heart when they take their monthly shift in the mines. The work may get hard sometimes, but they're never without help and resources to get the job done and to see that what they do benefits everyone at the end of the day. They take great pleasure as they see the sparks fly and hear the rumble of machines large and small. Melluria is one of the main suppliers of ore, metals, and other materials in Aeled, and Mellurians are renowned for the high quality of the materials they produce and how they shape it to fill the needs of their culture and the world.



Geography, History, and Climate

Geography

Melluria has many mountains in the southern area of the country where much of the ore they mine can be found. Further north is dotted with a few cities where most of the population lives, with wide roads connecting each. In the far southwest corner of the country are the ruins of the original capital, Silviar, which was abandoned after The Great Tragedy destroyed most of the city. A day's walk north is the busy port town of Hilltague, where most of the materials and goods that are carried by boat via the inland sea are processed and sent to their destination. The headquarters for the Traders Guild may be found here.

The southern central area of the country contains Mount Carnel, an active volcano which has had a few intense eruptions in the past. Much of the area near the volcano is still hostile to plant life due to the heat. However, rich mineral deposits have also been found there so some are willing to risk the heat to explore and mine.

Further past the cities are the farms that grow most of the food. They've become very efficient when using the latest tools and other machines that come out of the cities to plant and harvest. The town of Lake Cavan in the north central region is a popular destination for recreation, especially to get away from the summer heat in the south. Melluria was heavily forested in the past but much of it has been cleared in the south and central regions to be put to use in building farms and expanding the cities to the south.

To the southeast of Lake Cavan near is the current capital, Saphiren City. This is home to the Mellurian Council and headquarters for the Miners, Machinists, Farmers, and Crafters guilds. It

is also where the nearest lattice node may be found. Many of the factories in Melluria are nearby, working night and day to produce the goods that make Melluria famous.

Climate

In the far north is the port town of Basanite, where goods that travel via the oceans around the world are traded, other smaller towns dot the landscape.

The climate is generally cool at higher elevations with occasional storms blowing in from the western seas. Summers in the south tend to be hot and vary with the amount of rain, some swear it becomes even hotter when all of the ore processing machines are running full-tilt in the cities. The northern region has long winters but very mild summers in comparison.

The far southeast of Melluria near Kindaria contains a very seismically active area. The frequent earthquakes mean that the landscape continually shifts and it's nearly impossible to live or work there without a high risk of injury or even death. It is the one area that doesn't fall under Mellurian laws and regulations and is referred to as the Mines of the Lost. Very few voluntarily venture into that area.

The climate is generally cool at higher elevations with occasional storms blowing in from the western seas. Summers in the south tend to be hot and vary with the amount of rain, some swear it becomes even hotter when all of the ore processing machines are running full-tilt in the cities. The northern region has long winters but very mild summers in comparison. Occasionally the towns in the far north become difficult to access due to snow and ice and trade may be limited.

History

Melluria had once been the kingdom of Ceptaria with a royal family and a ruling class who owned the ancient mines. They developed many of the early metallurgical processes and machine designs. Most of the lower classes were made to work in the mines, which was a hard and dangerous job. The Great Earthquake that struck Ceptaria caused not only a large-scale collapse of Silviar, but many of the mines collapsed as well, trapping and killing thousands. The people were stunned as they had been told this would never happen, that their work and their city was safe and would last under the leadership of the king and the ruling class. The anger and blame was swift.

When the king and the mine owners tried to make the people go back to work, the people fought back, leading to riots and what nearly turned into a full-blown civil war. These events led to the capture and execution of much of the ruling class. It was revealed that many had simply ignored safe mining protocols in order to chase those veins of ore. Most of them hadn't even touched a mining pick or a cart for years, if at all. Others refused to share their knowledge or pushed out folks that were seen as competition. Those who weren't executed were forced to hand over their assets and their knowledge. Eventually the king was overthrown as well, considered to be the final source of all of the troubles.

With an eye towards improving their way of life and witnessing what they had done when they banded together, the people started to form initial groups to put together and reinvent their

society. This became a long process with a few false starts as some initial governance structures were tried but either were found not to fit with the ideals of the people or started sliding back into the Ceptarian ways.

Eventually, a group led by Isidora Delacroix (Sometimes referred to as Isidora the Stone) proposed a simplified system of a ruling council that is made up of representatives of guilds of workers with similar skills. With her charming and forceful personality she started her journey at what are now known as the Delacroix Cliffs and embarked on bringing this new system to the villages. Her work was a success as the newly formed guilds of miners, metalworkers, builders, and machinists were in favor of trying this out and it became a precursor to the modern Mellurian Council.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Government

Melluria is collectively led by a leadership council of the Miners, Machinists, Metallurgists, Metalworkers, Merchants, Builders, and Farmers guilds known as the Mellurian Council. Each guild elects two members from within their leadership council to represent the guild at the Mellurian Council for a one year term. The council meets twice a year to decide policies for the collective including some economic policies, safety regulation updates, and next directions on what to seek or produce. While the council will have the initial say in setting policy, Mellurians may petition to send the council decision to a national referendum to be voted to uphold or reject it.

Each guild has the authority to decide the structure of their leadership but they are bound by two requirements from the Mellurian Council:

Their leaders must be members in good standing of the guild they lead.

There are reasonable term limits in place to prevent leadership from growing stale.

At the cultural level each guild will discuss and make decisions on membership changes, setting guild related policies, hear grievances or other petitions, and appoint representatives to local areas and for visits outside of Melluria. Any policy changes that are made at the leadership level of the guild are put to a full vote of the guild members. Membership decisions are generally left as a board decision but members can petition for a reconsideration. In most local areas there is a council of representatives from each guild that handles the day to day decisions for the area each of them represents.

The main laws and regulations of Melluria are codified in the Mellurian Common Code, which emphasizes safety and the rights of the workers. Guilds may add additional regulations as needed for their work, which is subject to review by the Mellurian Council. Any violations may be handed at the local or guild level, but more serious violations or other crimes may be referred to a tribunal of 2+ judges who are picked from the leadership of other guilds. They're charged with listening to witness statements for both sides and rendering a verdict and consequences.

These consequences may range from a reprimand to being sent to The Mines of the Lost for a period of time. Judgements may be appealed to the council, but they are rarely modified.

Politics

The guilds within Melluria do actively recruit for their ranks and there are generally friendly rivalries between each one. However, the values of everyone being stronger through working together, no single person or guild can survive standing alone, and not forgetting where they came from tend to keep relations cordial among leadership. As Melluria supplies much of the metal and machines that the world uses they have an interest in keeping active diplomatic relations with their neighbors. Occasionally there have been disputes with Kindaria over mining rights where the two cultures share a border but the disputes are typically hammered out with both sides reaching a satisfactory conclusion.

Economy

Melluria primarily relies on the trade of their ore, crafts, and machinery with other cultures to support their economy. With their current reputation they do tend to sell well. All citizens receive a basic income to cover their living expenses. Additional income may be earned depending on the rates that are set by the guild. A progressive tax on income (past basic income) and value-added taxes on goods sold are what fund the social and safety programs provided by the Mellurian Council. If there should be any excess funds half is placed in a special emergency fund while the rest is redistributed back to the citizens.

All of the major businesses are owned and operated by the guilds; other businesses operating in Melluria that do not fit with a particular guild may form a partnership with an existing guild to access benefits.

Everyday Life

Some of the larger Mellurian cities and the mines seemingly never sleep as they are constantly buzzing with activity. Adults typically work an assigned schedule at their job but also are required to work one shift a week at the mines. This is a requirement for all citizens of Melluria with a few exceptions due to injury or disability. Besides this, occasional training is given to refresh current protocols or processes for production and safety, or to learn new ones. Morale is generally high as there have been no severe safety incidents in recent years.

Children spend time with their parents or at central daycare centers or school. As they grow older and begin to show a preference or aptitude for a particular set of skills, they will start an apprenticeship with the appropriate guild. A large part of their focus is on doing their tasks at the highest possible efficiency, which carries over into their careers. They also learn that they can't do it alone, efficiency means nothing if the results harm their colleagues.

Outside of work many like to gather at the tavern for a drink or gaming. Free time is also spent getting out to the land to camp or fish. Some may also spend time crafting personal objects for themselves or to sell to others. Mellurians also love to play games or sports in their off-time.

Two major events occur yearly in Melluria. One is three days of remembrance for those who perished in The Great Tragedy. No mining or other work takes place and the citizens may make offerings to shrines of remembrance asking that they never have such a tragedy occur again. The other is a celebration of the founding of Melluria, when the people came together to build a better way of life for themselves under the initial leadership of Isidora the Stone and the first Mellurian Council. Work is paused and feasting and revelry take place, including sporting and game competitions between folks. The crafting shows that take place during this time are very popular as folks love to show off what they have been able to shape with metal, stone, clay, or other materials on hand. There are other minor festivals that take place at various times.

Current Events

Recently a new ore was discovered at the Valcroft Grotto Mines. Now known as Valcroftium, it has exhibited some strange qualities, including reacting to certain elements or creatures by glowing, emitting a sound or vibrating. It also cannot be mined or processed by conventional means or it seems to become inert. It is possible to “tune” the ore to react to a given element if it is within a given space. Mellurian Labs continues to research the ore, hoping to further unlock its abilities and properties. A large chunk of it is considered to be “on loan” to the town of Fortune’s Bend.

Occasionally there are folks who try to exploit the abilities of other guild members or who attempt to ignore certain regulations regarding safety and worker morale. There have been calls to clamp down harder on those who would exploit fellow Mellurians. However, that has been resisted as some question the need for more regulations.

There has been a growing concern about impacts to the land and water with the heavy industry in the cities and the scale of mining that is done. Some are trying to see if they can reduce the waste produced or turn it into something more functional but they have had limited success.

Some groups are interested in excavating the ruins of Silviar. They hypothesize there may be additional historical artifacts or information on ancient processes that were lost in the Great Tragedy but would be useful to recover. However, some feel that since so many were killed there that the site should be left undisturbed and to start digging it up is the equivalent of grave robbing and could stir up trouble. Folks who have been charged with guarding the site have reported occasionally hearing strange noises.

Infusing metal with magic has been a difficult process that only a few have been able to master without risking injury or death. The Kodel College of Alloys handles most of the education and research into this process with the goal of making it faster, safer, and more widely available. However there’s been rumors of some outside of the college doing experiments with infusions that would be considered highly unethical.

Notable Mellurians

Isidora Delacroix, AKA “Isidora the Stone” - Considered to be the first leader of the Mellurian Leadership Council, she led the group that developed the initial structure of what has become

the modern collective of guilds and the leadership council. Afterward her work in visiting the villages, recruiting people to the given cause, and laying the foundations of the future collective of guilds working together to improve the lives of everyone is considered by many to be how Melluria evolved into where it is today. Additionally she recruited and helped form the local builders guilds.

Alaric Borges, AKA “Alaric the Hammer” - He was one of the first to be recruited to assist Isidora in her work, helping to form and recruit for the local metalworkers guilds. His specialty was in hammering out the thin but strong layers of steel that would become a trademark of early Mellurian swords.

Thalia Tauser, AKA “Thalia the Prospector” - She assisted Isidora by recruiting for the miners guilds. In her work it was said she could smell the ore because she seemed to have an uncanny ability to find it even deep underground. She also helped to develop some of the initial transport systems of ore from the mines to the processors.

Derrick Addington AKA “Derrick the Wrench” - He recruited for the first machinist guild, not only finding those who operated and maintained industrial machines, but also those who were working to invent newer and better ones. When he was around, the machines never seemed to fail. He was always drawing up ideas while training others in working on the ore processing machines that seemed to be his favorites.

Agoris Kodel - They were the first to discover that some materials could be infused with magic. Their first successful experiment was a pendant that glowed with a light that never seemed to fade. A few later infusion experiments failed in producing magic items but instead produced alloys that had not previously been seen in nature. This led to breakthroughs in Mellurian technology. Some of their techniques are still in use today.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot and Themes

Players involved with Mellurian plot will find themselves exploring mines to collect materials as a part of their obligation to give back to the mines. They may encounter creatures that prefer not to be disturbed and would need to be removed in order to continue. Occasionally they may be called on by their guild to research new skills or methods for crafting, investigate code violations, represent the guild in a friendly skills competition, or to negotiate/mediate any contracts or disputes within or between the guilds. Opportunities to lend expertise in crafting, refinement of materials, and to move up in rank in their chosen guild will also be available.

Costume and RP Themes

Utilitarian clothes that aren't too loose to protect from machinery or mining hazards. Sturdy boots and gloves are standard. Many opt to have goggles, a heavy leather apron or a tool belt. Mellurians also love to show their best work, whether it's a tool (Hammer, pliers) or item

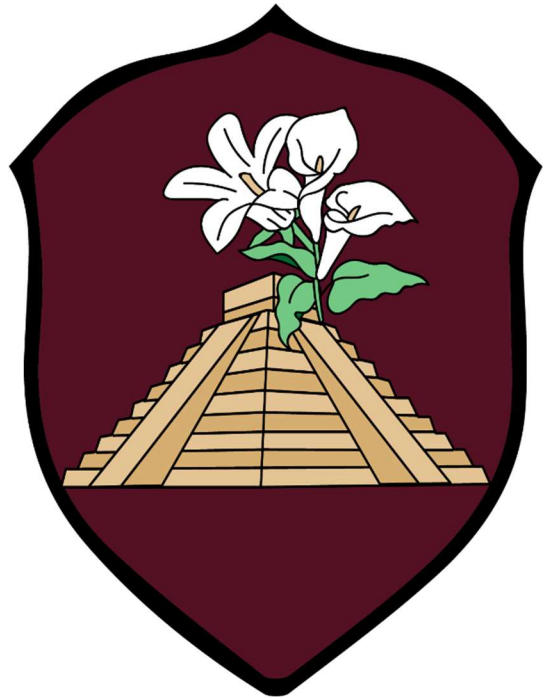
(necklace, armor, sword, etc.) that their ancestors have made or they have made themselves. A patch signifying the guild that the player is a member of is also worn on the upper chest. Players take pride in their work and actions meaning something and benefiting the people around them, rather than working just to work. Collaboration with fellow players will be highly encouraged.

Merrigor

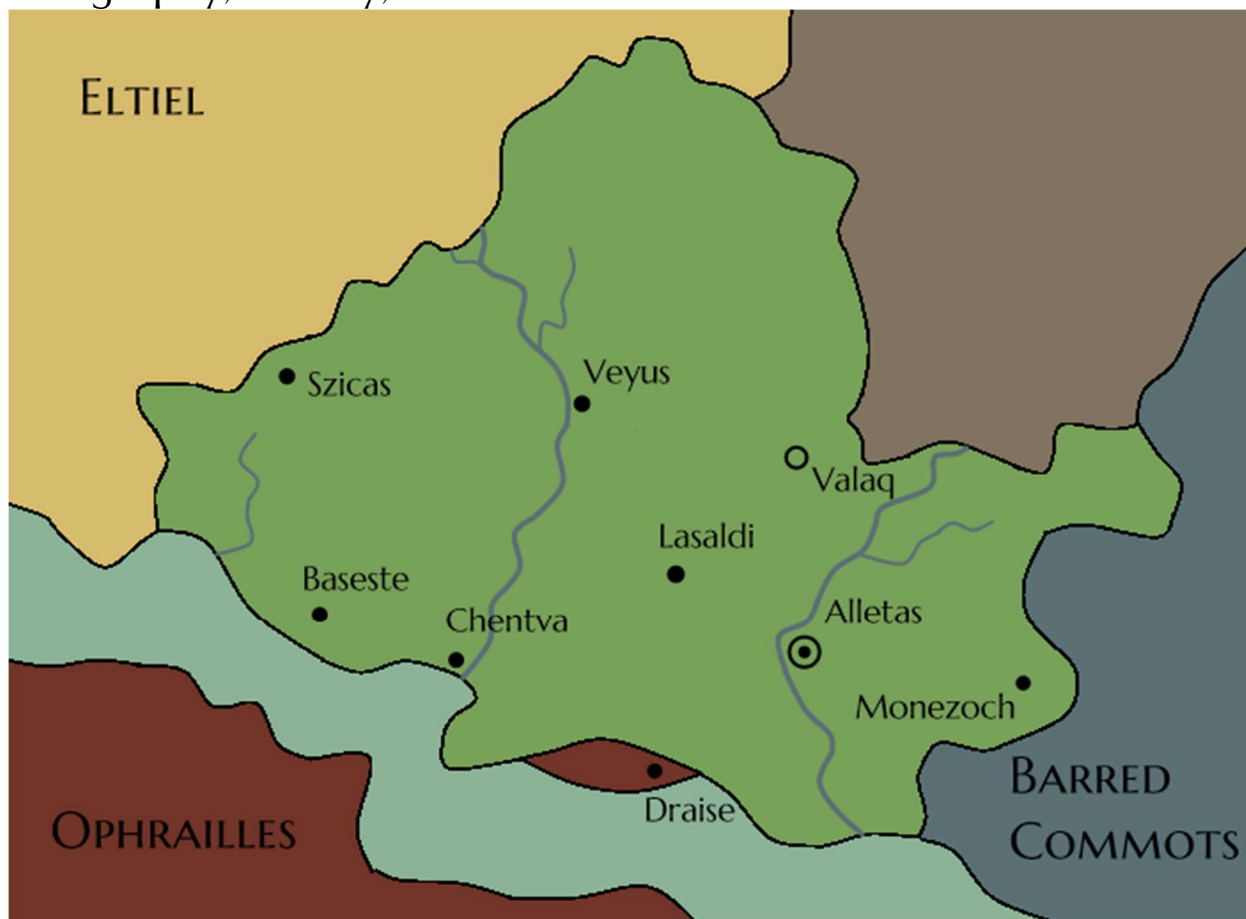
That one lives and then dies is inevitable; that one lives well and continues serving Merrigor even through death is to be celebrated.

Merrigor is a land of aristocrats and master artisans. Though the forests and fields are worked, they are sparsely inhabited, at least by the living. The vast majority of the farmers, woodsmen, guards patrolling the roads, indeed most of the labor force, are revenants. Luxuries abound in Merrigor; fine artisanal goods are readily available and the cities are filled with ornate architecture. The people live lives of comfort with their needs attended by the dead. Most of those who do any kind of work are master craftsmen and artists.

This lifestyle works because Merrigor accepts death as an inevitable part of life and embraces their final duty to the nation. The elderly, the ill and the infirm make their way to the Necropolis, the city built around an ancient keep discovered deep in the forest. There they participate in a mysterious ritual that converts them into a revenant.



Geography, History, and Climate



Merrigor is a land of forests. The southern coastal region tends towards marsh and bayou, the northern and western regions contain foothills of the massive mountains of Eltiel, but nearly all of the region is dense with vegetation. Most of Merrigor is dominated by the Ilfraic trees. The tall, straight trees have dark bark and dense foliage that is deep green in the spring and summer and blood red in the autumn. The Ilfraic woods are beautiful, but Merrigoreans know to fear them. They release pollen that, when inhaled, causes confusion, disorientation and eventually death. Though most active at night and in the spring months, they are never truly safe.

The great cities of Merrigor are surrounded by extensive farmland and pastureland. The residents forget that that land was cleared over centuries and without tireless work, the dangerous forests would quickly reclaim it. Fortunately, tireless work is something Merrigor has in plentiful supply.

The climate of Merrigor is humid and widely varying by the seasons. Oppressively hot in the summer and snowy in the winter. On the other hand, the misty, brilliantly colored Merrigorean autumns are legendary. Despite all their sophistication and finery, the typical Merrigorean follows the seasons much as their Marag ancestors did. In the winter and spring they tend to congregate in the cities. Trade, social gatherings and politics proceed at a feverish pace, taking

advantage of the proximity of homes and businesses and revenant-cleared streets. As the heat of summer rises, and the Ilfraic pollen dies down, some stay in the cities, but more retreat to villages, country estates and wilderness lodges. Life slows down as people focus on more personal pursuits and outdoor activities. Of course, the revenants care nothing for the seasons. They - and the brave souls that directly supervise them - work through rain, snow and scorching heat to bring prosperity to Merrigor.

After the collapse of the Lattice, people inevitably traveled seeking out safer homes and greener pastures. For the Marags, forest dwelling clans from the southern part of the continent, this meant journeying deeper into the forests. The Ilfraic trees were less common in those days and the Marags quickly learned to avoid the groves of tall, dark trees. Beneath the shadows of the lesser trees they founded various hamlets and villages. But life was not easy in a land of poison trees and fierce seasons. Seeking better terrain, they continued exploring the forest, until they came upon something surprising: a massive structure, ancient even in those early days. Perched on a bluff overlooking a river, it resembled a fortress, though it protected nothing of note. Others thought it looked more like a cathedral though it was dedicated to no Genesori, cause or order that anyone could recognize. The brave souls who explored this Necropolis discovered something that changed Marag society forever, the secrets of the Rites of Unbinding. To protect and explore the potential of their discovery, these explorers built the Necropolis around this keep. The residents of this city were the first people to call their home Merrigor.

The Seven Cities

Merrigorean economic, political and social life is dominated by the seven cities, by far the land's largest population centers.

Alletas is the oldest city in Merrigor, built across the Laghemi river from the ancient keep. Formally, the city is called "Alletas" and the keep is simply "the keep" but the entire region is commonly referred to as "the Necropolis." It's the last stop on a Merrigorean's journey.

Szicas is located far to the west, in the shadows of Eltiel. Outsiders often consider it a dark and forbidding place since night comes early beneath the mountains, but it's also home to caches of gemstones and extensive mines.

Chentva is currently the most populous city in Merrigor. It's located on the southern coast and has both a seaport and a large threshold, making it a travel hub.

Lasaldi is located in central Merrigor and perched in a small clearing in the deepest woods. The lodges in the surrounding regions are favorites of hunters and lovers of the outdoors. Lasaldi is smaller than most other cities and only recently elevated to the status of 7th city. It is a replacement for Valaq, which was lost to the Ilfraic trees.

Veyus is the hub of lumber and logging in Merrigor though such efforts can be found nearly everywhere. Timber and other goods collected from the forests can be easily floated downriver to Chentva.

Monezoch is located in far eastern Merrigor. It has a sizable population of living Merrigoreans, but it is best known as the staging ground for the Revenant Legion and training facility for their officers. Squads of guards can be found patrolling any city or road in the land, but except in times of crisis, the bulk of the Legion will be found in Monezoch.

Baseste is home to the famed Sanar academy, one of the great institutions of learning. While studies take place in many subjects, its historians and collection of works from before the lattice-breaking are without peer.

Draise is not considered one of the seven cities, even though it is their equal in size, because it is not even a Merrigorean city. Over a hundred years ago, a faction in Ophrailles decided they wanted some territory on the mainland, for easier access to roads, lattice nodes and the like. Directly across the straits from them was some empty marshland that was formally Merrigorean, but largely uninhabited, so the Ophraillians decided to settle it. Even though this did no real harm, Merrigor dispatched the Revenant Legion to address the insult to Merrigorean sovereignty. This almost immediately produced a stalemate, with the revenants unable to besiege the fortified port and the Ophraillians unable to advance through the horde of the dead. Before long both sides signed a treaty formalizing the situation. Merrigor conceded the one walled port city on the mainland to Ophrailles and Ophrailles agreed not to try to expand any further into the mainland. A few rural Merrigoreans in the Draise region still hold a grudge for the invasion, but most of Merrigor has long since moved on to more pressing issues.

Politics, Government, and Economy

The government of Merrigor is ultimately democratic, but in a notably complex way. Each of the seven major cities elects ten councilors to represent them in the outer council. One of the councilors from each city is selected by lots to have a seat on the inner council as well. The inner council is the face of the government. They sign treaties, appoint magistrates, and meet with visiting dignitaries. It is the duty of the outer council to draft various decrees and call an assembly. Any living adult in Merrigor has the right to attend an assembly, which discusses and votes on a decree. Magistrates are selected from a pool of volunteers by the inner council and set to travel about Merrigor resolving disputes and interpreting assembly decrees. Magistrates typically serve for life but can be removed by decree of the assembly. Frequent elections and term limits ensure that no one person wields too much power in the councils, but the assemblies are open to all, and skilled negotiators or orators can become fixtures.

Another powerful group in Merrigor is the Keepers of the Curtain. This order is the caretakers of the Necropolis and the Rites of Unbinding. They welcome those who have reached the ends of their lives and help them perform the Rites. Most Merrigoreans come to the Necropolis surrounded by friends and loved ones with an atmosphere that is surprisingly cheerful to outsiders. That one lives and then dies is inevitable; that one lives well and continues serving Merrigor even through death is to be celebrated.

Whether one arrives amidst celebration or limps in alone, the supplicant is welcomed with open arms by the Keepers. The supplicant is brought into the heart of the Necropolis by Keepers;

though their loved ones are not permitted inside, no one is expected to face the transition alone. The Rites are considered a solemn duty and widely regarded as the right and responsible thing to do, but ultimately the Keepers question supplicants to ensure that everyone makes their own choice. Then the Keepers introduce the supplicant to the Rites of Unbinding, which when performed, sever them into their component parts. Their Purpose returns to the Tallow Man's pot, but their body rises again as a revenant. Cured of whatever infirmities plagued them in life, not needing food, or water, or sleep and durable beyond normal human capabilities, the revenants are impressive workers. But no spirit or will or sense of self remains. They can perceive their surroundings and follow simple orders, but they do so without initiative or creativity. They unfailingly obey the Keepers of the Curtain and may be instructed to obey others.

The Keepers are also responsible for placing revenants where they are needed. They strive to honor the wishes of the departed but their first goal is the good of Merrigor. Most are assigned to forests. Keeping the woods, and the dreaded Ilfraic trees, clear of the cities is the top priority. And logging is hazardous work; though the revenants are unaffected by the pollen and unconcerned about small injuries, they can be destroyed by a large enough mishap. And losses need to be replaced quickly, lest the trees gain ground. Other revenants are sent to fields or mines as workers or to maintain cities and roads, or to join the Legions. A handful are tasked as servants of a particular family or household as thanks for services rendered to the nation.

Though the revenants represent a huge military and economic power, the Keepers generally consider themselves above the factions and politicking of the council and the assembly. However the Keepers are quite fanatical about a few specific points and will go to great lengths for three things: To keep secret the internal workings of the Keepers and the Rites, to ensure that those who command revenants use them for the good of Merrigor, and to ensure that no one is ever coerced or compelled into completing the Rites.

With no shortage of arable land or manual labor, no one in Merrigor wants for the basics. A roof overhead, food to eat and clothes on one's back are ubiquitous. But hardly anyone in Merrigor is content with the basics. Ornate gothic architecture, elegant fashion, original art and masterwork goods of all kinds are the norm. Merrigoreans' freedom from the basic trials of life gives them time to develop expertise, focusing on becoming the best painter, musician, tailor, jeweler, scholar, or orator that they can be.

Paradoxically, being a nation of highly specialized experts makes Merrigor generalists when it comes to trade. Few people there can compete with the smiths of Melluria or the alchemists of T'barris, or the tinkers of Eltiel. But in any field you choose, there ARE a few people who can compete with those great nations, and they'll happily create the perfect bespoke piece just for you, for the right price.

The most notable bulk export of Merrigor is timber. The efforts of the revenants to keep the forests at bay produces large amounts of wood as a byproduct. And the tall straight Ilfraic trees, terrifying when they are alive, are, once felled, highly prized by the shipbuilders of the world.

They also export gemstones. Though Merrigor is poor in metal resources, the region around Szicas is known for its emerald and ruby mines.

While Merrigor lacks the military tradition of some of its neighbors, it does have a quite formidable fighting force in the Revenant Legion. The revenants are not normally aggressive or violent, but when ordered into action by their living officers, they are a force terrifying to behold - one that doesn't know fear, pain, hunger, or remorse.

Everyday Life

Merrigorean cities are filled with small shrines and many people even have them in their homes. Some of them are dedicated to various Genesori, who are held in high regard in Merrigor, but more are dedicated to ancestors, or to local heroes. Though they aren't exactly worshiped, the dead are honored in Merrigor. Everyone knows that their cities, traditions and way of life were created by founders who are no longer living. And that the final sacrifices of their predecessors provided the labor force that built Merrigor. Folk belief in Merrigor claims that spirits of the dead return from time to time to watch over their various descendants and proteges and many superstitions and traditions surround making these spirits feel welcome. When families or friends gather for meals, an extra place is typically set for any visiting spirits. Many Merrigorean homes have gardens or planters by their front doors. Lilies are said to welcome spirits of friends and family, while Chrysanthemums ward off spirits of enemies and rivals. Many citizens know their lineages in great detail, and though Merrigor has no hereditary nobility, being able to trace one's ancestry back to a city founder, local hero or other individual of note is a point of pride.

Merrigorean values are heavily based on the notion of cycles. Merrigoreans know that while the world is constantly changing, things ultimately stay the same. Winter follows summer, death follows life, falls come after great successes. But summer comes again, scions pick up where their ancestors left off, and the disappointed rebuild their endeavors. A common platitude is "the wheel turns" which can variously be commiseration for a disappointment, a warning against overconfidence, grim fatalism or hopeful optimism depending on the context.

Many Merrigoreans are content to simply enjoy the luxury that their world allows. Others throw themselves into making things for its own merit. But for the idle aristocracy of Merrigor, by far the most popular pastime is the Great Game.

Not only in Merrigor, but throughout the world, stories tell of a place known as the Bridge. The Bridge is a part of the Void where living beings can walk in relative safety and the living and the dead can coexist. Rarely, the Bridge intersects with the living world, allowing those with no ability to walk between worlds to converse with the dead. Usually these intersections are rare, fleeting, and difficult to predict, but not so in Merrigor. The Bridge appears in the lands surrounding the Necropolis every three years on the longest night of the year, like clockwork. No one knows if the Necropolis was built where this connection to the Void occurs, or whether concentrating all the land's death in one place somehow draws the Bridge. Nor does anyone know why it appears not every year, but every three. And most Merrigoreans don't care.

The opportunity to talk to the dead is a valuable chance to meet heroes and learn of the past for anyone, but for the ancestor-obsessed Merrigoreans, it's priceless. By law, the honor of presiding over the Bridging, and the first chance to speak to the dead, is awarded to the group who has made "the most contribution to Merrigorean society and culture." By tradition this is interpreted as advancing arts, culture and knowledge rather than political, military or economic gain. And so Merrigoreans form groups - families, guilds, civic organizations, social clubs, wherever they can find skilled and like-minded collaborators - and vie in the Great Game. Those with a talent for arts, crafts, architecture or scholarship work furiously to create masterworks that would bring prestige to their faction. Those without the skill to contribute directly position themselves as patrons. Homes are adorned with new paintings and sculptures. Concerts are held. Events are attended in the heights of fashion. Players of the Great Game place nearly as much pride in recognizing and supporting talent as actually having it.

Of course, a concert with broken instruments brings no pride, nor does a party infested with vermin, so sabotage of opposing factions can be appealing. If any faction crosses the line into endangering public safety, letting the Ilfraic trees spread or weakening Merrigor's military or economic situation, the councils, and if necessary, the Legions, put a stop to it quite emphatically. Even without the practical consequences, "taking things too far" is seen as quite tacky. Even for lesser transgressions, "cheating" invites retaliation in kind, so until the final weeks of the years-long Game, players keep any transgressions subtle and secret.

In the last few cycles of the Game there is a new phenomenon. Several different persuasions of players have arisen. These groups don't align themselves as factions in the Great Game. In fact often the fiercest competition is between people of the same persuasion. Rather these groups align based on what they believe "contributions to Merrigorean culture and society" should look like.

The praxists support traditional Merrigorean culture. They are known for dressing in unrelieved black. Patterns and styles may be ornate but are very monochrome. A praxist at an even slightly formal occasion tends to look like a funeral attendee from most nations. When it comes to the arts the praxists favor realism. Their works are frequently beautiful and dramatic but they tend to favor depictions of real people and places and retellings of traditional stories. They tend to be overtly staid but are known for loving stories of courtly romance.

The cultivators tend to push more boundaries. They augment their blacks with rich colors and tend to wear ornate jewelry. When it comes to art and crafting they believe in "letting the spirits guide you," resulting in works that are often more evocative than realistic.

The atavists scorn the Game even as they play it. They certainly appreciate all the trappings of modern Merrigorean life, but they remember that Merrigor began when the Marags settled beneath the trees, and believe that no artistry or craftwork or celebration could do as much for Merrigor as simply pushing back the Ilfraics. They tend to incorporate earth tones and natural materials and themes into their garb and work. Most conspicuously, they favor elaborate leather masks. Masks are frequently worn by those who supervise logging crews or who brave the

forests to hunt or explore. This is a practical matter as they offer some protection against the Ilfraic pollen. But they are usually considered working gear; only an atavist would wear one to a formal occasion.

Current Events

The last cycle of the Great Game ended with the Bridging presided over by the Albescu family. They are a prominent historical family in the Chentva region and one of the most notable cultivator factions. In the last few months of the cycle they produced a variety of disturbing surreal statuary and a famously well attended concert full of sounds clearly made by instruments but almost mistakable for voices. These contributions cemented their already strong lead, but detractors are suggesting that their recent works are not merely haunting, but actively haunted. Thus far such suggestions have been dismissed as slander by sore losers.

The next cycle of the Game is in full swing and seems to be dominated by an alliance of several praxist factions. Much will be determined by how long that alliance manages to hold together. The disappearance of several well known artists of various media and the sudden illness of several more have lead to a great deal of finger pointing as various factions accuse each other of impropriety, but shrewder, or perhaps less partisan, minds note that no particular group seems to benefit from these tragedies.

In the region around Lasaldi in central Merrigor rumors are spreading of people beneath the Ilfraics, where no people should be able to survive. The most common belief is that some poor travelers succumbed to madness but not death from the pollen. On one hand this would mean that the Ilfraics are somehow becoming less lethal, but the end result is still fear. Revenant patrols in the area have increased and people who never before barred their doors at night are now.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot and Themes

Death and undeath are backdrops in Merrigor that likely feature in most plots. However the Great Game and exploring the woods and the threat they represent are a lot more immediately interactive. People in Merrigor compartmentalize well. Personal friends and enemies and allies and rivals in the Great Game aren't necessarily the same thing. And even enemies and rivals are collaborators when it comes to economic, military, political and other practical matters. The Great Game may produce some small opportunities for competitive plots, but it is by no means an excuse for PvP play in broader matters.

Costume and RP Themes

Most Merrigoreans enjoy fine clothes and other fine things and dress accordingly. Styles tend to the Victorian and Gothic. Coats, cloaks, vests and corsets are commonplace. Of course black is always in style, but recently jewel tones have also been popular. And people of all genders also

wear actual jewels, especially the famed local rubies. Consider what you wear; any Merrigorean would make assumptions about your persuasion and likely faction memberships in the Great Game based on superficial appearance.

Neither members of the Keepers of the Curtain nor revenants are suitable for player characters. Much like kings and high nobles in other lands, the Keepers have too much power and responsibility to be seen adventuring. Occasionally an acolyte chooses to leave the order before completing their training for whatever reason, so one could play a former acolyte, but such a person has neither the responsibilities nor the secret knowledge of a full Keeper. Revenants simply lack the spirit, will, or personality to make an interesting character.

Myos Islands

The Myos Islands are a nation that sits securely at the middle of a convergence of several Lattice Nodes known as the Sea Gates. Although the Gates themselves are usually surrounded by storms, the bad weather rarely touches the islands. The Myosians claim all of the sea up to the Gates as inside their border; this has caused arguments with other countries. There are three main islands in the nation: Myos Misi, Myos Cori, and Myos Okelis. It has become a thriving culture of its own as well as a gigantic trading hub. If you're willing to brave the storms and the Strait of Salts, you can trade in Myos for almost anything, as long as both parties agree it exists.



Geography, History, and Climate

While most of the smaller islands have their own ports of call and busy markets, Myos Misi has higher lands and rolling hills good for supporting livestock and producing goods made of wool, leather, and horn. Recently a quarry has begun work on the far side of this island, producing stone that appears to be good for building.

Myos Cori has low lands and limni ponds that produce two of the goods Myos is most famous for: island sugar and sun salt.

Myos Okelis is the largest and tallest of the three islands, and the center of commerce and trade. It is informally divided into two areas: "The Boards", which are the ship docks, markets, taverns and houses that cover every available spot at sea level, and "The Clouds", where the wealthiest merchants and nobles live in a bit more space. Each depends mightily on the other for survival, and a person running the Boards in search of something one day will be in the Clouds negotiating the best price the next.

The sigil of the Myos Islands is a stylized gold starfish on a field of blue. Locals proudly state that the arms of the starfish represent traveling through the Nodes to find needed things that only Myos can provide.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Myos is a monarchy that is descended from Carolin Myosine, the original discoverer of the Islands. She was an adventuring ship captain who set out and got caught in a terrible storm. With visibility at a dangerous low, she sailed in the only direction she could: dead ahead. After half a day of terrible winds and rain, suddenly they came upon clear weather—and tall islands rearing up from the horizon. Upon landing, Carolin and her crew broke out the rum to celebrate that they had lived through the journey. As their hangovers dissipated, they began to scout the land. They soon discovered that the islands were rich in wildlife and natural resources, but had no people. Seeing that, Carolin immediately declared herself Monarch and the rest of her crew to be Nobles. Originally the monarchy was meant to be hereditary, however, it took only a few generations to realize that the monarchy should be negotiated as well as most other things on Myos. Exactly how that was achieved remains a mystery to this day. The current Monarch is styled Arion Galanis of Myos, and has been reigning for the last 4 years.

The government is headed by the monarch but run by the Stewards, who are negotiated representatives of the people. While most noble Houses each have a steward of their own, it's not uncommon for whole neighborhoods in the Boards to band together and be represented by only one Steward. With protracted negotiations being almost inevitable, though, many Islanders simply trust themselves rather than waiting for the Stewards to decree something. A Steward of recent note is Sofia Kellis, who seems to be always available to lend a hand or smooth a discussion.

Everyday Life

Though negotiations dominate business, family and friendships have a much more relaxed approach. A marriage between firstborn sons might take months to finalize, but once they are family, business is a far second thought. A common signal in the Islands is to hold a coin or token in the hand but refuse to let it go, indicating that this is friendship, not livelihood. Parents often place a coin on a shelf, telling children they can begin learning to negotiate when the child can reach the coin—and not before.

Learning is prized in Myos, but is almost always in the style of mentor-apprentice rather than formal classrooms. Even the highest nobles will have done some practical training in their life; it is a point of pride to be able to say that they can always make an honest living. The first Monarch and Nobles, after all, were sailors—even Arion Galanis is said to be a very competent leather worker. Many people come to the Islands to learn sailing and shipbuilding, of course, but alchemy, healing, and art are becoming more popular for apprentices seeking mentors.

Just like their first Queen and her crew, Myosians love to celebrate. A ship arriving, a masterpiece made, a full moon are all reasons to relax and enjoy life on these pleasant islands. One of the

most famous celebrations is called the Festival of the Boards, which is so popular that revelers have been known to swim ashore for it if no docks are available for their ship.

Current events

The nation of Myos is currently dealing with something almost incomprehensible to the population: piracy. Goods have been falling prey to ships flying no identifying flags, causing turmoil in all areas of trade. Being a nation that is famous for their negotiating skills, the reality that someone can stoop to stealing what they want (and be successful!) is increasing anger and suspicion on the Boards and in the Clouds. Myos has never held a navy or other military force, but some voices are starting to question if that decision is wise.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot Themes/RP Themes

Adventurers, Ambassadors, Mercenaries and Crafters from all cultures are in Myos from one day to the next. Some choose to stay and make a living; others choose to take the next ship out. It's almost a rite of passage for young Myosians to step on a ship without knowing where it's going; if they choose to return, they're expected to have learned a great deal to offer back.

Myos is a relatively young country with all of the benefits and drawbacks of being young. Players from Myos can expect themes of exploration, discovery, and danger in unexpected places. Those who enjoy finding what's beyond the sugar and above the salt, forging new alliances, and fighting for their ideals will likely find Myos plot entertaining.

Costume Themes

Since Myos is a true international port, cultural dress from all nations can be seen. Locals wear any style they like and can afford, with practical alterations where necessary. Those that stay a while will often copy their previous culture's style in lighter weight fabrics that help to keep cool in the warm Myos air. Vests have recently become the fashion. Different hues of gold and blue are popular, representing the sun and the sea.

Republic of Ophrailes

The Republic of Ophrailes is a nation with a curious balance of power between the people and the rulers. The government is made up of three branches - the Crown, the Legislature, and the Judiciary. Ophrailes is a Democratic Republic where the people elect their representatives. Those representatives elect the Crown Prince and most of the judiciary, and vote on behalf of the people.

Though the Crown Prince is elected, for more than a dozen generations the Leonate family has held the position. The current Crown Prince, Eviar Leonate, has ruled for 10 years after winning an uncontested election. Indeed, it is rare that anyone has contested the election of a Crown Prince since the Leonate Dynasty came into power. On the few occasions where someone has tried, they have overwhelmingly lost. The Leonate Dynasty is truly loved by the people.

The Republic is a feudal one, with noble families (the head of each holds the title of Prince) owning and governing the lands, and Peasants laboring for the good of the nation. The Peasant class includes non-landed gentry, merchants, farmers, and other laborers. Some peasants who fall upon hard times may become Bonded Peasants, who owe a debt to their Prince and lose some rights until that debt is repaid.

Geography, History, and Climate

Ophrailes was founded nearly 500 years ago, after a series of wars between neighboring kingdoms. Alliances between those kingdoms shifted with the tide, and no single kingdom was ever able to gain the upper hand long enough to end the wars. A Peacebringer of Istarum, Lucas Ophrailes, finally convinced enough of the Kings to come to the negotiating table. They were able to hammer out a treaty that not only ended the wars, but formed a new Republic stronger in unity than any of the Kingdoms had ever been divided. A key point of conflict during the negotiations was who would rule. None of the individual Kingdoms were willing to submit to another, no King was willing to bow the knee to another King. The ingenious solution that Lucas came up with was that none would have to - the current Kings would retain their titles, but relinquish authority to their heirs, who would likewise retain the title of Prince. Those heirs would elect, from among themselves, a Crown Prince. The title of King would not be used, and as the Crown Prince would be an elected, not a hereditary position, no King or Prince would be called upon to bend the knee to another - instead, they swore oaths to the Republic, not its head. Against his objections, the new nation was named after the Peacebringer who brought it to fruition. Though Ophrailes today has two Assemblies (of the People and of the Princes), originally it had but one - the Assembly of Princes. The people had no representation, and most had no autonomy or authority over their own lives. That came centuries later.

200 years ago, Crown Prince Eduard Dales nearly led the country into a civil war. The Dales family had never treated the common-folk in their lands particularly well, and other Princes who were likewise were emboldened by the accession of Eduard to the throne. Conditions for peasants living in parts of the country ruled by those Princes deteriorated, and civil unrest spread

across most of the country. Those Princes not aligned with Eduard rallied armies (both conscripted and volunteer, with many volunteers coming from Eduard and his allies' own peasantry) to support the peasants. With the support of these armies and many of the other Princes, Prince Alistair Leonate successfully led a campaign to recall him. He was then selected unanimously to replace Eduard Dales, and adeptly navigated the country not only out of the impending civil war, but to greater prosperity than ever before. Under Leonate's rule, laws were established protecting the rights of peasants and forbidding their mistreatment. An Assembly of the People was formed, ensuring that the common-folk would have a voice in their own governance - even to the point of allowing the Assembly of the People, not the Assembly of the Princes, to elect the Crown Prince. The Dales family and their allies lost all political clout they once had. They did retain their status as nobles, and most still have a seat in the Assembly of Princes. Though it took a few generations for all the Princes to truly come on board with Alistair Leonate's new laws, even the most stubborn and cold-hearted of Princes were convinced by the success of those changes.

Ophrailes is located in the center of the southern continent, between Spyndlemere to the west, and Tbariss, to the east. Its northern and southern coastlines are forested, while the center of the country is mostly plains. The Great Bonarey Lake (so named after a species of rather large fish endemic to the lake) sits in the center of the southern half of the country, while a mostly cold desert spreads across the northern half. The country has four seasons, with snow (sometimes significant) in the winter, hot and rainy summers, with temperate seasons in between.

Politics and Government

The government is divided into three branches, each of which with its own unique authorities and responsibilities, and with no branch having unfettered power over the others.

The Crown

The Crown branch is headed by the Crown Prince, who is elected by the Assembly of the People (originally by the Assembly of the Princes, until the end of the last civil war), from among the Princes. Once elected, the Crown Prince serves for life, or until recalled by the Assembly of Princes. Crown Prince Eduard Dales, who nearly led the country into a civil war, was the only Crown Prince ever recalled. The current Crown Prince is Eviar Leonate. The Crown Prince names several Consuls who advise them.

Legislature

The legislature is divided into the Assembly of the People (elected by the people) and the Assembly of Princes (titled nobility). The Assembly of Princes has a High Prince and the Assembly of the People has a High Speaker, who each manage the business of their Assemblies.

Judiciary

The Judiciary includes local elected magistrates, regional appointed tribunals, and a Court of Arbitration. Magistrates are elected by the community and serve largely at the community's

pleasure. Within each prince's territory is a Tribunal, nominated by the people but appointed by the Prince, usually from among those nominations. The Court of Arbitration, the highest court, consists of 5 Justiciars appointed by the Crown Prince, who serve for a single 20-year term, staggered by 4 years each. The appointment of Justiciars, and their identities, is a closely guarded secret, known only to the Crown Prince and their Judicial Advisor, the High Prince and High Speaker, and a select few others. By tradition, Justiciars take on the name of the first Justiciar who held their position at the founding of the nation, setting aside their given names for the duration of their service. The Court of Arbitration meets in public but with their identities hidden by powerful magic granted by Thiacris. This secrecy serves to ensure that the Court of Arbitration cannot be swayed by politics, bribery, or corruption. Decisions made at lower levels can be appealed upwards, but decisions of the Court of Arbitration are final.

The Seat of Government

The government of Ophrailes meets in the town of Nanamont, where the treaty forming the nation was signed. By tradition the land the town rests upon is not owned by any of the noble houses, but is neutral and maintained by the Crown Prince's house.

Religion

Worship of individual Genesori varies from village to village, and most smaller villages do not have a dedicated temple. Larger towns and cities may have one or several temples, dedicated to some or all of the Genesori. Religious affiliation is seen as a deeply personal, but important choice. Those who choose not to worship the Genesori are not seen as any less (or more) than those who do.

The Economy

Ophrailes' economy includes a healthy balance between peasants and nobility. Peasant farmers and merchants support most of the local economy, while the Princes provide economic support in times of trouble, and manage most of the trade within Ophrailes and with other countries. Peasants are supported by the nobles upon whose lands they live and work. When there is widespread drought, pestilence, or other natural hardship impacting most or all of a Prince's land, the Prince is obligated to ensure that the peasants on their land have what they need to recover, without the peasants incurring any debt as a result.

If an individual peasant family falls upon hard times and is unable to support themselves, contribute to their community, or pay their taxes, they may petition their Prince for help. In exchange for the Prince's help, the family incurs a debt and become bonded peasants until that debt is repaid. Bonded peasants owe additional taxes to their Prince to repay the debt; and beginning one year after a family become bonded peasants, the Prince may direct their labor, including retraining them to perform other duties. Often, the grown children of bonded peasants are sent to apprentice with other tradesmen or merchants, where they may be better positioned to earn enough to repay the family debt. Princes are also responsible for dealing with any hardships that befall bonded peasants who are indebted to them - if a bonded peasant family is unable to pay their taxes due to hardship (disease, natural disaster, what have you), the Prince

is responsible for making up the difference; if crops fail, the Prince is responsible for providing food to live and seed to regrow; though this support may add to the debt the bonded peasants owe. The law forbids Princes from abusing their authority to make repayment of the debts too onerous, and provides for outright cancellation of the debt and full restoration of rights for the peasant should a Prince violate this law. In the vast majority of cases, bonded peasants are able to work their way out of debt within a few years, or a generation at most.

Everyday Life

Among the peasantry, family structure in Ophraile is relatively malleable - there is no legally recognized "marriage". Formal consortships between two (or sometimes more) people are common and often long-lasting. The same is not quite true among the Nobility, however. In order to maintain family lineages, it is made clear from the outset of any consortship which family the children will be considered to be part of, and what inheritance rights they may have. Most often, the firstborn child of a Prince inherits the title upon their parent's death; in the rare occasions where both parents are Princes, the firstborn usually inherits the title for the more prominent house, and the second born inherits for the less prominent house. Written contracts dictating inheritance rights are strictly adhered to, and enforced by the courts (by the High Court, any time the title of Prince is involved.) For both peasants and nobles alike, consortships do not have to be formed with the intent of producing offspring, and consortships between people of the same gender are not uncommon. Consortships between more than two people, while far less common than that, are neither unheard of, nor frowned upon.

Peasants of any type typically spend the bulk of their daylight hours at their labors, though leisure time in the evenings is cherished. In many small villages, dinner is a social event where everyone will gather in a large hall and share meals they cooked in their own homes, and travelers are usually invited to join in the humble feast. In larger cities, these communal meals are less common, typically reserved for festival days and organized within each neighborhood.

For the nobility, daily life is very different. Other than the poorest of nobles, most of the nobility spend their days not at manual labor, but at more creative, intellectual, or cultural pursuits. As the nobility have an obligation to their peasants, leisure time for a noble is very much dependent on their peasants' well-being. If the peasants working a noble's land are suffering hardships, the noble must provide for them. A noble who has mismanaged their estate and spends their time at leisure while their peasants suffer risks being ostracized at court, and in extreme cases, stripped of their titles and land.

The practice of the Arcane is important in the Republic. For its entire history, the Crown Prince has been a powerful mage of some kind, and every noble family has at least one mage among their ranks. The powerful Gift of Jade guild, founded shortly after the reemergence of the lattice, counts among its members many of the highest ranking nobility, including several advisors to the Crown Prince, and according to rumors at least two members of the Court of Arbitration; though the guild is open to peasant mages as well. The guild takes its name from the jade gemstones its members use as a focus for much of their magic. While some of that jade comes

from deposits within Ophrailes, there are trade agreements in place with the Vale of Scyllina for more.

The First Walk

When peasant children come of age (anywhere from age 14-22, though the exact timing depends on the developmental maturity of the individual, family needs, and other individual circumstances), they are taken blindfolded out into the countryside, several days' journey from home. There they are left, with a few days worth of rations and a knife, to find their way to... wherever. Whatever village they come upon first is their new home, where they are welcomed with open arms into a new family. Sometimes parents will strategically deposit their children somewhere the parents think will give the children a good opportunity to better their lives. While they do stay in contact with and often visit their parents, it is this with this new family upon which they build their future. A young Ophralian's first consortship is often with another young person who found the same new family.

Nobles have a similar rite of passage, though it is far more carefully orchestrated. A young Ophralian noble will be sent to live with a peasant family for two years, to learn to live as the peasants do, and labor alongside them. This is seen as an important step in the noble child's education and preparation for leadership, as they gain a valuable perspective on what life is like for the people they govern. A noble who refuses to live among the peasants, or who refuses to humble themselves while doing so, will often be passed over for inheritance.

Current Events

In the past year, strange creatures with glowing green eyes have started coming out of the forests along the southern coast of Ophrailes, attacking small villages. Rumors abound that the Gift of Jade guild is somehow responsible, allegations they vehemently deny.

A blight is forming upon the land, beginning west of the Great Bonarey Lake in the center of Ophrailes. No cause is yet known.

Prince Skyler Dales has been making noise in the Assembly of Princes about the Leonates ruling for too long, suggesting the need for a new law preventing the election of the Prince of any House from being elected Crown Prince, if the previous Crown Prince was from that House.

Notes for Players

As Ophrailes is the union of what was once several kingdoms, names can take inspiration from virtually any real-world or fantasy-world culture or other origin, or can be entirely made up. Names without a strong gender connotation are popular and the title of Prince is non-gendered. Nobles always use their family name in addition to their given name; peasants often use only a given name. Characters from Ophrailes may be from any class level, from Bonded Peasant up to nobility. Characters from named noble houses require background approval to ensure plot consistency.

Cultural Plot and Themes

Characters from Ophraile can expect opportunities to navigate the maze of politics and shape the future of their nation; explore magic and magical beings; overcome adversity; figure out what's going on in the forests to the south; and discover what exactly rests deep beneath the island off the southern coast. Community is important in Ophrailes, and supporting each other (especially when it comes to necessities of life such as food) is one of the core cultural morals.

Costume and RP Themes

If from a Noble family: family crests, courtly/nobile attire dyed in vibrant colors (most often shades of golden yellow, red, and purple). Leather, cotton, silk are all common materials. Jewelry is less common than in other cultures, and when present, is usually modest. All members of the Gift of Jade guild wear some kind of jewelry or other adornment which includes a small piece of jade.

If a Peasant: Sturdy clothing in more muted colors, mostly browns & grays with some yellow, red, or purple accents. Leather, wool, linen are all common materials. Jewelry, if present, is usually simple, a keepsake on a string perhaps.

Customs and Common Phrases

When an Ophralian meets a stranger with whom they expect to have ongoing contact, it is customary to offer the stranger food or drink. This could be by inviting them to join you for a meal, or simply offering a small snack, wrapped candy, or the like. This custom does not apply to incidental or passing contact. Merchants typically have a small sample of their goods they will gift to potential customers.

"We always rebuild" - used when something (usually) bad happens that you have no choice but to accept and move on from. Crops fail? Time to rebuild. Sword breaks? Time to rebuild. It's used as a reminder to one's self not to dwell on the misfortune for too long, but instead to figure out how to recover from it.

"Dust farming" - doing something pointless/fruitless, especially when obvious that it's pointless.

"Dust farmer" - one who is doing or regularly does dust farming.

"Party of pigs" - when a situation is all messed up and those involved are unlikely to be able to fix it without outside help.

"Rot!" - catch-all swear word usable in most circumstances.

Notable Personages

The Crown Consulate

- Crown Prince Eviar Leonate - the current Crown Prince
- Consul Kavie Austen, Legislative Advisor
- Consul Avery Wright, Judicial Advisor

- Consul Johann Dunbarton, Military Advisor
- Consul Jonathan Morrow, Arcane Advisor
- Consul Dorander Marcellus, Divine Advisor
- Consul Edward Bower, Commerce Advisor
- Consul Adrian, Advisor for the People
- Consul Stranach Vitandas, Foreign Advisor
- Other less-notable people

Assembly of Princes / Noble Houses

- House Leonate is represented in the Assembly by the Crown Consort, Sawyer Leonate
- House Sarraffet - Prince Tyrodes Sarraffet, High Prince
- House Gofraid - Prince Camden Gofraid
- House Hadley - Prince Ameline Hadley
- House Dunbarton - Prince Juan Dunbarton
- House Morrow - The Twin Princes, Dhoma and Yesta Morrow
- House Crenton - Prince Urul Crenton
- House Lamorral - Prince Ulysses Lamorral
- House Dales - Prince Skyler Dales
- Other less-notable houses
- (See below for more details about each of the major noble houses)

Assembly of the People

- High Speaker Smythe, a merchant and High Speaker
- Speaker Noel, a craftsman
- Speaker Roch, a craftsman/merchant
- Speaker Auguste, a mage
- Speaker Renée, a farmer
- Other less-notable Speakers

The Court of Arbitration

- Justiciar Balderic
- Justiciar Ebbo
- Justiciar Sethra
- Justiciar Tescelin
- Justiciar Thegan

Gift of Jade Guild

- Archmage Dhoma Morrow - Guildmaster
- Archmage Mortimer Gange Dett - Head Examiner
- Archmage Hollister See - Chief Librarian
- Archmage Emilia Thorne - Healer

- Archmage Zorander Roshin - Field Study
- Other, less-notable archmages and mages

The Noble Houses



House Crenton

House Crenton is known for throwing lavish parties for the nobility, and generous seasonal feasts for the peasants. The parties they throw for the nobility are ostensibly non-political, and nobody would be so gauche as to openly discuss politics during them. This has given rise to a sort of art form where nobles will hide political discussions within more mundane topics of conversation. Despite hosting these gatherings, Prince Urul Crenton is not politically active, preferring to play the role of host to that of head. House Crenton's symbol is the Golden Cornucopia on a white field.

House Dales

House Dales is still recovering somewhat from the damage done to its reputation by Crown Prince Eduard Dales 200 years ago, though Prince Skyler Dales, its current Prince, has made great strides in bringing House Dales back into public view as a responsible noble house. Through astute dealings with the other Princes, Prince Dales has started to become a powerful figure in the House of Princes. There are rumors that Prince Dales may even be aiming for the position of High Prince after Prince Sarraffet. House Dales' symbol is the Tree in Winter on a green field.



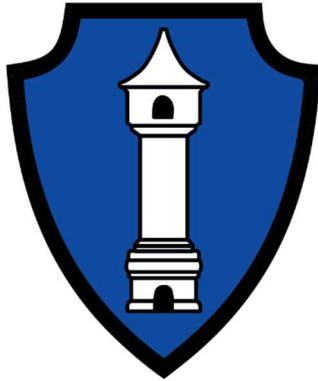
House Dunbarton

House Dunbarton is the only house with a standing militia, and as such conducts most of the military training for Ophrailes' military. Prince Juan Dunbarton previously served as General of the Armies, before his father passed 5 years ago. Peasants on House Dunbarton lands are encouraged to join military service for 2 years in lieu of their First Walk, and wherever they most recently served as of the end of their term of service becomes their new home. House Dunbarton's symbol is the Crossed Swords on a purple field.

House Gofraid

Prince Camden Gofraid is a skilled Shadewalker, and much of House Gofraid's lands have a strange overlay with the Shade. Shade creatures can often be seen flitting around in the shadows, especially at night, and peasants know better than to travel alone at night, for fear of getting lost and wandering into the shade by mistake. Those taking their First Walk in this part of Ophrailes will be left early in the morning and closer to another village, so they can complete their First Walk before night falls. It's agreed that Prince Gofraid is a suspicious, distrusting person, and that has filtered down into other members of the House. When it comes time for elections, the Prince arrives with their retinue, votes, and leaves. House Gofraid is also known for having a large number of Bonded Peasants relative to the total peasant population. Many openly disparage the House for this, saying that it's proof they do not care for their Peasants responsibly, but Prince Gofraid asserts that they are complying fully with the laws. House Gofraid's symbol is the Ring of Stars on a black field.





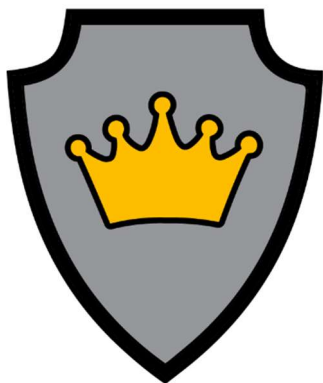
House Hadley

Prior to the founding of Ophrailes, King Hadley was one of the most powerful Kings in the region, and once the treaty was signed, his daughter Pritan was elected first Crown Prince. Since that time, though, no Hadley has held the title of Crown Prince – a fact that has never set well with them. House Hadley is known for being one of the largest Houses in the Republic, with smaller branches of the family seeming to sprout up everywhere. In recent generations, the Hadleys have started to pay close attention to their consortships as well, encouraging joinings that balance each other out: a warrior will be encouraged to consort with a scholar, for instance. Some whisper that House Hadley is taking a long view towards leading the Republic by trying to achieve dominance in several areas of excellence. Prince Ameline Hadley is the current Prince of the house. House Hadley's symbol is the Tower on a blue field.

House Lamorral

House Lamorral lays claim to the Great Bonarey Lake and much of the land immediately surrounding it. Many of the peasants living within their lands are farmers or fishermen, the latter pulling in schools of Striped, Spotted, and Silverfin Bonarey for sale in markets. The lake's namesake, the Great Bonarey, has been in decline in recent years, with catches being smaller in both number and size – where once it was common to catch Great Bonarey weighing several hundred pounds, now it is rare to find any over 100 pounds. Prince Ulysses Lamorral has outlawed the catching, sale, or consumption of Great Bonarey, in an attempt to help the population recover. More recently, a blight has begun to form to the west of the lake, affecting fields and wildlife. What was once verdant soil is now dead swampland. The Lamorrals are quietly consulting with other Houses on this growing problem. House Lamorral's symbol is the Kingfisher, on an orange field.



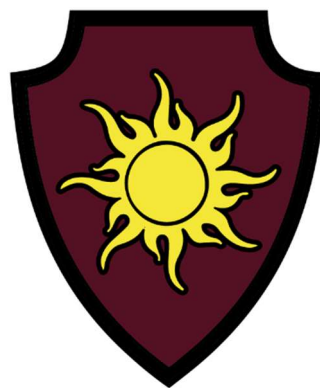


House Leonate

Since the near civil war 200 years ago, the Prince of House Leonate has held the position of Crown Prince of Ophrailes. The current Crown Prince, Eviar Leonate, has ruled for 10 years. Crown Consort Sawyer Leonate represents House Leonate in the Assembly of Princes. It has been a tradition in House Leonate for several generations that whatever excess funds the House has at the end of the year, beyond their projected needs for the next year, would be used to reduce the debt owed by any Bonded Peasants owing House Leonate. This has made House Leonate quite popular with the peasant class, and has resulted in them having fewer Bonded Peasants than any of the other noble houses. House Leonate's symbol is currently the Golden Crown on a gray field, but prior to that was the Lion Rampant on a gray field.

House Morrow

House Morrow is led by the twin Princes, Dhoma and Yesta Morrow. Most of the nobility in House Morrow are mages of some kind, and the practice of magic is encouraged not only amongst the nobility, but by the peasantry as well. Every year, any peasants who wish to be tested for magical aptitude are invited to travel to Castle Morrow, and if they are found to have talent, are offered an apprenticeship in the Gift of Jade guild. Prince Dhoma is a powerful archmage and guildmaster of the Gift of Jade guild, while his sister Yesta is a practitioner of Divine magic. House Morrow's symbol is the Sun on a burgundy field.



House Sarraffet



Prince Tyrodes Sarraffet currently holds the title of High Prince, the top-ranking Prince in the Assembly of Princes. House Sarraffet is one of the wealthiest noble houses, counting among them many merchants with significant national and international interests. The bulk of trade with other nations, particularly via the Myos Islands, flows through House Sarraffet. House Sarraffet uses their wealth to ensure their peasants have what they need to live comfortably and work their trades. Most Bonded Peasants who owe a debt to House Sarraffet do so because of failed trade investments, piracy, or other similar misfortune. House Sarraffet's symbol is the Tradesman's Scale on an orange field.

Lesser Nobility

In many cases, especially among the larger noble houses, when a Prince has several children, they will subdivide their lands and while one of their children will become the next Prince, the others will be given the title Marquess and given an allotment of land to own and manage. There

may be several Marquesses in a given Prince's domain. These Marquesses do not have a seat in the House of Princes, though many of them do serve as advisors, aids, or in other official or unofficial capacities. A Marquess who has also served in the military is referred to as a Margrave (see Knights, below).

The Military

Ophrailes has a national military, not tied to any individual house. Houses are forbidden from forming their own military, except for House Dunbarton. In exchange for being allowed to maintain a militia, House Dunbarton agreed to train the national military (at the government's expense) and relinquished their right to be considered for Crown Prince.

The Military is divided into officers and soldiers. Officers are usually from noble houses, though sometimes peasants who show particular promise can be made officers. Soldiers are usually peasants, though again this is not always the case. Military service is voluntary, though the Crown does have the right to conscript people into service in times of war.

When the child or grandchild of a Prince chooses to join the military, they are given the honorific of 'Knight' in front of their rank (e.g. Knight Lieutenant, Knight Soldier, etc.) Knight Officers' children who join the military are given the same honorific, and this continues for as long as there is an unbroken chain of Knights. Children and grandchildren of a Marquess who join the military are given the honorific of 'Knight Errant' in front of their rank. Unlike the 'Knight' honorific, the 'Knight Errant' honorific does not automatically carry through to future generations.

Noble Titles

Crown Prince - The Prince of a house who has been selected by the Assembly of the People to lead the nation

High Prince - the head of the Assembly of Princes

Prince - the head of one of the major Noble Houses

Marquess - A non-heir child of a Prince who has been granted land and title.

Margrave - A Marquess who has also served in the military.

Lord - other members of a Noble House

Knight - The child or grandchild of a Prince, who has served in the military. Inherits to future generations as long as the tradition of military service is unbroken.

Knight Errant - the child or grandchild of a Marquess, who has served in the military. Does not inherit to future generations.

Education

All princes have a legal obligation to provide for basic education for any child whose parents request it. This mandatory education includes the ability to read, write, and perform basic arithmetic. Beyond that most education for peasants is provided through apprenticeship in a trade.

The Principalities of the Reach

"Here there is freedom, my children. Freedom to build, freedom to rule, freedom to do as we choose. This is where our story begins, and should we be found unworthy, this is where it ends."

"The Principalities of the Reach" is not a name adopted by any nation. It is the name the other nations have given to an expanse of land where politics, wars, borders, and even life are ever changing. Nobody can predict at any time how many micronations claim to exist in the Reach, nor can anyone accurately predict what will appear or vanish next.

Geography, History, and Climate

Lying to the west of the inland sea, the Geography and Climate of the Reach are nearly incomprehensibly varied. Throughout the ages the land has often been shaped by those with power and will to shape not just a Principality but the very land to their desires. Geomancers, weather controllers, Nature workers, and others have all had their impact on the land and the long reaching consequences of this have left both dense rainforest, snowy tundra and everything in between in various places of the Reach.

History is likewise nearly impossible to track within the Reach. Scholars can devote a lifetime just to simply tracking the names of Principalities and rulers as they come and go, without even finding the time to actually explore the values, politics, or prerogatives of these Principalities.

A very few notable groups have made strongholds in the Reach that have stood the test of time. Some of these groups are like the Hearthguards - a powerful military order that chooses to maintain it's keep within the Reach so as to remain neutral to the Nations of the world. This is in fact not uncommon and the Reach is seen as a place where a powerful enough group can establish a base of operations while maintaining political neutrality.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Politics, Government, and Economy are all everchanging in the Reach. It is up to each Principality how these things will develop, and rarely if ever do they impact lands outside the Reach.

Out of Game Note

The Reach is an open playground available to players whose characters simply can't fit anywhere else in one of the other Nations. Choosing the Reach as a background gives the player the ability to devise a small micro-nation that their character originated from, with few restrictions on the politics of the land. The basic guidelines are that it be small (There are always many Principalities in the Reach, you can not come from one leader that united or conquered it) and the Principality can not have a long and storied history (Principalities rise and fall frequently but do not often last beyond the lifespan of the individual or group that founds them)

If you choose the Principalities of the Reach as a National origin, then you accept that your character will not likely see National plot directed their way. While there will always be many plots running in Numina and you may even encounter personal plot tailored to your character and background, the Principalities of the Reach simply won't have National Plot.

Notes for Players

The Principalities of the Reach is provided for those players who desire a land completely apart from any of the more developed Nations. If it is critical to your background that your Mother was a queen, then perhaps she was queen of a Monarchy here within the Reach. Likewise if you want to play a character completely divorced of any national loyalty, the Reach could be an option for you.

Costume, RP, and background are all up to the player who chooses the Reach. It is fine to decide for yourself cultural rules, common looks, holidays, behaviors, or other elements to give flavor to a character, but anyone choosing to do this should be aware that few if any characters will have any idea what these things are due to their extreme specificity to small Principality.

As a reminder of what was said above, If you choose the Principalities of the Reach as a National origin, then you accept that your character will not likely see National plot directed their way. While there will always be many plots running in Numina and you may even encounter personal plot tailored to your character and background, the Principalities of the Reach simply won't have National Plot.

Rues

Ah, Rues! The land of legend!

After centuries of isolation behind a magical barrier, Rues appeared suddenly and brilliantly on the world stage as a result of the Great Rebalancing. Many are surprised to find that such a historically significant place is not a vast continent but a large island far across the ocean. It is home to the Mercurian Empire, the Federated Kingdom of the Selda'nire, and a number of independent peoples, all of whom are in the midst of a golden age.

In addition to being the last known location of Fortune's Bend, it is also home to the famous Academy of Diplomats, who have managed the three Lattice Thresholds that make large scale travel to Rues possible. This group had its humble beginnings as a network of couriers who had mastered the use of Rues' rustic gate network and over time blossomed into expert international ambassadors who have been entrusted with Rues' connection to the rest of the world.



Even before the Lattice was reconnected, intrepid travelers crossed the great ocean from Rues and made contact with the mainlanders. The incredible events of Rues, including the Night of Guardian's Glory, the Awakening of the Ten, and the Great Rebalancing were told and retold throughout Aeled and it became a romantic ideal. It is so beloved that it is not uncommon in some places for people to know more of the history of Rues than of their own nation.

Geography, History, and Climate

Rues comprises one large landmass called Cavalero, an archipelago known as the Shar'deen, and a number of smaller islands around the coast.

The northernmost tip of Cavalero is cool temperate grasslands, while the southernmost point is a dry, unforgiving desert. The center is a jumble of jagged stone mountains that, prior to the opening of the Lattice, were impossible to navigate. In the northeastern quarter is a vast connection of swamp and marshland, and in the northwest a lush old growth forest. It is on this diverse, larger landmass that the Mercurian empire makes its home.

The Federated Kingdom of the Selda'nire is on the Shar'deen archipelago off of the western coast of the empire. It consists of five large islands and a good number of smaller ones. The capital city Tor Mythra rises from the pinnacle of the towering mesas on Mythandros Isle. Before any Thresholds opened on Rues, trade was established on ocean-going ships from the docks on the archipelago. The island of Galdarn hosts Rues' only known volcano.

Just south of the Shar'deen near the coast of the empire is the Wyvern gate, a safe passageway to the underwater kingdom of Drakkenspar.

To the north of the Shar'deen Archipelago is Valya Seere, an island pushed far above sea level by a powerful spout of water. It was thought lost to Corruption on the Night of Guardian's Glory, but it became accessible once more after the Great Rebalancing.

The residents of Valya Seere are a strange lot. Stories are told that when corruption overtook the city long ago, the residents split into two separate beings; one containing all the emotional traits and other characteristics that would be vulnerable to corruption, the other containing those traits that could not easily be corrupted. Whether that tale is true or not, the schism seems to still exist to this day in the personalities of any who make Valya Seere their home.

The Batterklast mountains in the center of Rues are only lightly inhabited, and for that reason the Dominus Conduit was constructed there. This marvel of Arcaneering provides power through arcane pipelines across Rues for the function of comforts like flameless lanterns. Below the mountains are the caves and caverns of the Ereskial republic and their deep metal and gem mines.

A short way out from the southeast coast is Oscillo Island, which is more commonly referred to as Frontier Island. Around two hundred years ago, the Sovereign Archon Marax broke open the Sphere of Illusion, which was anchored to Aeled. It is speculated that perhaps he did this too quickly, but regardless of cause the effect was a devastating disgorging of Illusion power and Archons onto Oscillo, making reality difficult to discern and usually irrelevant on the island. Due to the dangers, the Empire holds this place as a protectorate with custodial rights given to Isou University, and the aftermath is still being carefully studied, measured, and mitigated.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Rues conducts its politics with the rest of the world through a neutral organization known as the Academy of Diplomats. This group proved themselves adept at managing the minutiae of relationships between the Empire and its regencies, the Federation and the Empire, the Ereskial and the overworld, and the independent peoples.

When the first lattice Threshold appeared on Valya Seere, it nearly caused a rift in the centuries-long alliance between the two great powers of Rues. The Academy of Diplomats is credited for resolving the conflict without war and as a sign of trust from both nations, they were put in charge of managing the Threshold. This first portal that connected Rues to the outside world is called the Donato Gate.

As trade and relations slowly opened between Rues and the world beyond, the Academy of Diplomats became just as adept at managing the visitors and all of the new cultural customs and ideas that came with them. They were deemed so good at it that when a second Threshold opened in the Federation, and the third in Pyrelight, the Academy was called in to manage them.

The majority of the land is governed by the Mercurian Empire, named for the family of its founders. Within the empire are a number of kingdoms and regencies who, even though they are under imperial rule, have maintained their own cultures.

Equal in political power but smaller in size is the Federated Kingdom of the Selda'nire. Their governing document, the Doctrine of Unity, is also their national philosophy. It has served them well even across centuries leading to a flourishing population and unspoiled natural beauty.

Scattered across the lands, rivers, and seas are independent peoples who do not claim allegiance to any of these kingdoms or regencies, and live under no rule but their own.

The Mercurian Empire

The Mercurian Empire is named for its founding family, the Mercurio. The current empress is Evenia Mercurio Pentratheron who gained the throne at age twenty-six and has ruled over the empire's golden age for forty-two years. Her eldest son, Venius Mercurio is unwed. In keeping with tradition, her second-eldest child, Aspira, has married the second princess of the Federation, Hethryl Mythandros.

The emblem of the empire is the Stinging Phoenix, a hybrid creature composed from the Mercurian Phoenix and the Pentratheron Manticore. The union of these two families is generally credited by historians for the remarkable longevity of the empire and its eventual golden age. For people of Rues, the Mercurian Empire and Empire of the Stinging Phoenix are interchangeable names.

The regencies under imperial protection are Anbara, Volbrecht, Inlyrico, Braeus, Shiara, Drakkenspar, and Khemera. They manage all of these from the imperial capital of Pyrelight.

There are a variety of cultures even within the empire, and only the Academy of Diplomats has proved expert at consistently navigating them. Most have a more casual understanding of the imperial regencies and their highlights.

Anbara is a thriving monarchy on the edge of the Byse desert in the south. Though Anbara was once a nation rife with poverty and starvation, that ended during the reign of Queen Azari the First. Anbara is known across Rues for the Alastair Games, an international competition in fighting, music, scholarly pursuits, and other games. They are also known for their heraldic, Jackal, who often accompanies the Unmasked Monarch to important functions.

Volbrecht is a stalwart, visceral regency whose people are known as the warriors of Rues. Communities tend to be close, as it is common for at least one person from each household to be out of the country, bringing their shield to where it is needed. Volbrecht is also home to the Feathered Sword, a group who travel throughout all of Rues, providing basic education in reading, writing, and arithmetic to those who can not access a school.

Inlyrico, the Golden Rose, is the most beautiful of the regencies, and is home to the Pristine Tower. This tower is a locked gate that keeps Corruption at bay in Rues, and it is said that it will

stand forever unless it is left unguarded. Inlyrico's regent is always a member of the convocation of Those Who Walked Away.

Braeus has territory from the northeastern swamps up into the Batterklast mountains to the Dominus Conduit. They are known for Isou University, which was open even before the Lattice connected Rues to the rest of the world. Braeus is known for their highly educated population, their forward-looking Arcaneers, and their wide-reaching civil engineering projects like the arcane pipeline

Shiara is a kind, easy land to live in due to their conscientious provincial lords, fortunate climate and countryside, and a guardian dragon. In the countryside is the Shiaran Conservatory, an archive of Mementos that were bequeathed upon death and can be called upon for stories and songs from the past. In the capital is the humble home of the Bladesmen Academy, the dueling school whose teachers can be found across Rues and beyond.

Drakkenspar is an underwater kingdom, protected in a bubble of air and only accessible through the Wyvern Gate or carefully connected Lattice nodes. The regency is known as a liminal space, shared equally between physical land and the Shade domain of the Ship. This unusual relationship means that every aspect of Sparian life changes with the seasons, as the four aspects of the Ship wax and wane in power.

Khemera is just south of the Imba'nire Nation, in land that was known as Pyredown until the dawn of the Stinging Phoenix. The largest city is Fort Firetol, where the former imperial palace has been renovated for use as a hospital.

The imperial capital of Pyrelight has grown up around the former site of Fortune's Bend, and some of the historic buildings are still preserved at its center. One in particular is the tavern, where visitors report hearing music and voices telling stories from the time before the Great Rebalancing. Khemera's Lattice Threshold, called the Vincenzi Gate, is located just outside the city.

The Federation

The Federation has five large islands called Mythandros, Halanth, Galdarn, Ambra, and Erekon. Surrounding these are a number of smaller islands whose names are little known outside their own borders. The archipelago boasts remarkable biodiversity within its relatively small borders to include lush forest and a dormant volcano. The Federation's Lattice Threshold is called the Meraki Gate and it opened on a mid-size island just off the coast of Halanth.

The Federation society is predicated upon a document called the Doctrine of Unity, which governs both the rule of their nation as well as each citizen's rule of themselves. The doctrine promotes balance between the physical, mental, and spiritual aspect of the world and the individual. The Federation culture has developed a caste system to support and further this goal. There are seven castes, each of whom contributes differently to the Federation and must overcome different obstacles to fulfill the Doctrine of Unity. The castes of the Federation are the

Manu, Oros, Arcos, Triss, Prian, Regnum, and Valar. Unified, they create societal balance to equal the individual balance of each citizen.

Among the Regnum is the monarch of the Federation, a hereditary position that has been held by the Mythandros line for generations. The current Shining Radiant Monarch is Ayril Mythandros.

The Independent Peoples

The largest group of independent people are the Imba'nire Nation who live in the old-growth forest of the same name. The forest is in the northwest corner of Cavalero and though it is surrounded by imperial land it has long been independent. Outsiders apply labels such as nation-state, but the people of the Imba'nire have long resisted being defined by the terms of the wider world. They are who they are, and they live where they live.

The Imba'nire have strong relationships with their neighbors in Inlyrico to the east, and the Federation across a short causeway to the southwest. Only those who call the Imba'nire home spend much time in the depths of the massive forest. Visitors know to stay on the Adahy road, a simple route for overland trade that was created more than two centuries ago.

The Mehrdad'i people live primarily in the Byse Desert on the far south of the continent. The area is just as large as the Imba'nire forest, but the population is clustered around the beautiful oases that are sprinkled across the barren sands.

Mehrdad'i family lines trace back into ancient times when they would frequently travel the desert along trade routes. Since the opening of the Lattice, they have tended to live in large multi-family groups at the oases. They are generous with the beauty and bounty of their home, often hosting visitors from other lands who then fall in love with the striking landscapes and welcoming culture.

The Ereskial live under the Batterklast mountains in the center of Cavalero. They lay claim to very little surface land except the few areas where their cave entrances connect to the surface. Those on the surface primarily know the Ereskial for their wealth as the majority of the metal and gem deposits in Rues are in Ereskial territory. Within the culture, though, the Ereskial are master craftsmen, remarkable oracles, savvy traders, and disciplined soldiers.

There is one Ereskial surface city in the mountains, called Symonovsk, though its reputation among the Ereskial is troubled. It is inhabited mostly by naturalized Ereskial, as the majority of native Ereskial prefer to live underground. This city has the most direct entrance to Stovaresk, the most powerful secular Oracle in Rues.

The ship people of the Vascoll, though they are no longer counted among the peoples of Rues, have kept their connection to the great Alentina river in Khemera. At some signal known only among themselves, they will set out from their far-flung locations to converge on Khemere. They will stay for a few weeks, enjoying what appears to be an indulgent revel whilst trading with Rues natives. It is said to be so raucous that you can hear the singing from miles away.

During this revel, the Vascoll act as though they have known each other for their whole lives even if they have never even raised flags to each other before. They will leave as suddenly as they arrived, back on to the open waters that they love.

Everyday Life

Rues is a large, diverse land, and the intricacies of everyday life are different. Outside of Rues, the whole of the land is perceived to be an idyllic, legendary place, and most of the residents would find it hard to disagree. There may be some small pockets of Rues where times are troubled, but the nations and cultures are comfortable and easy in their golden age. Their great enemies have been defeated and all the dust from those many wars have settled. It is a place of peace, learning, and growth.

Most citizens of Rues have time for leisure activities and travel outside of their work. Day trips and holidays to other regencies or nations is not uncommon, and is easily managed thanks to the relationships forged and maintained by the Academy of Diplomats.

Current Events

The queen of Anbara has been reaching out to nations across the great ocean to arrange a multinational site and schedule for a special Alastair Games event, which would be the first games event to include nations that can only be reached by Lattice.

The bicentennial celebration of the first of many traditional marriages between the Empire of the Stinging Phoenix and the Federated Kingdom of the Selda'nire is approaching, and preparations have been ongoing for years. The centennial event was said to be a wonder, with both Heraldrics materializing from the shade in an awe-inspiring, dancing flight.

Notes for Players

Cultural Plot and Themes

Rues is definitely more of a background setting than a plot focus for Numina 3. Players of cultures within Rues should expect plot that pulls them away from home, and focuses on activities and problems in other parts of the world.

Rues is a land of legend and romantic story, and some people in the wider world are enamored with Rues history. Your character may expect to meet some wide-eyed excitement at the mere mention of their homeland... though sometimes that excitement is not accompanied by any knowledge of pertinent facts about Rues, such as the political intricacies of the nations and peoples.

Costume and RP Themes

The different cultures and nations within Rues each have unique preferences, traditions, and expectations. Being “from Rues” might look very different for one person than another. Depending on where in Rues a character is from, they might be more inclined to long, flowing garments or neo-georgian breeches and tri-corner hats.

Rues does not truly have a unifying heraldry, but it has been discovered that those outside recognize the symbol of the Academy of Diplomats as “the flag of Rues,” and it is simpler to just roll with this misconception. The unofficial heraldry of Rues, therefore, is a yellow or gold fleur-de-lis on a black field.

In one exception to the difficulty of identifying a person from the land of legends, Arcane Aspected people from Rues often present with angular black patterns on a red background which is unique to this area of the world.

Out of Game Note

Rues was the setting for the first two campaigns of Numina, when it was locked behind a magical barrier that cut it off from the world. Many momentous events happened there, and in the final act of the second campaign, the magical barrier was unlocked and Rues was reconnected to the rest of the world.

Players choosing to be from Rues should understand that Rues is unlikely to be a focus for any culture-related plot in Numina 3 because of its prominence in previous campaigns. The problems there are largely resolved, and the people who live there are still reaping the benefits of all of the work put in by the Heroes of Fortune's Bend.

Players who wish to begin the game with little experience or knowledge in the campaign world of N3 might consider Rues as their starting culture. It is also suitable for those players who are carrying over a character from previous campaigns, or those who choose to be a descendant of a former character.

Spyndelmere

When you hear of the land of Spyndelmere, it sounds like a storybook tale has come to life. The land is full of green hills, winding dirt paths, dark enchanted forests, crumbling towers forgotten by time, gallant heroes, and wise beings with sound advice. The land is also full of stories. The tales of Spyndelmere's four founding heroes twine together at the origin of the nation and promise happiness ever after for its citizens. In these first adventures are the origins of Spyndelmere's knights, rulers, enchanters, wanderers, and unexpected heroes. From them, modern residents have gleaned a vast array of traditions that honor the past and assure the continued happiness of their children and grandchildren.



Even though the rulership in the Compass Rose has grown stagnant and the Knight's Mark has not illuminated in some time, it is still possible for townsfolk to pretend that the Thorn Trees' shadows are not growing longer, and the sea is not rising on the stones, and that a strong heart will still win out over darkness. The creeping sense of discomfort is not too strong yet, and surely will lead only to another great adventure for ready heroes, full of tricks and turns, with a fine and satisfactory end. Somewhere among the orphans, tailors, apprentices, and sheltered noble children will be the ones who come along and make everything all right again.

Geography, History, and Climate

The footpaths and forests of Spyndelmere are interconnecting and vast. The Waxing Crescent forest lines the northern coast of the land, and provides the greater share of Spyndelmere's lumber. This forest is characterized by its sunny glades, flowering meadows, and idyllic trails, and is generally regarded as a friendly forest so long as one stays on the path.

On the southern coast, the Lockfall forest looms dark and grim over the nearby villages. Some lumber is gained here, but the prevalence of Thorn Trees and the ornery nature of the woods themselves have encouraged the locals to find other means of gaining resources. For all that it lacks in exports, the Lockfall is infamous in Spyndelmere for hosting a vast number of difficult-to-find components for casting and breaking curses. Mushroom gatherers and woodcutters live along the edges, but no Purposed folk live in the deepest parts of either forest.

In the high, uninhabitable parts of the Mistbound mountains lie mysterious valleys, fathomless lakes, and openings to the caves beneath. The sharp craggy eastern peaks soften as they roll westward, where villages begin to pockmark the landscape.

Spyndelmere's only big city is the capital, known as Thornwen. Embervale Castle sits as its centerpiece, a city itself within its walls. Those who call Embervale home know not to poke in the shadowed corners or to get lost in the maze of hallways. While they're supposed to be empty, wailing can sometimes be heard from the dungeons far below. The center spire is off limits to all but the most trusted. It is within the ancient halls of the castle that the current members of the Compass Rose and their families reside.

Alongside Embervale Castle is the stalwart Brumesward Citadel. When a Mark of the Knight appears on someone they go to Brumesward for the basic training they will need on their Path. Paths for knights are highly personalized, depending on the new knight's age and many other factors. The old fisherman who found the Rainbow Scaled Sea Slime may not want to disrupt her daily life, while the street urchin who is hit by a careless cartsman and whose mark comes after the bruise heals may have wished for nothing more.

The history of Spyndelmere begins with stories. Long ago, there were four adventurers who would end up bringing great prosperity to the land that would become Spyndelmere; Ignatia, Skylar, Nira, and Ferris. These four adventurers were the original members of the Compass Rose. Those who are said to be kindred of the Rose bear one of four marks related to the heroes of old known as the Mark of the Knight. The likenesses of the Original Compass Rose and their stories are immortalized within the Fernfallow Halls, along with others of great renown from the stories of Spyndelmere's colorful history.

Politics, Government, and Economy

From the lofty halls of Embervale Castle, the Four Regents of the Compass Rose watch over the land. Their emblem, a golden compass with a pink rose bloom at the center, tells the people that they are there to guide them in the right direction, even when hope seems distant and the way unsure. Regents are not chosen by the people but by the magic of the land itself, for when their Knight's mark burns bright, they know their time as Regent has begun and when the light fades, they must step down to make room for the new Regent. While the Regents tend to the stuffier parts of ruling, their children and grandchildren, the Princes and Princesses of the realm, wander the halls of the castle and do what they can to aid the people with daring deeds, tall tales, magic stories and of course balls and tournaments.

Most towns are guided by the gentle hands of the local Compass Coriander, who yield to the Compass Iris. Appointed by the Regents of the Rose, the seats of the Corianders and Iris are filled with others who bear the Mark. These officials



are on hand to tend to marriages, disputes, and minor magical mischief such as the baker who accidentally cursed the delivery boy with biting shoes so he would move faster. Of course in Spyndelmere, sometimes the magical mischief is out of control, and the Compass may call to rally the garrisons of the Knight's Guard.

The Guard is composed of those who bear a Knight's Mark and those who do not. A Rally Call is rare, and would usually only be heard when one of the morphoses is causing a stir. When a wildling bull knocks down a barn, or a free-fire sets light to a tavern, the Knight's Guard will be on hand to battle and to give aid.

It is considered an honor to have a Knight's Mark, certainly, but there is no social class division between those who have marks and those who do not. Many qualities are honorable in Spyndelmere, including the Knight's Mark, great wisdom, proficient curse breaking, and a well-known family title such as the Shadowseekers. In fact, social hierarchy in Spyndelmere mainly consists of the nation's belief in good noble royalty and steadfast, gallant knights.

Travelers to Spyndelmere come away remarking on something that the residents themselves hardly notice - their habitual, ingrained honoring of traditions. Some traditions, such as always walking a complete circle around any cluster of exactly seven dandelions, are known and common across the whole country. Others are localized to particular places based on which of the many tales are important, and which are less known.

Notable People:

Regent Berkeley Evers: Berkeley is the longest-serving regent in Spyndelmere's history. He bears Nira's mark, and it illuminated when he broke the Depthless Goblet at age twenty-four. Sixty years later, the glow has not faded and he still sits on the Compass. Berkeley is a compassionate, involved leader who has been forced to cut back on his activities due to age.

Regent Sage Ashfall: Sage is the youngest Regent on the Rose. Sage's mark, the one born by Ferris, illuminated only a couple of years ago. She bears the family title of Ashfall along with her siblings from their paternal grandmother, Linden Ashfall. Linden was also a Regent of the Rose and had hoped Sage would follow in her footsteps one day.

Louis Wenform: Embervale castle has always been the place where the ruling bodies of Spyndelmere resided. But there came a time when there was more needed than the castle and the grounds. And when that time came, someone was needed to step up and help tame the lands around the castle and plan the emerging city. Louis Tinker, as he was then known, decided to use some of his contraptions to help tame the wilds around Embervale. They were so effective that in short order the plans for Thornwen were laid and he was granted the title "Wenform" because without him and his devices the city could never have been built.

Agnes Shadowseeker: One of the great titles and places in the Fernfallow Halls, given in the last century, was to a woman originally known as Agnes Fletcher. She and her brother Oliver traveled into the southern forest with other Knight Guards in search of some pigs that were taken by unknown monsters. It is said the creatures she fought were twice as tall as the tallest

man, with fur the color of fire and eyes that were cast over with shadows. They were able to breathe lightning from their gaping jaws and had hands large enough to snatch away a large swine in one grab. The stories say she climbed atop a monster while Oliver distracted it and pierced it through the eyes with her daggers, collapsing the monster swiftly. The other monsters fled further into the forest after this, leaving behind most of the swine. It was at this time, unfortunately, they also kidnapped Oliver. While many of the swine and Oliver were never found, a whole herd worth was returned to their owners deftly. For this heroic deed and the loss of her brother, she was given the title and name of Agnes ShadowSeeker. This name has been passed onto her family and many know that those who bear the name ShadowSeeker should be held in high regard.

Everyday Life

Growing up in Spyndelmere, children often remember living in a plain, ordinary town wherein their own role as the Miller's Daughter, Orphan, or Hedge Witch's Son was unique. Traveling around, it seems impossible that any plain, ordinary towns truly exist, so it may be that this is all part of the magic of the realm. On a map, it seems clear that the great forests line the northern and southern edges of the country, and yet living in Spyndelmere it is known that following the mushroom path can get you there in short order, no matter your starting point.

The common folk of Spyndelmere often settle into a comfortable, happy routine. Jane Weaver's day at the loom or market is very different from Sam Hunter's daily trek into the forest looking for wildlife. In these routines, time is left for their dreams and aspirations. One common tale is that of Lilane Forestfell, descendant of Reese Forestfell the defender of Darkstone Manor (the one in the south), who spends her days studying sword play hoping that she will find the Path or that her Knight's Mark will appear. Most towns have their local wise people for odd cures and prophecies and because it is Spyndelmere, it is assumed that these wise ones spend their days gathering herbs or studying things only they can see.

One of the highest regarded professions are those of the mushroom farmers and gatherers; two very different but equally important jobs. Mushrooms are well known and liked within the community, for they represent the ability of the community to grow even when they have been struck down by daily life. Many enjoy eating a variety of mushrooms, and even those who do not will still adorn themselves with representations of the valued hearts of the country.

While Cremini mushrooms are farmed, mushroom gatherers use swine to find the wild fungi that appear sporadically within the land and its forests. A well trained swine is hard to come by and they are able to find mushrooms that can be sold for great value to Princes and Princesses of the land or exported. As such, it is a sign of great opulence to have a swine in one's household, and even more opulent for the swine to be a pet rather than a service animal.

Much like mushrooms are an integral part of the land, so too are the varieties of tea. Mushrooms are an ingredient in many teas, alongside various herbs and other elements. Spyndelmere teas are known to be used for something as simple as a beverage or as mystical as the gateway to another world.

Current Events

Rumors have been heard in taverns and inns across Spyndelmere.

"Be careful when walking in the forest, we've heard rumors that there are stranger than usual things going on. Some have whispered they were hit by multiple falling branches when there was no wind. Others can't seem to find any hunting."

"Oh, we know that only two of the Regents are active. One is said to have been called by the Path and hasn't come back yet, one caught some kind of illness. But the two sitting Regents are doing a fine job, we aren't worried."

"Morphoses are all around, more than usual, keep a sharp eye for the portents of mischief."

"I just came from the west. I heard a loud heartbeat near this little village. When sunup came, I investigated. It was completely abandoned, as if the townsfolk had got up and left in the middle of the night."

Notes for Players

Spyndelmere players should expect plot that is steeped with tropes from western/european fairy tales, plus a few outliers, but without any of the specific characters of those tales. In addition, a concerted effort has been made to ignore or change the poor stereotypes and gender roles that sometimes accompanied those early works. In Spyndelmere, we firmly believe that we can conjure the wonder and optimism of fairy tales without relying on the negative ideologies and suppositions that have too often gone hand-in-hand with the genre.

Players are encouraged to make up local traditions and superstitions for their home in Spyndelmere.

Ignatia's Tale

Once upon a time there was a low and hungry land, full of low and hungry people. Many of them were good people whose time and willingness to do good had been worn away. The rocky soil grew more miserly each year. The snows came earlier. The nights grew longer, and the night-hunters grew bolder.

In this low and hungry land lived a lonely farmer by the name of Ekrem. He sat by his fire each night, and wished that he might have a child to care for and who might help him with the difficult work of the stubborn farm.

One especially dark and cold night, a loud knock sounded at the farmer's door. Now, a wiser man would have ignored it, but Ekrem was known to be generous, not wise. The visitor was a bedraggled, stooped woman wrapped in a weatherworn cloak. Ekrem brought her into his home and gave her food, tea with traveler's honey, and the warmest place around the tiny fire. When he woke in the morning, she was gone.

The following night, as he once again sat near his pitiful fire, wishing that he might be warmer, the fire began to burn brighter. It was so warm and comfortable that he wished he might have a bit of sweetbread to enjoy. No sooner had he thought this than he realized that the poor crust of bread he had left on the plate by the fire had grown warm and soft.

He chewed it in great contentment, and watched the flames jump and whorl like dancers on a stage. The warmth of his skin and the fullness of his belly made him very sleepy. He watched one of the flames closely, one dancer. It looked like a young woman spinning and flourishing with joy. "I wish," he said, "that I had a child to care for." He fell asleep before he heard the fire answer him with "I wish that I was a girl."

So it was that on the very next day, he found Ignatia among the embers of the fire.

The farmer and the child spent every day together, and quickly grew to love one another. He cared for her, as he had always wished to, and she found great satisfaction in the hard work farming crops.

Even though she loved her father, Ignatia began to grow lonely as she got older. You see, she had wished to be a girl, but she was also still a fire. Her hair was dark like coal and smoke. Her skin was warm like cinnamon. Her eyes were golden-orange and flashing like a spark, and her touch was burning like a flame. She could not hug her father or pet a cat without wearing gloves to protect them from her fire.

One day as she worked the field nearest to the forest, she pulled up a carrot, but instead found a mushroom in her hand. She looked in shock at the next carrot and saw instead a trail of small glowing mushrooms. What wondrous little things! She followed them and soon found herself going deeper and deeper into the forest.

Deep in the woods, in a blue-green glade, she found a well-dressed young man in a chestplate and pauldrons, with his ankle trapped beneath a fallen thorn tree. Working the farm had made her quite strong, and she lifted the great trunk just enough for him to wiggle free. His steed, he said, had run away, and was the only one who knew the way back home. She laughed delightedly, and offered to lead him to the farm.

Now, a wiser prince would have said absolutely not, but Prince Esper was known to be open-hearted, not wise. He accompanied the fire woman back to her home, and on the long walk they had many adventures, and fell deeply in love with each other.

Ekrem the farmer welcomed Prince Esper as though he were family, and the three of them worked the farm for a full season before the prince revealed who he was, and that he must seek his home. He asked if Ignatia would accompany him.

She enthusiastically agreed before thinking of her father, and the hard work of the farm. Ekrem waved her onward, though, and she and the prince promised that they would return after Esper's neglected business was tended to. Little did any of them know that this promise could never be kept.

During the winter while Prince Esper and Ignatia stayed at the castle, a terrible illness took the valley, and took Ekrem with it. Both of them were heartbroken at his loss, and it only increased their longing to embrace and comfort each other. This they could not do, though, because the Prince was still as susceptible to her burning touch as any other.

Once winter passed, they vowed that they would find a way to hold each other. Ignatia told Esper the story of how she came to be, and they agreed that they would try to seek out the old woman. Surely, she would be able to help them.

The lovers wandered the land in search of the enchanter. They risked the depths of the Grickleback forest, and the heights of the Mistbound mountains. It was deep in the Studded Cavern that they found her. She was just as Ekrem had described, stooped over a bubbling cauldron, wearing a weatherworn cloak clasped with a metal mushroom.

The enchanter welcomed the travelers, and listened to their story as though she did not already know it. When they had finished, and pleaded for her help, she told them the same thing that she had whispered to Ignatia's sleeping father so many years ago. "I can give you what you wish for, but it brings a price beyond my control."

And like her father, they eagerly agreed. Whatever the price, they were sure it was one they could bear. The enchanter gifted them a small object, a trinket of no remarkable qualities. "Hold this," she instructed Esper, "and you may choose to take on an element as well. Wish for it, and it will be so."

The lovers thanked her, and rushed aboveground to use the trinket and embrace each other for the first time. After a hurried conversation, the young lovers made their choice. Esper held the trinket and stared with excitement into Ignatia's eyes. "I wish to be air," he said aloud.

In a moment, it was so. He was still the prince, but he was also air. His hair was cooling colors like the evening sky. His skin was white like the refracted sun. His eyes were pale grey like the springtime clouds, and his touch was light and wondrous like wind. A sort of quiet whistling sound came from him, as the whirling air passed over the space between his chestplate and pauldrons.

Overjoyed now, the lovers embraced at last. Ignatia found that finally she could pour out all that love through her strong arms, and hold on as tightly as she wanted. Esper felt elation, a powerful updraft of joy that left him dizzy and his heart pounding. Air did not burn, and so they could touch.

Ignatia only realized something was horribly wrong when she heard his strangled gasp. Her burning touch had turned to fire that blazed off her shoulders, raging with great strength as it

consumed the sudden gift of air. They both realized their mistake, but it was too late. Ignatia released her lover and jumped back in horror. As his apparently empty clothing and chestplate clattered to the ground, she heard his voice one last time. "EARTH," he cried out hoarsely.

From that day on, Ignatia and the Blooming Prince were together always. And then, when the prince's mother passed on, the two ruled together until their own deaths, wisely and with much heart. Children were born to them. They traveled many places, made the greatest of friends and allies, and had many adventures. The trinket that had caused them so much pain was eventually lost. Their subjects would claim that the king and queen knew all of them by name, and would sing of their generosity, and the love they bore for each person and animal in their demesne.

It was almost so. But truly, there was one that they could not make space in their hearts for, and that was the old enchanter who had given them the trinket. They blamed her for what had befallen them, and perhaps that blame was well placed. The ways of the morphose are their own.

When they passed, a memory stone to each was erected near where the southern forest touches the mountains. Around the stones, there is scorched earth surrounded by lush blooms of every flower from the meadow and the garden. The stones exact location has been lost to time, but legend says that by their request, a last curse upon the enchanter was carved into the rock.

Ferris' Tale

Hello there, friend. Come this way. I wish to tell you the tale of how Ferris found his path. Much of his story is well known, but the further we get along the more cobwebbed it gets as many people cannot agree with the exact details as it goes on.

Ferris had a childhood like many children. He lived with his mother and grandmother in a small fishing village to the north of the Dark Forest. He spent much of his childhood playing with his friends and learning to cook with his grandmother. His favorite pastime, though, was sailing the water with his mother. When he was out in the strait on their boat with the wind sweeping through his hair, he felt the most alive. His mother taught him how to feel the temperature of the water, follow the currents and read the wind. During the hottest days of the summer, they would sit on the rocks overlooking the water and search for crabs and other critters to bring back to his grandmother.

In the evenings, while his mother was resting from her long day fishing, Ferris would help his grandmother make dinner. Dinner was a family affair, and they always had someone over for the meal. While his grandmother had the shortest temper out of everyone in the village, there was never any doubt about her loyalty to the village and its people. When she wasn't helping his mother around the home, she was out in the village helping others who needed it. Whether it be tending their garden, or patching up an injury, she stayed busy throughout the day. In the evening, come dinner, she would always bring home someone who she helped earlier in the day.

His mother on the other hand, knew many people but mostly kept to herself. Though the day she was out on the water fishing and trading her goods across the strait. She worked hard and kept the family afloat by providing where she could. When he was with his mother, she seemed to have endless patience for him and all his questions. Each question he asked she would hold him close and wave her work-worn hands and everything would suddenly make sense. He never felt he had to question the love she exuded for him out of every pore.

On the outskirts of the village resided The Path. The Path was a well-known walking road which traveled into the forest. Ferris knew traders would go there and come from there throughout the day. The Path itself was lined with small mushrooms. He always remembered being so enthralled by the glow of them that his mother would let him poke them and feel their textured skin as a toddler. It was at this age he was taught he should never get too close to the forest at night where there was no path. The mushrooms were said to be placed by someone generations before and helped ward the path by soaking sunlight and holding the light until nightfall. The areas without the mushrooms were dangerous areas where monsters of the night could reach out and grab you and you would be gone before anyone would even notice.

During the summer Ferris was finally taller than his mother, he noticed the rustling of leaves from the edges of the forest any time he would go near. The noise made him nervous, for at this age he knew better than to go towards the forest. He had lost at least a couple of youngling friends to the forest previously. They were gone, without a trace and never to be seen again. He spoke to his mother about it only to be greeted with a horrified look and a quickly placed warning to never to get too close. He was safe here, safe near the water. The water would keep him safe. It was this summer that his mother taught him more about her trade. More about how she moved the water, lived with the water and controlled the water. It was this summer he began to learn about magic.

Learning that you could control nature around you with nothing but your will was enlightening for Ferris. It was a simple form of magic. His mother did not know much and wasn't able to show him anything powerful, but he did learn to feel the earth and water around him. Any time he asked his mother where she learned this, she would simply tell him that when she needed it the most, it came to her like a breath of fresh air. As his knowledge of magic began to grow, so did the noise at the edge of the forest. After a whole summer of hearing rustling, his mother began to get more and more cautious about going outside.

During the winter of that year, his mother caught a sickness that was plaguing the village. People would suddenly get sick; their skin would feel like fire and their lungs would expel a dark substance. It was said it came into the village after a strange man came to visit from the forest who had similar symptoms. Unable to fight off the mysterious sickness, his mother was lost at the end of winter. As Ferris mourned with his grandmother at the foot of his mother's pyre, the sounds from the forest began to turn into a more recognisable sound. Slowly sounding more and more like a voice. A voice telling him to come into the forest, promising safety and wealth beyond measure.

After his mother's passing, his grandmother's health began to wane. No matter what they did, she was not getting any better. It was only a few years after his mother's passing that his grandmother also passed, her heart broken from seeing her only child pass before she did. The same day his grandmother passed, the voices stopped. Ferris knew loneliness for a whole moon-cycle before a man came to the edge of the forest. It was said he walked out of the darkest part of the forest and seemed to be made of the trees themselves. They say he had skin made of leaves and hair of thorns. His eyes were closed and never opening. He waited at the edge of the forest, never moving for days, until someone asked what he wished for. "Ferris," he said, his voice sounding like wood scraping against itself. It took two days for Ferris to gather the courage to speak to the man. When Ferris finally got the courage to speak to him, the Man Made of Leaves told him his father had been looking for him for years. His mother stole him away as a child, and hid him from his father.

This brought Ferris pause, his mother never liked to speak of his father. What he was told was his father lived far away and left his mother to die while she was with child because his father had wanted to keep the child from inheriting anything. Could it be that his mother had lied to him, for his whole life? The Man Made of Leaves was clever though, always interrupting Ferris' thoughts and assured him that he would be welcomed with open arms into his father's land and that his father loved him unconditionally. What followed was a week of the Man Made of Leaves telling fantastical tales of the forest and its beauty as he tried to convince Ferris to leave the village. As he spun his tales, the village came to sit, listen and became enthralled. As the man made of leaves started to run out of tales, the village began to tell tales of their own. Many of which Ferris had never heard of before. Speaking how strange his mother and grandmother were, how unlike the rest of them they were. The elders spoke about how suddenly they came into the village with a small child, strangely alone and unwilling to speak of the past.

Ferris listened to the great stories during the day, and went home at night only accompanied by the cold loneliness of the loss of his family. After a week of listening to the stories of the Man Made of Leaves, Ferris decided to head into the forest to meet his father. His long-lost father who yearned to meet his missing child. Ferris turned his head away from the water and stepped over the treeline following the Man Made of Leaves and disregarding everything his loving mother had taught him through his life thus far.

The trek through the forest was not an easy one for Ferris. His legs were strengthened for water and not for land. Within the dark forest, Ferris was unable to tell the passage of time as sunlight did not leak through the dense forest canopy. He relied heavily upon the sound of the rustling leaves of his guide as Ferris made his way along. It could have been a day-long walk, or a week-long trek, but Ferris felt that it lasted forever. The brambles along the forest floor scraped his legs and feet tearing his clothing as he went along. He stumbled often, falling to his knees only to be picked up by the Man Made of Leaves and pushed to continue. His legs ached, bled and threatened to give out but he continued his march towards his father's home. He kept telling himself that this was for his family, this was for his future.

Eventually, his eyes adjusted to the darkness just as he reached a glade within the forest. His eyes settled upon a shallow well in the middle of the area. As Ferris stepped into the glade, he found that the ground in the glade was covered in soft grass which felt like a blessing upon his battered feet. He fell to his knees, weary of his travels. When he looked skyward, he realized he did not see any light. No clouds, no stars or moon. Where the sky should be, he only saw darkness. Turning towards his guide for assurance, the man gestured him forwards before rapidly decaying into a pile of dirt. Ferris scrambled back in horror. As he stumbled to his feet and turned around he was greeted with the sight of a tall looming man, his eyes glowing yellow in the darkness. He spoke in a deep timbre, "Welcome back, son." He offered Ferris a hand, pulling him to his feet. With a wave of his other hand, the glade changed.

Before him now was a small stone tower house, which looked incongruous in the middle of the forest. The building was barely taller than the trees and looked so very new with its white stone and freshly cut wood work. It housed a small door that looked steeped in such a way that caused your vision to trail towards the pinnacle at the top. His father pulled him towards the house, slowly helping him along. The building seemed to start leaning one direction as Ferris walked up upon it, causing his vision to spin and blur the closer he got to it. His father placed a hand upon the door and welcomed Ferris into the building. The room was round on the inside with a fire roaring in the back. A stark contrast to the cold darkness of the forest. His father eased him into a chair, bringing him food and tending to his wounds. As he ate, his father spun him the tale of lovers gone awry. His father loved his mother deeply, only to have her turn her back upon him during a time of great need. When Ferris inquired about the story further, his father explained that he was still quite young, and he would explain more when he was a bit older. Ferris learned that his father was a magic user of the forest, deeply in tune with what he called the 'true nature of the forest'. He grew up in his own village and eventually traveled into the forest to learn of its beauty and nature. What many would call dark and revolting, he called inviting and incredible.

For many days Ferris spent time with his father, learning about his father's past and how he lived when he was barely Ferris' age now. They spoke over tea and soup, enjoying each other's company. Ferris was never able to tell when it was day or night, so his father informed him of such each morning. For the first few weeks his father would take him outside in the morning and teach him a bit about the forest and gather food. Ferris learned which plants were edible, which ones were poisonous, and which ones would help him find his way home. In the evening, his father would leave him home alone to go hunting. Over the next few weeks Ferris was with his father, his health began to wane. It started with his vision, just like when he first arrived. Everything slowly grew blurry and unfocused before going dark. His father assured him it was a temporary feeling of being within the darkness of the forest, and would soon pass and lighten. As the days grew on, his legs began to grow numb. He was assured again it was just because he was not out on the water all the time, his legs were adjusting. When he began to lose feeling of his fingers, Ferris began to feel paranoid about his choice to go into the forest.

Ferris was forced into the seclusion of his room, his newly-acquired father placing him on bedrest to recuperate. One day, after Ferris' father had bought him his tea and soup and left,

Ferris found a funny shaped mushroom in his soup. It was at this moment he decided he was not hungry and poured the food out the window near his bed. As the liquid touched the beautiful wood of the windowsill, it promptly burned into the surface, turning it a muddy blackened sludge. He began to remember things his mother told him about staying away from the forest and the darkness within. Ferris then made the decision not to eat for two days, which angered his father. His father told him he needed to eat to get better and would often slam the door on his way downstairs when Ferris refused to eat. Slowly, over the course of those couple days, Ferris began to feel better. His hands stopped tingling and he began to gather strength in his legs again. When his vision came to him, so did the realization that the food was the cause of his illness and this became his new grief. His father had been poisoning him.

Over the next few days kept his eyes closed and his legs immobile as much as he could while his father was nearby, though he continued not to accept any food from his father. For the rest of the week, each morning his father would head out to gather food, just like before, and then bring it to him a short time later. Ferris learned that this time in between the visits was his chance to practice walking again. The days began to pass and Ferris used these next days to strengthen his legs. However, he began to grow more and more hungry. At the end of the week, while his father was gone, Ferris decided to sneak down stairs carefully. He didn't think he could last much longer without food. He headed towards the cellar door with the single thought of stealing some food. He opened the door and slowly crept down the stairs, only to find there was no food in the stores. No matter where he looked, everything was empty. He could have sworn the cupboards were filled to the brim only last week.

Ferris began moving empty crates in the pantry to search behind and around in frustration. It was in this fit of desperation that Ferris discovered a door hidden behind a shelf. Its wood looked new and freshly carved, just like the rest of the house. Inspecting the carving, he found it to be a rendition of a withered tree with a woman sleeping below it in a puddle of water. With his stomach still rumbling, Ferris pushed on the door in hope of finding food. Opening the door was a task within itself, due to the loss of his strength over the last week. Peering in, he saw nothing within the room. He stepped in trying to get a better look and found that the room felt as if he walked into a pool of cold water. His skin pricked causing him to shiver. It was in this moment he heard steps behind him. He turned around quickly only to see his scowling father pulling the door shut with a slam.

As the door rattled it's foundations Ferris' vision warped and changed drastically. The newly carved woodwork of the door began to wither and rot, the stones cracking and falling from their perch on the wall. As Ferris reached for the door and wrenched it open, he found the door to have been suddenly bricked shut on the other side. With no way out, Ferris turned in fear only to find the whole building to have changed around him. No longer was the space completely empty, but half collapsed, covered with dirt and a shallow well in the middle. The same well he saw upon entering the glade. He collapsed against the door feeling defeated; he was alone once again.

When Ferris found he had no more tears to cry he slowly lowered the rest of his body to the floor, lying upon the grime that now resided upon the once clean surface. His eyes stared unblinking towards the wall ahead of him. With each passing moment despair wound tighter around his heart. How was he supposed to escape this new anguish.? He was betrayed, by someone who was supposed to love him unconditionally. He thought back to his mother and grandmother whom he had also turned his own back on. Was this the world's way of condemning him for abandoning his family's memory? For turning his back on his mother and the water that protected her? Ferris closed his eyes and willed away his ability to be in the land of the awake. Hoping and praying this was all just a nightmare.

Ferris was pulled awake by the stabbing pain of his hunger some time later reminding him of how he got into this current situation. He stared blindly at the stone ceiling hoping something would happen. Nothing did. Eventually, Ferris pulled himself up just enough to use his arms to crawl towards the well in the middle of the room. His arms felt as heavy as stone as he pulled himself forwards with the last of his strength. His legs were barely able to move to help with the movement. His breath was ragged by the time he moved a few feet to the well. With great effort, he managed to get up above the lip of the well only to find the well Filled to the brim with crystal clear water. He reached his hand eagerly as water was better than nothing. As he reached his fingers out to touch the water, this strength began to give out and instead of scooping the liquid out, his hand splashed against the surface creating severe ripples. He braced himself with both hands on the lip of the well, trying to regain his balance. Bringing his eyes back up to the water's surface he was startled back as a face met his gaze. He fell backwards off of the well and back onto the dusty ground.

He found himself staring at the ceiling once again. Ferris took a deep breath upon realizing nothing, or rather no one, came out after him. With similar effort as before, he hauled himself back up to the well's edge to see who was under the water. His vision spun for a moment when his eyes met with his mother's eyes. As the vision in the water continued, he saw his mother speaking to him as a small child. The memory came flooding back to him as he watched. She spoke that his father was a being of the deep forest and held great power over the trees, bending them to his will. When he had realized Ferris' mother was with the child, he was enraged. Only his own child could take his powers. For once the forest accepted his child as its own, all the powers the forest had granted him would be transferred to his child Instead. His mother bowed her head to kiss his hair as she reminded him once again to never go near the forest. It was at this moment in the vision that the well then showed Ferris the ritual his father had used to bind himself to the trees. Ferris now knew what he had to do to survive.

Unfortunately, my friend, this is where the story begins to turn to wisps in the wind. The truth of how this was completed was lost to time, but all agree that this process brought Ferris great physical pain as the earth molded itself within his person. It's even said that Ferris himself never spoke of what exactly took place for him to tie himself to the trees and take his father's powers. Many tales agree that Ferris then used this new found power to tunnel his way out of the cellars and under the forest as the tower that his father created crumbled around him.

Ferris traveled through these tunnels he made under the forest until he found himself lost within the caverns of the mountains to the east. It was within this cave that Ferris found nutrients in the form of mushrooms. All along the inside of the cave were large outcroppings of grey mushrooms with a soggy flavor that sustained him for many days as he tried to find his way out. Some scholars assume these were a type of oyster mushroom as they are commonly found in the caves of the Mistbound mountains now.

Ferris was not safe yet though, for the way through the caves was twisting and unrelenting within its depths. Ferris lived in the dark for ages unknown. While he was able to move dirt through the ability of the trees, there was nothing he could do against stone. Ferris had not seen any monsters within the caves, but the dark began to seep into his mind creating things in the shadows. Whispers from the dark spoke to him and beckoned him to hide himself away. Stay hidden, stay safe, don't let the things of the darkness find you. Come to us. This way. Deeper. Deeper. Ferris soon began to lose himself as his mind started to leave him all together and wander away to follow the whispers. It was another age before he was saved from the darkness by an unsuspecting cause.

It was deep within these depths that Ferris eventually found a man trapped. With that little mind Ferris had left he realized the desperate shouting he had begun hearing was not in fact the strange whispers but a man trapped in the caves. Ferris rushed to his side, only to find that the man was stuck under what appeared to be a cave in. The man at this time, upon seeing Ferris stopped shouting for help and fell silent. Ferris desperately began to dig the man out, his mind solely focused on saving him. He had to save this man, he would not let him die down here. This place was not a place for anyone to be. His hands ached and bled from moving all the rubble by himself. He had to save him. He had to. Eventually, Ferris was able to pull the trapped man free and see that he was gravely injured. He found that the man, while no longer conscious, was at least still alive. He dug through the man's pack quickly looking for something to help. He ended up finding cooking supplies and many herbs that he recognized. He began immediately on cleaning the wounds and creating a poultice to help stave off infection. Through his powers, Ferris was able to stretch the meager amount of herbs the man had into copious amounts. This was undoubtedly what helped save the man's life.

After many sleepless nights, when he was sure the man was in the clear, he began cooking his first hot meal since he had eaten with his father. While it was barely more than a plain mushroom stew with simple herbs, it invigorated him so suddenly his mind began rushing to him in full force. It was as if the sun was just rising over the treetops and his memories began accumulating like dew on the leaves in the morning. How could he have forgotten? How could he have gotten lost from his path again? His heart ached from the loss.

The man eventually recovered enough for the two of them to make their way out of the caves. The man was a mushroom hunter and had come down into the caves in search of a mysterious mushroom said to help cure those who were cursed and sold for a lofty amount. This was not the first time the man had been down here and had marked his path and the two of them were able to follow these markings back out of the cave. They reached the surface as the sun was

setting and they camped just outside the entrance. It was at this moment the Mushroom Hunter gifted Ferris a trinket for his help in saving his life and spoke of the small mushroom farming village that he was from, explaining the exact path they would take tomorrow to get there. Ferris and the man then fell asleep under the stars, dreaming of better days.

The next morning, the sun shone its warm rays over the treetops and onto sleeping Ferris. He woke to a calming feeling as he opened his eyes... Only to find his new friend gone, and his belongings left behind. Ferris searched for ages to find his new friend but was unsuccessful. With dismay, Ferris gathered up all the belongings and headed towards the village the mushroom hunter had spoken about in depth. With luck, Ferris found it easily due to the instructions the man spoke of the night before. However, when Ferris spoke about this man to the village, the villagers were shaken with surprise for the man had passed away months prior due to a similar accident Ferris spoke of. Even stranger still, before the man had passed, he had left his home and his belongings to a neighbor with an unopened note that was addressed to Ferris himself.

No one knows what was in the note, but it is said that this village is where Ferris finally settled down happily and eventually found his calling as a healer; keeping all those who traveled to him healthy and happy with his magic and knowledge of the nature around him.

Friends, now that you know the tale of Ferris, let this be a lesson to you. Be sure you keep reminders of those you care about to ground you to their memory. Never follow strange people into the forest. Be sure you check your food for poison by using wooden utensils or sticks. Keep herbs on you, just in case you are the one that needs to be healed later. And always, always don't believe whispers you cannot see the source of.

Skylar's Tale

Once upon a time there was a child named Skylar whose parents were always working and never seemed to have time for them. It wasn't that Skylar's parents didn't take care of them or love them. It was more that they were so busy taking care of Skylar's worldly needs that they never seemed to have time to do things like play games or read stories or sing songs or any of the other things Skylar desperately wanted to do.

So while Skylar's parents were off working hard to provide a good life for the whole family, Skylar would explore the nearby woods. Everyone said that many strange things happened in the woods, both wonderful and terrible; but those fanciful stories are what drew Skylar into the woods instead of wandering around the town and playing with the other children where it was safe and known.

Over the days that turned to weeks then to months then beyond, Skylar ventured further and further into the forest. As Skylar ventured they learned important lessons. Like which tracks to follow to find the rabbits, which ones lead to the deer, which ones lead to the good berry bushes or the tasty mushrooms. But also things like where the hunter's traps were, how to unsnare the animals that were caught, how to set traps for the overly greedy hunters.

The more time Skylar spent in the woods, the more time they felt like they were a part of them. Skylar's parents didn't notice the subtle changes to their child or more they didn't place any more importance on the changes than Skylar growing up. The shifting of their eyes to green, the darkening of their hair, all things that helped Skylar blend with the forest, but also showed the impact the forest was having on Skylar.

One day, Skylar was following a trail into one of the deeper parts of the forest that they had never visited before when they came across the most fantastic mushroom they had ever seen. It had a faint glow in the darkening woods. Skylar wasn't sure what made them keep going along the path that seemed to open before them and close behind except that those glowing mushrooms seemed to be leading somewhere. It felt to Skylar as if the forest wanted to share a secret. Finally after criss-crossing, switch backing, Skylar was very turned around but there seemed to be a large clearing ahead of them.

When Skylar finally was able to see what was in the clearing, their breath caught. There was a large lake, surrounded by trees on all sides. Spanning the lake was a magnificent bridge with multiple points skimming the water only to rise gracefully again to the sky. And what was even more spectacular was the forest path had emptied Skylar out to very near one of the two points the bridge met the shoreline of the lake.

As Skylar approached the bridge, they knew instinctively that there would be no going back once they began to cross the bridge. That realization made them stop and look around. There was nothing in the forest that seemed out of place other than the bridge itself. And then Skylar realized, there was no sound of wildlife around this lake. The light breeze that shifted their hair didn't disturb the water either. So Skylar did the only logical thing a young person would do, they approached the lake and looked into the depths.

The stillness of the surface made the lake reflect the world like the most perfect mirror. Upon closer inspection Skylar realized that something wasn't quite right about the reflection. Like the bridge across the lake was made of wood, but the one in the reflection seemed to be covered in flowering vines. The sky seemed purple in shade in the reflection versus the bright blue of the current sky. Then Skylar looked at themselves, the image was them but not. Almost a more extreme version of what they already looked like. Sharper angles in the face, darker hair, greener eyes, slimmer build even what could almost be called tattoos that looked like leaves and vines. More like a spirit of the forest. And that is when Skylar understood, crossing the bridge could bring about changes, they might be what was reflected in the lake, but maybe not because reflections can change with as little as a puff of wind.

Skylar approached the bridge again, excited yet scared for what would follow if they crossed. They stopped at the base where there was a small plaque.

Be warned ye who pass this point. Reflections can give you a different point of view but they can also change you. Should you cross the Pool of Reflection, you will be changed; maybe for

the good, maybe for the worse. What you make of the Reflections that are brought to you as you cross will guide your change.

Skylar wondered if they should continue. What they would leave behind would be loving, though absent, parents but they never really understood Skylar or felt like family. What was ahead was the unknown, but wasn't that life in general? After reflecting on what would be left versus what could be achieved, Skylar began their journey across the bridge.

At each point where it skimmed the surface of the water, Skylar was given a hard puzzle to ponder about their life; like why they had gone into the woods originally and what did they wish for themselves. At each peak, they were shown what could happen given various choices in life and how things could have led them away from being at this bridge at this time in their life.

As Skylar reached the other shore, they knew that they were not the same person that they had been when they started across the bridge. As they looked back at the bridge there was another plaque:

Be aware, you have crossed the bridge. While you can go back to the beginning you will never be the same as when you first laid step on the bridge. Every time you cross the bridge you must reflect on your decisions and be changed by those reflections.

Skylar looked around where they were, and while the lake still looked the same, something felt different. So they followed the path in the woods that opened before them, marked by the magnificent mushroom, and left the forest. When the path emerged from the forest Skylar realized they weren't anywhere near their home town. But deep down they knew that didn't matter anymore. They were not the same scared and lonely child that had originally taken refuge in the forest so many years before.

So Skylar decided to see where life would take them and adventure. Using the lessons they learned in the Pool of Reflection, Skylar did what they could to help those in need. One day while walking between towns and wishing for more adventure, Skylar saw one of the fantastic mushrooms at a fork in the path. Remembering what had happened the last time they had followed the mushrooms, Skylar eagerly took the fork in the road.

The path again was full of twists and turns and there was little way for Skylar to know exactly where they were going, but they were filled with anticipation at what would be at the end of the path. One thing that they noticed was that the path seemed to be going uphill. Strange since the mountains were far away from where they had been traveling. Skylar knew better though, this would not be the first time they had been in one portion of the land they called home and then found themselves in another. The difference was, Skylar had never delved into the trails in the mountains. Strange things happened in the mountains, stranger than a person changing bridge or glowing mushrooms guiding you along the way. Skylar had heard tales of people going into the caves that dotted the mountain side and never returning. Or worse, those who did return from brief stints in the caverns and reporting back the misshapen things that they found there,

or the magical forces they felt, sometimes there were even tales of the mystical beings that were said to live in the deep grottos of the mountains or the darkest sections of the forest.

While the forest and all of its inhabitants didn't scare Skylar, something about going into the mountains sent a shiver through their veins. Skylar was stubborn though, once they had set their mind to do something they usually did it. And they had set their mind to follow the path that the mushroom had started them on.

Further up through the wooded mountain side, the shadows grew colder and deeper. There was something around them that wasn't quite the normal feel of the woods they were used to. Then ahead, not on the path, but up an incline, a glowing mushroom. Their excitement began to build as they scrambled their way to it and crested a small hill on the mountainside. Then the excitement drained into dread when they looked in the gully below them.

Cornered by the most enormous boar Skylar had ever seen were two children, maybe 10 or 11 in age. One boy, his face caked with mud, his knees bloody. One girl, the ribbon around her waist torn, the hem of her petticoat in tatters, the ringlets of her hair adorned with leaves instead of ribbons. The children were holding hands and facing the beast in front of them. The boar, pawing at the ground, looked as if it were about to charge the two children. Skylar didn't know what to do, if the boar ran for the children, one or both of them would be grievously injured if not killed; but if Skylar made a noise it might spook the animal into charging them anyway. There was no guarantee that Skylar could get the animal to charge towards them and not the children.

Then something glinted in the sparse sunlight making its way through the canopy of the trees. On the hoof the boar was pawing at the ground with, something shiny was sticking from the fur covered flesh. Then a flash of color waved by the animal's hoof, matching the girl's tattered belt but mud soaked so it was hard to make out. And it wasn't caught in the hoof, no, as Skylar looked closer, they saw that the ribbon was tied in a way to make the glinting item push further into the poor animal's leg.

Then Skylar saw the other hand of the boy, the one that wasn't holding the girl's. There was a dagger in it. Normally, Skylar would have thought that the dagger would be no match for any boar, much less one of the size in front of them, but there was something about the glint in the eye of the boy as he watched the boar paw at the ground with its injured foreleg that made them wonder.

Without a second thought, Skylar drew their bow as the children crouched to run. They notched an arrow as the children jumped to start. Loosed the arrow as the children began to run at the boar. And as the boy brought the dagger to bear, fear in the boar's eyes, the arrow knocked the dagger from the boy's grip.

Shocked at the unexpected attack, the children whipped their heads around to see where the arrow had come from. But Skylar knew better and as soon as they had loosed the arrow had

begun the swift descent into the gorge where the boar and children were. Notching another arrow, aimed at the girl, Skylar approached the group, their breath fast with anticipation.

“Leave now, and no harm will come to you,” Skylar stated with more resolve than they actually felt. They weren’t sure they could actually fire at children to harm, even if it appeared they were not innocent.

“This is our kill, we trapped it fair and square,” the girl’s voice was uncommonly deep for one so young. Skylar looked closer into her eyes and a fierce realization hit them, this was no ordinary girl. A swift look at the boy’s eyes confirmed their suspicions. They had heard of twinlings, marked by the matching star shapes at the corner of their eyes. Creatures of the deep parts of the mountains and woods that always appeared in pairs. Twinlings were known to change a person and then hunt them for sport. The sport only ending when either the twinlings or the changed had been destroyed.

Skylar had to think fast or they too might be changed and hunted. Then they remembered some of the stories about twinlings. They could only kill a changed one with one weapon: the dagger that Skylar had knocked out of the boy’s hand. They could see it glinting nearby. A quick dive and roll would get them to it, but how to do the move without alerting the twinlings before it was started.

The boar must have known what Skylar was thinking, or it was tired of waiting because at that moment it decided to run around Skylar and at the twinlings. The distraction was enough for Skylar to dive, roll and scoop up the dagger and get back on their feet facing the twinlings.

“Give us our dagger little one,” the boy said sweetly, “or suffer the consequences,” he finished with a much deeper tone. But there was one other thing that Skylar had remembered about twinlings when they had remembered about their weapon. They were defeated by cutting their link to each other as much as they were defeated by killing one of them.

Slowly, so as not to arouse suspicion in the twinlings, Skylar moved towards them, dagger out as if they were going to hand it to the twinlings. As they approached, Skylar noticed that around the wrists of the linked hands of the twinlings, was a ribbon that matched the color of the one around the boar’s leg. That HAD to be the link that needed to be cut. As soon as they were close enough, Skylar swiftly flicked the dagger between the ribbon and the linked hands of the twinlings.

A shriek to bring down the mountains around them echoed through the air from the throats of the twinlings. They clutched their now burning ribbons around their wrists, trying to put out the flames but to no avail. The shriek continued until the fire engulfed them and all that was left was ash in the leaf litter. Rattled by the result of cutting the link, because the stories didn’t mention the death of the twinlings or the sound they would make, Skylar looked at the boar. It pawed the ground delicately with its injured hoof.

Slowly Skylar approached the boar, but it didn't charge them or run. Shoring up their courage, Skylar knelt by the large animal and looked closer at the injured leg. The glinting item that they had seen was a blade, the twin of the dagger in their hand, but had a ribbon tied to the hilt and around the leg, making it dig deeper with every step the animal took.

Not sure if it was more for their sake or the boar's, Skylar said "this is going to hurt but I am going to remove it. I need you to stay put so I can bandage the wound after I remove the blade." Skylar thought they saw the boar, the changed they reminded themselves, nod. Maybe, some intelligence remains, Skylar thought. But they had delayed long enough, it was time to unwind the ribbon and remove the blade.

As soon as the blade was freed, the boar danced away from Skylar, a sound that was unidentifiable coming from its throat. And then, something else happened. The boar shifted to its hind quarters, then stood on its back feet. And were its front legs elongating? Was the snout shortening? The tusks were definitely gone. Within a few blinks of their eyes, Skylar was no longer looking at a boar, but an old woman, covered in the hide of a boar, her long grey dress dusting the forest floor.

Stunned, Skylar just stood there. The old woman spoke. "Thank you dearie. Those two had been chasing me for so long. I didn't think I would ever be free." The old woman picked up the dagger that had been in her arm from where it had been dropped and handed it to Skylar. "You did well, you know. Seeing below the surface of what was there." A knowing look passed in her eyes, "You learned the lesson of the Pool well: that not all is always what it seems on the surface. Sometimes you have to look beyond the surface to find the truth. Remember that as life takes you on its course. It will serve you well. Now, take these daggers, and use them for good. They are but mere trinkets, but you never know what they could bring you." The old woman looked as if she were about to leave and then turned back to Skylar, "your adventures are not over yet dearie. What you wish for, a family that understands and loves you, will come to you. But make sure that you take the lessons you have learned to heart or you might destroy the very thing you want most."

And with that, the old woman walked away and faded into the mist that suddenly surrounded the gorge. Skylar looked at the two matching blades in their hands and didn't know what to think. For sure, the future would be interesting. Now they just had to find a way out of the mountainside forest.

Of note, while Nira is an essential and honored founder, the specifics of her tale have been lost to time.

Cultural Plot and Themes

Growing up or living in Spyndelmere means coming to terms with the idea that anyone you are speaking to could be an enchanter, a monster, a transformed animal, or a charmed inanimate

object. Most of them are just people, of course, but you just never know. That is why a greeting of looking a person in the eye for a few seconds followed by a head bow is commonplace. Similarly, any unfamiliar objects might have a consciousness of some kind. Most don't, but one can never be too careful.

Curses, personal villains, and family secrets are welcome aspects of character histories and are likely to be encountered as part of cultural plot.

There will also be plot elements regarding the slowly growing sense that something just isn't quite right, something that threatens the things that make Spyndelmere unique, and make its inhabitants assured of a happy ending. Some elements of Spyndelmere plot may be laced with despair, obstacles, and hardship, but there will always be an underlying torrent of optimism, and the option for a happy ending.

Costume and RP Themes

More than any other culture, those in Spyndelmere purposefully dress in a way that sets expectations for others, using dress as another language. Their villains tend toward sharp edges and malevolent insignia, their heroes toward shining armor, and their urchins toward raggedy neutral clothing. Even when dressing to deceive, Spyndelmerians can't seem to help but leave at least one clue as to their true nature.

One common element in Spyndelmere costume is an homage to mushrooms either by imagery, texture, or the familiar colors and patterns of favorite mushrooms.

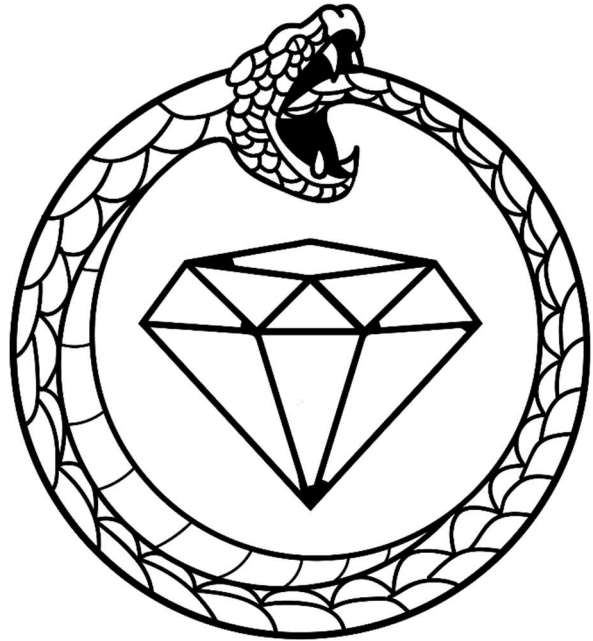
Spyndelmere heraldry is not often worn but does appear sometimes on banners, flags, bags, and other carried items. It consists of symmetrical mushroom-lined paths leading to the profile of a bridge over water. Above the bridge is a castle framed by paired ivy vines.

T'barris, the Serpent Kingdom

There's no line in the ground, no change in the landscape, but you can feel it in your bones when you pass into the lands of the Arcanis.

The people of T'barris live in a balance with the Arcanis, the great magical beasts of the world. Wyverns, White Harts, Frostfire Hounds, and many more share the country of T'barris with the people of that kingdom. T'barris is a balance between the town, fields and forests of people and the nests, groves, dens and caverns of the Arcanis. However, while the Arcanis are the most amazing part of T'barris from first view, there is much more within this land than just a menagerie of arcane beasts.

T'barris looks well on the adventurous, as their focus on balance requires both defenders to protect against raging Arcanis and explorers to enter the Arcanis' lands to fulfill the promise of the beasts' existences. T'barris is quite civilized, as they find balance in all things, work versus play, beauty versus purpose, alchemical cures versus alcoholic and poisonous concoctions, and adventure versus infrastructure. This doesn't mean everyone practices balance in everything they do, more-so that the country recognizes the need for a range of people with a range of pursuits. Perhaps the only area where they are a bit out of balance is in Alchemy, as a surprising number of the Arcanis promote the growth of components well beyond what is found in the rest of the world.



Geography, History, and Climate

For some, the beauty of T'barris land is in its two coastlines rocky in the north and vibrant in the south. For others, it is the small mountains that glisten with snow and ice, and look from a distance to be made of glass. Its deserts are a beauty to behold in the waning hours when the bone-white sand reflects the blue and purple sky such that one of the larger deserts has been nicknamed the Twilight Sea. For most though, the true wonder of T'bariss are the creatures that walk these enchanting landscapes, the Arcanis.

The date it occurred was lost, but the story lives on. T'barris was a kingdom like many others, with people, cities, and commerce but nothing that set it apart from others of its time. Then the Vessel of Souls opened up on the shore and everything changed. The Vessel contained the spirits of arcane beasts never before seen in the world. They were not Purposed with Aspects, but the actual beasts that had been reflected in many Aspects. The lightning-falcon and wyvern took to the skies, kraken and acid-jellyfish took to the seas, and a stampede of other beasts

including the unicorn, silver wolf, and manticore trampled the lands. The people of T'barris did what any people would do; they fought, they ran, or they were lost beneath the hooves and paws of the arcane beasts.

Years uncounted passed and things were finally settled by the Diamondback, a great reptile with a thick hide and glittering scales. More than size or ferocity though, it is known to be powerful and wise. It chose the first ruler, Danielle T'barris, from whom the nation takes its name. Among the great gifts given by Diamondback was the knowledge that each of the Arcanis have an innate intent. They are not like a natural wolf or other creature of Eilona. Instead they each have an arcane structure that guides their behaviors, demeanors, and ends. Some maintain and guard gardens of herbs, like the dreaming-serpents. Others exist to be hunted and give the successful hunter a boon, like the white hart. Each one has a purpose and learning the purpose of an Arcanis shows how best to honor it and live in balance with it.

It is accepted across T'bariss that sometimes that balance and honor demands a beast to destroy or be destroyed. Even more special than their existence, the arcane beasts of this land have spirits. These spirits are what arrived in the Vessel of Souls and that is where they return when they are slain. In accordance with their individual rules, each will be born again when the time and conditions are right.

With that behind us, we can return to the beauty that is the land. The northern coast is covered in rocky cliffs and hidden coves. The southern coast is a paradise of different colored sandy beaches with calm waves most suitable for swimming and fishing. A reef rests just to the south of T'barris and within that reef many of the aquatic Arcanis make their home. The inland portions of T'barris include deserts, rivers, forest, jungles, fields and even small mountains with high cliffs and snowy peaks. Some guess that the Arcanis influenced the landscape over the years changing their lairs to match their preferences.

Towns are small, but many in number as they often must fit between the Arcanis' ranges, or are based on the symbiosis that comes from a specific Arcanis living nearby. An alchemy town might be situated near a slumbering-serpent's herb grove. A cloth town might spring up near a field of chaos-rams. The whole economy of the country is based on these relationships with the Arcanis and the unique treasures and plenty that they provide.

There are five provinces within T'barris, each named after the attribute of their most common Arcanis. The northern coast is The Azure after the azure-eels that inhabit the coast. Azure-eels are voracious, insatiable eaters. They eat and grow and eat and grow. If they grow too big they attack the shore, looking to eat the land. At that point, they must be killed to start the cycle again.

The central forest region is known as The Nettle after the nettle-boars found in that area. Nettle-boars forests contain many precious mushrooms and other fungus which can be used in alchemy. Nettle-boars exist to find and care for mushrooms, though if they are scared they will attack using the needle-like protrusions that cover their hide.

The province known as The Scaled includes the western deserts, mountains and plateaus which the Scaled Eagles fly over and treat as their range. Scaled Eagles each have a golden scale upon them which can grant power to the person who picks the scale off. The eagles fly notoriously high and make their aeries on distant hidden clifftops, making this acquisition very difficult.

The Sloth refers to the eastern jungles and swamps. The sloth-lizards of those areas have the gift of encouraging growth with their every step. Unfortunately they only ever take a step every few days or so.

The southern coasts are known as The Golden, for the golden-turtles sleep along the vibrant sandy beaches. The golden-turtles live to collect items touched by the arcane and bury them in the sea bed, resulting in the bloom of many aquatic components.

Politics, Government, and Economy

Since the return of the Lattice, T'barris has found a ready market for their Arcanis sourced goods. They have started strong trade relationships with Myos, since T'barris has two long shores to send their goods on their way to Myos, where-as land bound thresholds are often found in the lands of the Arcanis. T'barris alchemy is sought in all the lands as it provides easy to apply healing and cures. T'barris poisons have an equally strong, but more clandestine clientele that create a ready market.

The most unique aspect of the T'barris people is the way in which the rulers are selected. Once every 5-10 years, someone in one of the five provinces will find the shed skin of the great Diamondback, a huge reptilian beast with diamond-like scales. No one ever sees the creature, but for hundreds of years its scales have picked the future rulers. When someone finds the skin of the Diamondback, they have been selected to join the Council That Will Be. This council contains five people, one from each province. When a new member joins the council That Will Be, the old member from that province becomes the new monarch. The previous monarch joins the second council, the Council That Was. The two councils and the monarch run the kingdom and T'bariss has had prosperity and peace for many years.

Most citizens have a direct connection with their province's representative to the Council that Will be. Relative to the Council that Was, they are newcomers to governing and have the closest connection to their province of origin. They often answer letters from the towns or people of their region and can raise issues impacting their regions to the Monarch and the councils.

Having set down the crown, the members from the Council that Was looks to widescale or external interactions. They act as the treasurers, ambassadors and judges. They no longer see themselves as from a specific province, instead thinking of T'barris as a whole.

Everyday Life

Every town in T'barris has a slightly different way of life. A town near unicorns could drink its blessed water and live a simple life of health. Where-as a town near a crystal-mammoth live a warriors life, fighting off the rampaging beast and then taking all the crystals back for their

crafters to turn into exports or grind them up into alchemical dust. The people of T'barris also respect warriors and adventurers. More often than not it requires an adventurer to provide the solution of an Arcanis versus a peaceful solution.

All the people of T'barris have a habit of “looking into the reason why” if they can before jumping into action. This quest for meaning is the core lesson taught by the learning and honoring the individual purpose of each Arcanis. It has served the kingdom well as they look to understand the motivation behind deals and other people’s actions.

Current Events

The current monarch of T'barris is King Y’vain Pelle. There are concerns amongst the citizenry of late as it has been 11 years since the last skin was found and there has been no sign of the Diamondback. Y’vain was a good ruler early on in his career, but in the past few years he’s shown more and more desire to retire and less and less to care for the needs of the kingdom. This has allowed outside forces to unduly influence the King as he continues to set his hopes on the delayed transition. While the situation has not grown unfixable yet thanks to the influence of the other councils, it is not heading in the right direction.

One of the bad influences that the king has allowed entry into the kingdom is the Wyld Hunters. They are a group of hunters who are said to hunt some of the greatest game in the world. They do not have a strong presence in T'barris yet, but their unthinking hunts of Arcanis are causing issues with the carefully cultivated relationships with the beasts. This has caused many towns to reach out for additional adventurers to help them resolve their Arcanis-fueled crisis.

The current Council that Will Be is made up of Pierce Kenbow of the Nettle; Nuane Le'tor of the Azure; Caul Arix of the Sloth; Myra Rimane of the Scaled; and Wixyra Harper of the Golden. Each of them focuses on the issues of their provinces as they should and are easy to reach out to for their citizens.

Ilene Gieger, of the Council that Was, represents the Alchemists of T'barris. They have created many new or rediscovered alchemical substances and are always looking for assistants in acquiring components to fuel new discoveries.

One last rumor is that the lost location of the Vessel of Souls was discovered. This is a rumor that has resurfaced multiple times in the past so no one gives it much attention.

A Tale of Recent Events

Ah, weary travelers and seekers of truth, gather 'round! For I, your humble bard, bring you tales spun from the threads of T'barris—tales of kings, councils, and mysterious Arcanis, set against the backdrop of a kingdom caught betwixt the known and the unknown. Allow me to regale thee with the latest whispers and murmurings from the year-end of 124, a time when the land, though outwardly rich and vibrant, hides the weight of unseen troubles.

Two turns of the seasons have passed since last this guide was penned, and yet the heart of T'barris beats heavy with uncertainty. To the casual eye, all appears well: the fields still bloom

with the bounty of Arcanis, and the people, in their merry gatherings, still raise their cups to the sky, honoring festivals and cherished moments. But ah! Beneath the glittering surface, shadows lengthen, and the kingdom stirs restlessly.

The heart of these troubles lies with none other than the king himself, Y'vain, who once waited expectantly for the rise of a new king to take his place. But now, dear friends, the king's hope has withered like autumn leaves upon the wind. He mutters to his courtiers, casting doubts upon his very reign, fearing, perhaps, that he may be the last of his kind—the final King Who Is. “The Diamondback is gone,” he whispers, and with those words, the very soul of the kingdom shudders. His counselors, wise though they be, offer their advice—patient, steady advice—telling him to tend the land and hear the people's needs. But oh, dear listener, it seems the king's ears are stuffed with wax, deaf to their pleas.

More troubling still, foreign folk now roam the land, scouring every hill and vale in search of the missing Diamondback, the sacred artifact tied to the fate of the realm. And rather than guard the kingdom's secrets, King Y'vain has thrown open the gates! “Come,” he beckons, “let any who dare and are worthy take their place in council, for the throne awaits its heir.”

Ah, but not all is well within the councils of T'barris. The Council That Will Be, those who stand next in line, tremble at the king's words. Each member wonders in their heart—could they, should they, don the mantle of kingship? None are certain. Rumor has it that this council may soon seek to bend the laws of the land itself, to name their own king and raise a new member to their ranks. But such whispers are fraught with peril, for who knows what fate such changes may bring?

Meanwhile, the Council That Was, those who have already served their time upon the throne, scurry about the kingdom like ants before a storm, fixing all that has been neglected in these troubled days. Take note, dear audience, of the Guild of Heroics! Never have they been more active, striving to right the wrongs left unattended by the faltering hands of government. Yet even their noble deeds can only tip the scales so far, as they find themselves caught between the king's inaction and the whispers of rebellion.

But hark! Not all news is dreary in T'barris. Two glimmers of hope pierce the kingdom's clouded sky. The first, a most intriguing endeavor: a rumor spreads of one who has taken up the mighty task of crafting an Arcanolograph! Now, you may ask, what is such a thing? Why, it is none other than a grand compendium, a tome that would catalogue every Arcanis known to the world, revealing their powers and purposes. Imagine, my friends! Communities far and wide, able to understand the Arcanis that shape their lives! And it is said that this noble venture is backed by none other than the Heroes of Fortune's Bend, renowned champions of Purpose. If any are to succeed in this monumental task, surely, it is they.

And now, for the second spark of hope: the dreaded Wyld Hunt has gone silent these past six months. No longer do they hunt the Arcanis that support the common folk. They have turned their gaze elsewhere, and wherever they tread, this humble bard wishes them well, for their absence has been a boon to the kingdom.

As we stand on the cusp of the year 125, hearts across T'barris turn to the future, with hopes—oh, fervent hopes—that this new year may bring with it the return of the Diamondback, and with it, the changes so desperately needed to mend this fractured realm.

So raise your tankards, my friends, and toast to T'barris! May the year ahead shine bright with promise and may the land find the strength it needs to face the trials yet to come.

Notes for Players

T'barris is a culture based on a symbiosis with the Arcanis, the magical creatures. There will be strange magical creatures involved in the plots and there will be adventures to fulfill the existence of different Arcanis.

Alchemy will be a plot element you will see as T'barris is a leader in the way of potions, poisons and elixirs.

T'barris exists on the world stage and has come to engage in trade with many nations, using Myos as a hub. Expect trading and political plot related to the interactions between nations.

Cultural Plot and Themes

The general feel of T'barris is “everyone has their own balance” and to respect that. They know that each town has its own story and its own way of operating and they sort of expect that every new place they go or see will be this way too.

Adventures in T'barris will often require discovering what is going on behind what you see through research, adventure, or experimentation and this doesn't just apply to interactions with the Arcanis.

Costume and RP Themes

In general the folks from T'barris dress in traditional fantasy Larp clothing. Each person will have a highlight or an entire costume that highlights the region of T'barris they hail from. Those from The Scale may wear scale armor or adornments, reptile leather, or fabric with snake, alligator or other lizard skin patterns. Those from Azure have blue gems that adorn their clothing. The Nettle often have toggles of wood or bone that pass through their clothing. The Gold have golden clothing or have turtles adorning their clothing. Where-as those from The Sloth have a piece of clothing or a whole outfit that appears a complete mismatch, as if they weren't totally awake when they put their outfit together.

Vale of Scyllina

The Vale of Scyllina is a small nation that rests comfortably in grassy, mist-prone hills surrounding an offset inland sea. As the lattice reconnected cultures, the Scyllinari gained a new appreciation of how fortunate they were to live in a place of beauty and safety like the Vale. The soil and grass are ideal for farming and husbandry, the river and salt sea make for good fishing, and the unusually beautiful natural resources have brought good trade and wealth to the nation. The Vale is known across the lattice as the exclusive source of Dapplevein lumber, Vericulum ore, and Marieri filets.

The Vale is infamous for its ferocious, cutthroat, merciless court of nobility. Most of those who become embroiled in the dangerous game of wealth and power do so by choice, with only a few being thrust there by circumstance. The courts are known among the easygoing population as Fraemori Lux, or "Monster Silks." Their ambassadors are known in foreign courts as adept, razor-sharp, and possessed of a discerning talent for finding opportunity.



Geography, History, and Climate

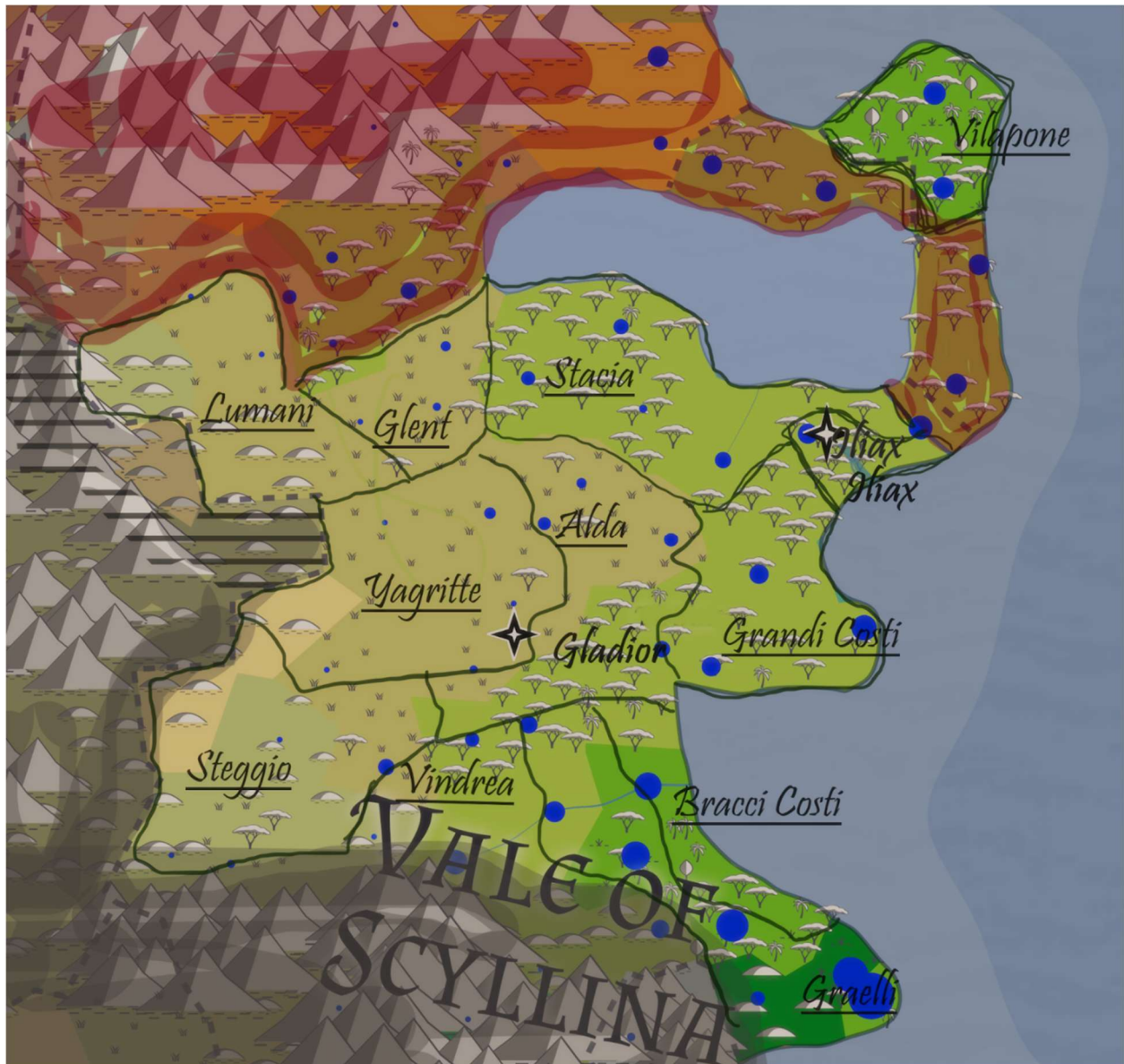
The Vale of Scyllina is defined on the southern and western edges by mountains, and on its northern border by impassable volcanic wasteland. The Estri sea takes up a large portion of the northern land. Towns in the Vale range languidly over several hillsides with single houses and small clusters connected by dirt paths or pavestone roads. The city of Iliax in the north was built upon the ruins of an old civilization once the remains of a Lattice Threshold were uncovered and repaired. The city's expansion exploded upward and outward when the Leaping Hare canal was dug from the sea to the Node, allowing ships to port through to the Myos Islands sea gates.

There are other such old cities scattered around the Vale, though none have risen to contemporary greatness in the same way as Iliax. The only other notable city is Gladior, an industrial hub near the heart of the nation that grew to support the goods coming out of the mines, forests, fields, and waters on their way to the Node in Iliax.

The Vale is commonly understood to have an active spirit population, and most notably they have established relationships with the Vale's unique regional spirits, often engaging them as allies and protectors. There are twelve widely recognized regional spirits, each with their own territory. A spirit's territory does not always directly align with manmade political boundaries.

The twelve spirits of the Vale and their regions are shown on the map of the Vale below.

There is no unifying heraldry within the Vale. The closest thing they have is the proprietary trade stamp that features an entwined V and S, surrounded by a fish, a leaf, and a veined stone in honor of their three premium exports. Although there is no national heraldry, there is a dizzying array of guild marks, trade stamps, and house heraldry that are vital to the financial and status games that are played by the elite.



The Twelve Regional Spirits

Region	Spirit	Known Seemings	Demeanor	Mask
Yagritte	Goodwin	A gentleman who prefers to dress in white. His clothes are usually of good make, but rumpled as though he had slept in them. He has short spikes of soft, white, feathery hair. His eyes are sometimes large and black.	Goodwin is a gregarious, joyful spirit who frequents taverns, bars, and parties in his area. He loves people and treats anyone within range of his boisterous voice as a lifelong friend. He almost never leaves a pub or an event. Instead, he will drink, eat, and toast until he eventually nods off, and then will fade out.	White Owl
Steggio	Consallow	Dressed always in dark and somber clothing, Consallow is assumed to be in mourning. Sometimes they are reported to have a foul, fetid scent. They are always to be found with a veil that covers their eyes, and a scarf, collar, or kerchief that covers their mouth and nose.	Consallow is known to speak only rarely. Most of the time, he stations himself at a corner, or the top of a hill, or the edge of a field, and he watches. At the behest of the Elite Courtier of this region, Consallow will sometimes agree to share their breath with a sleeping target, which will result in the target's death. However, if Consallow does not approve of the request, they will choose a different target on their own recognizance.	White Featureless White Face with a Black Veil over the Eye Area
Alda	Stycke	Stycke most commonly appears as a jovial mastiff, overexcited and drooly. Their fur is reddish-brown. Rarely, Stycke will appear as a lanky young human with reddish-brown hair.	Stycke loves children and sometimes forgets to appear for adults, giving the impression that children are playing with an invisible friend. Stycke is very protective of the people of their region. They will guard doors and patrol communities at night. Hackles raised, they will appear at the side of lone pedestrians in their region who are under threat. Stycke can speak, but adults will only hear barking.	White Mastiff
Lumani	Madam Sharpe	Madam Sharpe has always appeared as a woman. She is typically well-dressed, with hair piled high on her head. She favors skirts that are high in the front and low in the back, and she carries a dueling sword.	Madam Sharpe appears often at courtly functions and philanthropic endeavours. She is known to be keen-eyed and always manages to disappear from a place before the trouble arrives. She claims her sword is that of a fallen friend, and so she carries it in memory.	White Hare
Braccl Costi	Blayne	Blayne is a roguish character who, upon observation, has obviously been caught and punished for previous crimes. He wears looped chains and	Blayne loves a good story. He is often found in places such as campfires, fishing holes, tailor and beauty salons, and other places	White Opossum

		sometimes has a missing hand or a scar on his neck. He typically wears villager's clothing.	where strangers are likely to share stories with strangers. Every once in a while, he will be found sleeping in an unused bed, and it is best to chase him off with a broom.	
Glent	Serrah Churrah	Serrah alternates between appearing as a young man and a young woman. They are always dressed in simple, homemade clothing. Sometimes, they are heralded by the smell of flowers or stew.	Serrah is attracted to large windows, and sometimes doors or gates. They will sit or stand near them, and gaze through. Sometimes they will embroider or crochet while they wait and watch. Serrah does not initiate conversation, but will sometimes share what they see with those who ask.	White Cat
Vindrea	Anneliese	Anneliese can appear as a small spider, or as a regal middle-aged woman wearing a lot of lace.	Anneliese is a harsh, imposing woman in most of her appearances. Her advice is always on point, but she may present it in a misleading way if she dislikes you. Despite her apparent distaste for everyone, she does not keep to herself. Anneliese will offer unsolicited advice to people regarding situations she does not have any business even knowing about. As far as anyone has found, her sympathy is given only to the starving, so an Elite Courtier with her mask will typically fast for as long as they can before calling on her.	White Spiderweb
Graelli	Mister Phlox	Mister Phlox is most often seen as literal flowers, only sure to be him because they were not there moments before. When he does take a human form, he will either be covered in a carpet of flowers, or will be wearing a gentleman's coat with a flower design. He usually smells of freshly turned soil.	Mister Phlox is a gentle, peaceful presence who prefers to be outdoors. He is drawn to places where people touch nature, and especially to gardens. Mister Phlox abhors the cutthroat court of the Vale, so it is unclear why his mask is represented among the Elite.	White Mask Covered in Flowers
Stacia	Maven	Maven appears as an older woman with a kerchief covering her hair. She is sometimes spry, and sometimes decrepit. A bird rides on her shoulder, staff, or hat.	Maven is unique among the regional spirits because she is always visible, and seems to move about as if she were a physical being. She lives in a house, goes to a market, and otherwise interacts with the world as any person might. Those who have been in her house describe a cauldron that, no matter how	White Wings

			bright a light is shone inside, seems to have no bottom. Maven has been known to take in orphans on occasion, and will always take in any stray animal that makes its way to her.	
Grandi Costi	Brackish Ben	Brackish Ben has never been seen. He has a soft, watery voice.	Within his region, Brackish Ben is known as a water spirit. He loves money and is attracted to coins and other valuable things being tossed into water. He prefers pools and ponds but has been known to appear in running water and even in bowls. He loves stories of adventure, especially ones that feature a great hoard, or unexpected windfall. If pleased, Brackish Ben is willing to grant simple wishes.	White Cuttlefish
Iliax	Ilia	Ilia is a suave, silver-tongued courtier with long, flowing hair and bright eyes. Ilia claims no gender and typically dresses in pants, a cumberbund, and an embellished bolero jacket.	Ilia is an odd spirit in that every time their Elite Courtier's Mask changes hands, they forget their entire past and must start anew. Ilia is far too graceful to betray whether or not this troubles them. Most of the folk of the region live to see several Iliax though, and may treat them with pity, impatience, or indulgence. These occasional resets can bring changes to Ilia's personality, turning suave into slick, or indifferent into cruel. They can be found at estate balls, high-end shops, and expensive eating establishments when they are not out strutting the streets of Iliax. Sometimes, they can be found inebriated in an alley.	White Winking Fox
Vilapone	Cicero the Spearman	Cicero is an older man with greying hair. He is usually seen in a well-fitted but plain jacket, pants, and worn boots. He is never seen without his bow and quiver of blue-fletched arrows.	Cicero is a curmudgeon, and a weathered man of the the sea. Sometimes, he comes to towns to sell his catches. Other times, he will meet folk at the edge of the water, and either invite them fishing or ask to go out in their boat. Though he prefers to spend most of his time relaxing with his line in the water, he will sometimes demonstrate how he got his name. He is rumored to be such a deadly marksman that he can use his bow and arrows for spearfishing, and in every village in his region there is at least one person who will swear that they have seen him prove it.	White Kingfisher

Politics, Government, and Economy

It is entirely possible for Scyllinari who do not live near a city to go their whole lives without ever seeing a national official. Most of the day-to-day civil functions are tended to by local governors and civil servants, who likely have second careers as millers or coopers. Because the Vale lacks external threats, it has developed a curious system of governance that has tripped up many visitors. All of the trade routes including land, water, and lattice are owned and maintained by members of the court, and the taxes and tolls on these form the greatest share of their income. The powerful trade guilds, some of which have members in the courts and some of which do not, have a monopoly on the ships and caravans necessary for moving the Vale's precious cargo. The natural resources and the rate at which they may be depleted varies greatly, as these may be owned by citizens, courtiers, guilds, or village collectives, each of whom may have absolute say over the disposition of those resources. All other determinations of what is legal and what is not is made on a regional basis.

This maze-like system seems to only be understood by the courtiers in power, and only fully understood by the twelve mysterious masked courtiers who stand at the apex of the Vale's dangerous politics. It is their ability to understand and manipulate this writhing mass of etiquette and influence that keeps them in power.

Because the Vale relies heavily on trade to maintain its lifestyle, they put a lot of work into diplomacy and international outreach. They have been the money behind many charity, refugee, and peace operations, though they have been criticized for rarely taking a stand against an oppressor, always looking to make friends without making enemies.

Everyday Life

Most Scyllinari quietly spend their days at the work of their village or homestead, with occasional flurries of activity when the trade caravan comes through, or when there is a festival. To the average citizen, the ongoing events of the Scyllinari court are so outlandish that they are simply treated as gossip fodder, and it is a rich, neverending buffet.

Outside of the courts, there is very little attention paid to social status. Scyllinari citizens are more than happy to leave that tedium to the Fraemori Lux and to spend their own time on their family, hobby, and communities. There is a bit more of a status show in Iliax and Gladior, but beyond their boundaries even the Vale's other cities have more of a small-town disposition toward community and neighbors, generally up to lend a hand toward a friend or the betterment of the town.

Due to the regional governments and generally peaceful lifestyle, problems and issues in a citizen's life tend to be local ones. Overly ambitious courtiers, cheating traders, spoiled wine, and poor weather dominate the short list of Scyllinari complaints. With education available to all and enough wealth to allow for free time, there is a great deal of art produced in the Vale, most notably mosaic and painting. Many inhabitants inside the courts and out will make or commission vibrant murals on the walls of their buildings.

Within the courts, social status is the entirety of a person's existence, and those with experience in the courts seem to have the ability to sense one another's social value, even to fractional degrees. While most courtiers are as merciless as their reputation suggests, they do follow a certain set of unspoken rules in their pursuit of power and wealth.

Assassination, kidnapping, and other criminal acts are a known and accepted part of the race, but no true master of the courts would wield them against those who are not associated with the game. By the strange rules of the elite, it would be acceptable to target a rival's spouse for kidnapping, but not the foreman of their village. While the first act might be ignored as a fair play, the second would be pursued by all applicable laws because the foreman had no choice in his association, and it was considered a breach of etiquette.

If there is any one thing that unites the courtiers and the commoners of Scyllinari, it is the lively spirit population. Spirits within the Vale are remarkably visible and extroverted. Some are minor, attached to a popular bakery or pub. Other spirits may attach themselves to a particular family through its generations. And all citizens know their regional spirit, be it through shady deals they make in pursuit of power, or because of its carousing appearance at the festivals in its honor.

Current Events

As the chronicle begins, the Vale of Scyllina has just undergone the greatest turnover of its elite twelve in the history of the nation. Six of the twelve have turned, and no one is yet certain who is behind those six masks. Even those outside the courts are whispering about what changes this may bring as they cement their place at the top. The six who have turned are Ilia, Mister Phlox, Consallow, Goodwin, Cicero the Spearman, and Serrah Churrah.

In the west, there is great concern as the starfly migration patterns have been unpredictable,, and the Dapplevein lumber that is the area's lifeblood is in peril awaiting their arrival. Several towns are beginning to feel the unusual press of hardship and insecurity. The local governor is pleading for aid, but the land belongs to a missing courtier, and no other has come to offer aid.

Some years ago in the north, in the foothills of the volcanic wasteland, a small city reported that their ground was falling away, revealing the roofs of long-buried buildings. Similar events have occurred across the Vale, mainly in the north. Perhaps the most notable instance was the sinkhole that opened up beneath the intended venue for the 124 Midsummer Masque, swallowing the building and delaying the festivities while new venues were arranged. Notes for Players

Cultural Plot Themes

Players from the Vale should choose if they wish to be involved with courtier plot, by their character's choice or unwilling involvement.

Courtier plot will be full of back-alley plots, two-faced NPCs, dangerous allegiances, and most importantly, a handful of people trying to use a bad system to do something good. Those who

enjoy working behind the scenes to make big things happen, espionage, and conversational wargames will likely enjoy courtier plot.

There is much more to the Vale though, and other plots will involve the mystery of the ancient cities, the helping of good people in need, and the wild world of spirits who want to be involved with mortal affairs.

Costume and RP Themes

The typical Scyllinari citizen changes outfits during the day, having a different set of clothing for work and for relaxation. They also boast of being the first civilization to wear pajamas or sleepclothes to bed, as they were the first to be able to afford such luxury. Players who wish to represent their culture through their costume may choose rich or patterned fabrics in comfortable but beautiful design. Corsets, bodices, and suits are commonplace even among the Scyllinari commoners.

Vericulum Ore comes in a range of green to clear, and can be represented with stones that look like malachite, mossy agate, moonstone, quartz, aventurine, chlorite, jade, etc. Vericulum ore is unique to the Vale, and while it is an opulent purchase for outsiders, many citizens have items and accessories made from it.

Those who work in trade and export may sport the stamp somewhere on their items. It is a V and S intertwined, surrounded by a fish, a veined stone, and a leaf.

If you are a courtier in the Vale, then you are accustomed to being judged by every aspect of your outfit at all times. Courtiers are often accused of being vain, but one button out of place may be the reason they fall from power. Court fashion changes with the times, but costumes are expensive! No player would be expected to provide multiple fancy costumes in a weekend. If you'd like to represent a courtier look, consider silky sheens, lots of buttons, over-the-top jewelry, fabulous hats, parasols, and canes.

PEOPLES OF AELEDD

The people of Numina III come in all sorts of different colors, shapes, sizes, genders. Aeleddd has no concept of “race.” Beyond the nation and culture that one calls home, Aspects are the primary feature by which people identify.

Aspects

An Aspect is an outward exhibition of one’s inner self and reflects a connection to the forces of the creation. Everyone is born exhibiting at least one Aspect but may have more than one. Someone’s Aspect may be the same Aspect as one or both of their parents, or come from a distant ancestor, or have a totally different Aspect than others in their family. Aspect is not genetic or inherited, though some families have a long history of exhibiting a specific Aspect. Likewise, there are specific communities and cities with a predominance of certain Aspects, but even there, there is no guarantee that aspects will appear with any fixed frequency.

There are no names for people based on any of these characteristics, save for literal descriptions. “There is a group of people with white hair at the door” or “Do you see those two Divine Aspected walking down by the lake”. The people of Aeleddd do not make up names to classify groups of Aspected as a subset of people, each Aspected is a unique person.

As people exhibit one or more Aspects, the rational people of the world recognize that discrimination against an individual based on their Aspect is wrong. Individuals or cultures who do discriminate against someone based on their Aspect are considered villainous and treated as such.

Aspects don't change on a day to day basis; it's not like dyeing hair or putting on makeup, it's something fundamental. While an individual's Aspect can change, it is generally due to a major event, the culmination of a set of actions focused on realigning oneself, or significant time spent in an area that has ties to a given aspect. For example, someone who spends a lot of time at a forge, surrounded by the heat and flames, might start to exhibit Elemental Aspect.

The following Aspects are commonly known in the world of Aeleddd.

Arcane

Arcane aspected are touched by arcane energies and exhibit characteristics like unnatural horns, bone protrusions, or swirls of bright colors.

Beast

Beast aspected are linked to animals and display features of the animal to which they are closest.

Construct

The inanimate and living are combined within the construct aspected, be it through choice or circumstance, and their appearance shows what substance they are infused with.

Divine

The divine aspects have the energies of the divine within them which can be seen by having the metallic (gold, silver, copper) coloration upon their faces.

Ghost

The ghost aspected have been touched by the spirit of one who has died, and show that through a gaunt visage.

Elemental

The raw elements of earth, air, fire and water are a part of the elemental aspected and they show those elements upon their countenance.

Life

The life aspected are infused with life. This can be demonstrated by having exaggerated ears, or teeth, but not all life aspected show this. Simply being alive and not another aspect is enough to reveal one is life aspected.

Plant

The flora is a part of the plant aspected and they display the nature of those plants.

Shade

The Shade aspected have a bit of the shade within them and show those bits upon their face including Constellations, Heraldrics, Shade locations and other Shade beings. This aspect more than any other is very diverse as there are many parts of the shade.

Multi-Aspects Individuals

Some people, though it is not common, have two or three Aspects. Aspects come together to create a unique whole within the person who manifests them. For example, someone touched by Elemental and Beast might show characteristics of a lightning wolf. A different person with Plant and Divine Aspects may have golden roses grown on silver vines pictured upon their skin.

Foundations

The word “Foundation” is used in Aeled to refer to one’s basic training and profession. While everyone’s story is unique, certain Foundations are common elements of peoples’ backgrounds. One person might describe their Foundation as “I spent my time as a wastrel in the taverns, spending my days dicing for coins and deep in the cups;” another might say “I was a dutiful

apprentice to a wizard, delving deep into the mysteries of the arcane under the tutelage of my preceptor.” Both of these tales show how foundations occur in the complex tapestries of peoples’ lives.

The following foundations are common enough to be generally recognized:

Agriculture

You have sown crops, raised livestock and/or gathered the fruits of the world. You can find bounty anywhere, even where others would find naught. You could have owned a farm, worked on the land of another or kept gardens of flowers for their beauty.

Alchemical

There are times when you wonder if you have more alchemical substances running through your veins than you do blood. You have distilled potions, venoms, poisons, and balms. You could have spent years in an alchemical shop, apprenticed to an alchemist of great note or experimenting on your own.

Arcane

The Arcane was your world. Maybe you grew up in the house of a mighty wizard or arcane researcher. Perhaps you found a great book of magic in your youth that taught you how to control the arcane or maybe it just came naturally to you.

Artifice

Where something could be accomplished through muscle you create amazing constructs to achieve it. Where something could not be done through normal means, you found even more fantastic creations to realize it. You may have been part of a manufactory, were a lone inventor or come from a family with a history of working in creation.

Ecclesiastic

You may have spent your years in a temple or traveling the world preaching your faith. You dedicated your youth to the service of a single faithful order or perhaps you learned many faiths to better broaden your enlightenment.

Entertainer

A room full of people reading and studying is as boring as a tomb to you. You would rather see them all singing together, enjoying a play, or dancing the night away. Perhaps you were a traveling bard, an actor in a theater, a story teller, or maybe you were just the best singer in your town.

Expressionism

Perhaps you are a painter, a sculptor, or another creator of physical art. You gain insight and inspiration from the act of creation. Your works bring laughter, tears, and epiphany to those who view them.

Heroic

You are a hero. Perhaps you come from a time lost, like Fortune's Bend's past. Perhaps you are a modern hero, who has put yourself in peril to save others. You put the good of others and the good of the world above your own safety.

Leisure

You have money and goods at your disposal. When you are hungry there is food, when tired there are the softest of beds and when you want to go shopping there are always funds and eager merchants to sell you things. You grew up with money and know how to spend it.

Mariner

You could have been the captain, first mate or a sailor upon a vessel on the seas or rivers. You know navigation, ropes, and a wide range of ports of call. As a mariner you understand the weather, the tides, and the call of the waves.

Mendicant

You spent your years helping those in need, setting bones, healing the ills of those around you and learning about what cures and afflicts the body. You may have been the town healer, worked in a large house of healing, or traveled to help those in need.

Mercantile

You may have worked in a merchant house, run your own store, or traveled from town to town buying and selling goods. As a merchant you understand the real value of money and have connections that allow you to turn coin into goods or coin into more coin.

Military

You spent years serving in an army as a soldier or officer. You could have served in a kingdom's army, as part of a mercenary company or as the defense of a city. You know the ways of battle and understand the honor that comes from following a respectable commander.

Noble Courts

Maybe you have spent time as a courtier in the noble courts of your lands. Perhaps you are the 7th child of a noble of the sword and grew up amongst other children of the nobility in the palaces. Mayhap you were adopted by a Baron and gained her family name. You know the politics of your kingdom and understand how the nobility operate.. (Note: This background does not

grant any inherent noble or political rights, powers or status outside of the skills you can purchase. This background would be appropriate for someone interested in their character having a noble background, but that background cannot be of the direct line of the ruler of a kingdom or some other noble of significant status. You can be of a line related to the ruler, but it would be far enough away that there is no likelihood of inheritance.)

Poverty

You never knew if you'd have enough food to eat, a place to sleep or somewhere to get in out of the rain. Perhaps you are an orphan who had to make their own way, maybe your family fell on hard times and you had to work from a young age, or you might have had everything taken away by a bandit and were left with nothing. You know how to survive like no one else, because you've had to.

Reformed

You were not a hero, or even a good person. You committed foul deeds and made dark deals. But that is the past. You have changed and are that person no longer. You know what it means to be a good person, because you have seen the darkness and how easy it is to fall into evil. Now that you have come to the side of good, you understand more than any how important it is to stay there.

Stargazer

The constellations of the shade drew you from a young age. Maybe it was your choice, maybe it was theirs, but your past was bound to the shade. You may have traveled it when young or lived on the edges of it, but you know the shade.

Traveler

You never felt comfortable living in a single place. Perhaps you grew up in a family that was nomadic. Maybe you just left your place of birth to see what's out there. Or maybe you are following a legend across the world seeking answers. In any case, you love to travel and have seen much of the world.

University

You might have been a student, a professor, or a staff member of one of the great houses of learning. You have experience in classes, books and researching information. You know the way to dig for the right answer within a tome and how to record information so it is not lost.

Wilderness

Soft beds, ample food, the comforts of civilization, these things were not for you. You spent your years in the wilderness, be it by fate as you were lost there, by choice as you wanted away from the life of cities or by necessity as you had to leave wherever you lived. In any case, you know of life within the forests and wilderness.

The Numina Campaign does more with a character's Foundation than it simply being a roleplay element and a part of your story. When creating your character, you will have the ability to choose from a short list of Foundational skills that reflect the Foundation of your choosing.

Choosing your Foundation

The difference between Foundation skills and other skills is that they will be situational based on the Foundation you choose. For example, someone who chose the Soldier Foundation could choose to purchase skills that were useful during a field battle. Someone who chose Merchant, could spend CP to have access to additional choices or discounts from the mercantile exchanges and a player whose Foundation was the Noble Courts might choose from skills that impacted negotiations or political dealings.

Two additional thoughts, first we plan to offer ways that you can choose multiple Foundations which defined your character's earlier years. As we publish more details on character creation we will provide the mechanisms for selecting one or more Foundations. For now, let your imagination run wild on what you think makes up your character's background. Second, you should not feel your character history should be limited to the Foundations you choose. Your character can have done or been more than your chosen Foundations. Your Foundation should represent the aspects of your history which you feel mean the most to your character during the game.

FAITH AND RELIGION

The Genesori

In the world of Aeled, there is but one divine pantheon: The Genesori. The world and all things in it were created by them, and each took a piece of creation as their domain. They are:

- Bahadur - The Blade of Resolve
- Istarum - The Holy Defender
- Jormic - The Omniscient
- Thiacris - The Host of Mystery
- Koreel - The Primal Spirit
- Eilona - Mistress of the Wild
- Severin - The Twilight Guardian
- Gwenarra - The Lady of Life and Love
- Metioch - The Lord of Order
- Garioch - The Shaper

The power of the Genesori is such that their direct intervention in the world invariably leads to large scale upheaval and destruction, and since the living gained Purpose, they have stayed their hands and instead choose to act through their agents in the mortal world. In fact, the last time a Genesori touched the world was the final blow struck in the War of the Heavens, where Garioch reached his fist to the world and struck the last army with enough force that the continent of Rues was pushed entirely through the world.

In the past, churches rose up in worship of the Genesori - each a sprawling organization devoted to the exaltation of a single deity. Often these churches became powers rivaling nations, either politically or militarily. This shaped the world in many ways both good and ill, but the Genesori, in their eternal wisdom, decided that the world being shaped in the image of the Genesori stunted the Purpose and free will given to the Purposed beings.

Thus, many years ago, A great revelation was passed from the Genesori through their Zeniths and the heads of their churches - That the churches would be dismantled, and the worship of the Genesori would be directed to serving and bettering the pieces of creation belonging to each of them. This revelation was known as The Desuetude Pronouncement, and began a new age of the Purposed.

Faith

Faith is the belief an individual has in the Genesori. In the world of Numina, the presence and influence of the Genesori is a tangible and real thing, and only a very confused individual would deny the existence of the Divine. That does not mean that everyone in the world is faithful to the Genesori or actively gives them worship. It does happen that people live out their lives without

giving any credence or heed to the Genesori, but even those individuals would not go so far as to say the Genesori are false or imaginary.

While most common folk of the world have faith in the whole pantheon of the Genesori, there are those who are called to the service of one or more specific Genesori. This service may take many forms or titles, including Priest, Cleric, Monk, ... or any of a number of titles based on the specific role the individual undertakes in the service of the Genesori. Often, this service is referenced as calling oneself "Faithful" to a Genesori or Group of Genesori or "Devoted" to a single Genesori. Individuals will often have small personal shrines or small temples within a community dedicated to their favored Genesori.

The Zenith, The Chosen, and the Exemplars

Though the Genesori have divorced themselves of mortal churches, they maintain the need for a small number of beings that serve them directly and exact their will upon the world. Those beings are known as the Zenith, the Chosen, and the Exemplars.

The Zenith

The Zenith is a being of duality - of both the pure divine and of the mortal world. To achieve this duality, the Zenith is actually two* separate beings that are linked together through their Genesori.

*In the case of Koreel, the Divine Zenith and Mortal Zenith frequently share a body; this has been the case since Matriarch Phyllida Vondran in the Age of Piety.

The first half is the Divine representation - an ageless and eternal being that is the manifestation of the divine influence of the Genesori. Though these Zenith were once mortals, they have transcended mortality and can now travel both the mortal world and the realm of the Genesori. They are tasked with the furtherance of the metaphysical aspects of their Genesori's domains.

The second half is the Mortal representation. The mortal Zenith is born and lives their life like any other individual, but at some point was chosen by the Divine Zenith to become their counterpart. This process is voluntary, though none have ever refused this calling. The Mortal Zenith gains insight and enlightenment into the realm and domains of their Genesori and is tasked with the maintenance of the tangible and physical aspects of their Genesori's domains. This job is not always permanent. On occasion the Zenith chooses to pass on their role before their death and another is chosen to replace them. This often comes at times of great crisis, when the current Zenith feels someone with a particular mindset or skillset would serve the Genesori better than they do. The Divine Zeniths are:

- Amar, The Charitable One - Gwennara
- Varis, The Host of Reason - Garioch
- Cosima, Lady Temperance - Metioch
- Mournvale, The Sacrificed - Severin

- Riel, Fortitude - Eilona
- Alise, The Yearning Soul - Koreel
- Seifer, The Peacebringer - Istarum
- Aeron, The Hand of Justice - Bahadur
- Laylia, The All Knowing - Theocris
- Vintia, The Speaker of Truths - Jormic

The Chosen

Chosen are, like the Zenith, divine servants of the Genesori. They were all once mortals and each of them lived a life that exemplified something that the Genesori wanted remembered and honored. For example, there is in the service of Metioch a Chosen of Loyalty who served as the last general of Metioch's armies in times long past when armies marched under the flags of Gods. He willingly served even to the point where death was inevitable, and was honored by being taken into the Divine service of Metioch. Chosen work as agents of the Zenith, as the Zenith has the broad portfolio of a Genesori to serve and cannot attend to all things. The exact number of Chosen is not known, as they often do not make themselves known to the Purposed until it becomes necessary to seek aid or intervene in a particular event.

The Exemplars

Exemplars are those who served as an example of faith in their lives or in their deaths. Each and every Exemplar is dead, as only after death can the Zenith or a Chosen announce that someone has been made an Exemplar. Exaltation is generally done as a memorial, so the acts of a person will be remembered and studied as an example of faithfulness to the Genesori. On occasion certain rituals can be performed that can call upon a saint for advice, guidance, or council, but calling on an Exemplar is no different than calling on the spirit of any other deceased individual.

Convocations

During the Desuetude, a new way to pay homage to the Genesori spread throughout the world. Where once there were powerful churches devoted to each individual Genesori, instead new organizations rose up to offer faith through the support of the purviews of the Genesori. These organizations defined their purposes for existence, for example a group setting its purpose to Exploration and Discovery of ancient lost cultures might take as patrons Bahadur for the sense of adventure, Thiacris for the discovery of the unknown, Jormic for the cataloging of that which they find, and Severrin for the honoring of the departed. These groups are commonly called Convocations, and while there are a great many throughout the world, there are some with greater influence and spread.

It is not required for a PC to be a member of a Convocation in game. Conversely, should a PC wish to be part of more than one Convocation, this is permitted. PCs are not required to have or use a Divine Magic Source to become a member of any Convocation. The Convocations presented here are large enough and world-spanning enough that they are recognized and known throughout all the cultures of the world, even in places where they may not be welcome.

Most small convocations are offshoots of the large Convocations listed here, and it is rare for a Convocation to spring up without at least an origin among one of them. It is also possible for a PC to be a member of a smaller Convocation of their own design if desired, but with the understanding that Plot may not be able to account for all PC created Convocations and other players will likely not have heard of these player-created Convocations.

World Spanning Convocations of Faith

The Hearthguards

Defense Against Aggressors, Personal Honor, Self-sacrifice

Patrons: Bahadur, Metioch, Istarum

The Hearthguards were once a mercenary company in Ancient Moskeyna. During a war in which Moskeyna was beset by many neighboring kingdoms, the Hearthguards were hired into service to protect the Capitol following the destruction of the standing army. The Hearthguards formed a defense that held true for three years, protecting not only the capitol but all the refugees who had fled there for sanctuary. In the second year of the siege, the money and the supplies had run dry. The invaders approached The Prime Warlord of the Hearthguard, offering to issue payment on the contracts that could no longer be fulfilled, with the only condition being that the Hearthguards abandon the capitol. For two days the Prime Warlord prayed to the Genesori, after which he approached his soldiers with the following direction - The Hearthguards would from that day forward accept only contracts that asked them to defend a nation's borders against attack. They would take in payment only that which could be afforded - Money from the rich, Food from the agrarian, and if needs be nothing at all from the poor. The Prime Warlord offered that each of his soldiers could decide for themselves whether this decree was acceptable, and there would be no ill will for any who laid down arms and walked away. According to legend, none did. The Prime Warlord was re-titled Paladin of the Hearthguards, and through divine providence their company held the defense even with no known supply of food, soldiers, or succor for nearly two years. So began the service of the Hearthguards as a Convocation of faith, with the charge of defending nations from aggression.

It has become well known that The Hearthguards will accept only the payment that a people can afford, but will demand that such payment is made - a rich nation who choses to pay a pittance will be turned away while a poor nation that would impoverish their people finds themselves with defenders almost at no cost. As the Hearthguards' soldiers can come from anywhere, a foundational rule of the Convocation is that no member may be forced to act against their conscience. If a soldier finds their unit dispatched to a nation whose soldiers burned their home village in a long past war, that soldier may refuse to accept the posting at no penalty. Likewise, this morality holds true throughout the Convocation, and the Paladin of the Hearthguards will refuse any contract to defend any nation whose morals or actions would cause a stain on the honor of the Convocation.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy martial combat with a noble cause, standing up as a defender of the weak.
- You look for plot that has a more martial bend, taking up fights that do not often exist in a moral gray area.

Notable Descendant Convocations

The Harriers

This convocation has decided that the best way to counter an aggressor is to make it expensive and difficult to continue a war. Harriers do not march in armies but instead act alone or in tight knit bands to harass the supply, logistics, and infrastructure of their enemies. This also means that the Harriers often respond quickly and on smaller scale than the Hearthguards would. Harriers will often use more dubious means to defend a victim, but they maintain a rigorous morality similar to the Hearthguards regarding their chosen causes. Harriers do not often ask for formal contracts or wait to be asked for aid, they simply find the places they can best do their duty and strive to do so.

Those Who Walked Away

Fighting Against Injustice, Aid to the Downtrodden, Resistance

Patrons: Garioch, Gwennara, Severrin

In every unjust society, there are those who see injustice and choose to take action. Sometimes that action is protest, sometimes sabotage, sometimes rebellion, and sometimes that action is to turn and walk away - to be unwilling to participate in a society that violates their personal morals.

The original founders of Those Who Walked Away were among this last group, those who left when they might have had the power or ability to stop things. The Convocation was originally founded as a penitent order, dedicated to making up for what the founders perceived as their cowardice in fleeing instead of taking a stand. Their foundational mission is to fight against oppression, abuse, mistreatment, and injustice by a nation against its people, and to use any means necessary to do so. It is by no means necessary any longer to have turned your back to an injustice to join this Convocation, only to have a desire to take action against such things wherever they are found.

Those Who Walked Away are not a rash or aggressive Convocation. They stress understanding and planning, and when they take action they counsel decisive, precise, and ruthless methods. While the Convocation will smuggle goods to the hungry, secret away people held in bondage, or lend support to political forces, they are also very capable of sabotage, fomenting unrest, and even assassination when the need calls for it.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy opposing injustice wherever it lives

- You look for plot that encourages you to take decisive action against evil, and to have the option between solutions (martial, political, or rogue-like) to fight against your enemies.

Notable Descendant Convocations

The Rabble

The individuals who eventually became the Rabble were all members of Those Who Walked Away who succeeded in overthrowing the oppressive regimes that they sought to combat. Having succeeded, they realized that success was not a one time event but instead was an ongoing struggle. They turned their attention not to ensuring a new government's ideals, but instead to preparing the population to fight back should the new government become tyrannical like the last. The Rabble see preparing the citizenry as the only defense against oppression, and believe that while help from the outside should come when needed, what stops tyrants is a population that would rather die than be oppressed.

Alessa's Hand

Exemplar Alessa of Bahadur was not born to simply wait around to be asked for her help. From her earliest days she was known to be headstrong, wild, and zealous, with a deep abiding hatred of anyone who would inflict suffering on others. She spent her youth traveling from battlefield to battlefield not for the purpose of fighting, but of relieving the suffering of anyone she found in pain. As her legend spread she developed a following of like minded individuals, and as this following grew it formed into a Convocation of its own. The Hand don't stop to think about why there is suffering, only that it exists and it can be combated. They are well known as not only healers of the injured and ill, but as smugglers who will attempt to run any blockade to get food and medicine inside a siege. They are as likely to be found distributing blankets in winter as they are to be breaking open a silo of hoarded grain to feed the starving.

The Wildland Compact

Wild Places, Nature, City Planning, Exploration

Patrons: Eilona, Metioch, Koreel, Gwenara

In the world there is far more space untamed and unexplored than there is planned, plotted, and structured. The Wildland Compact is comprised of those who have set their mind and purpose to these places in one way or another, though the shape of that devotion is as varies as the wild places themselves.

Unlike many Convocations, the Wildland Compact can not point to a single origin or inciting group. In fact, as long as people have lived there have been those who espoused the ideals of the Compact. Only after the Desuetude did like minded people begin to join with individuals and organizations to begin the Compact, formalizing their behavior and desires into official devotions. In fact, the Wildland Compact is most easily recognized not by gathering halls, livery, or organized events but instead by gatherings of the faithful that crop up almost instinctively when a need or desire arises for community action.

The majority of those in the Wildland Compact join for the expected reasons. Those who seek to protect the wilderness, to oversee the wild beasts of the land, or to live away from civilization alone and at peace with the wilderness. But those are not the only folk who find themselves drawn into this convocation. Explorers and cartographers join the compact due to the time they spend in those wild places. Most surprisingly are city planners, road builders, and builders who see it as a sacred duty to respect the world in their designs, spending their time deciding the exact needs of a village so as to use the least land for houses and fields or the best route to place a road so as to minimize the damage to land and wildlife.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy nature based themes, both in the preservation and cultivation of nature and natural resources.
- You look for plot that centers on nature and the relationship of people with the natural world.

Harbingers

To be Present at Momentous Times, Journalism, Prediction

Patrons: Garioch, Thiacris, Jormic, Bahadur, Severrin

There were a few who saw the Desuetude in the days before it happened. When the world was in mourning, their vision bound them together and they began to seek out others who were also sensitive to the huge changes that affected the world. The group now makes it a point to travel to find others like themselves. However, no matter their talent, one cannot be named a Harbinger; it can be decided only by the individual.

In the early days after the Convocation was formalized, it was common for Harbingers to be denied entrance. The groups simply took the denial as the sign they were waiting for and published that fact as far and wide as they could. Some people think that the appearance of a Harbinger automatically signals something frightening, but nothing could be farther than the truth. A Harbinger might request entrance to a royal military tent, but they are just as likely to appear to celebrate a child's birth or to enjoy a harvest festival.

Harbingers travel in groups called Circles. The group can be made up of any configuration of talents, but usually include an Oracle, one or two Witnesses, and some who are battle experienced. There is no single reason for a Harbinger to be somewhere, and they may not always know why something is momentous. Sometimes they are simply present, sometimes they record, and sometimes their presence or participation in a momentous occasion is what is important. After the event has occurred, whatever it may be, Harbingers make an effort to report it to the masses so that everyone from a High Priestess down to a humble painter knows exactly what has happened.

Notable Descendant Convocations:

Ink Filigree

Named to reflect the reach of the Lattice, this sect of the Harbingers is known for supporting the necessary network of information that must flow throughout Aeled.

Timekeepers

The people of Aeled all experience the passage of time, but a few are called to record time itself in the hopes to predict what might come next. People who follow the movement of the sun and stars, observe the Constellations, or watch the seasons will often join this Convocation. Farmers and Rangers have been known to join as well, since they are the first to see through weather and soil what might happen next. Healers, teachers, and politicians can all be found in the Timekeepers. While the entire convocation agrees their work is necessary, it is often very solitary.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy prophecy, recording, and spreading knowledge
- You look for plot that requires you to search for answers, defend your group against those who might wish them harm, and politics.

The Civil Lyceum

International Diplomacy, Education, Communication

Patrons: Thiacris, Jormic, Istarum, Metioch

Ambassadors, Teachers, and their counterparts have always existed on Aeled. After the Genesori pulled back from the world, Ambassadors from all nations struck out to meet in Eltiel. The meeting created the Civil Lyceum, for it was confirmed that despite the upheaval, passage of information and education must continue, for it was as the Oathtaker had said: "society needs a framework". They take over from the Harbingers by interpreting the news that has been announced and making sure that even the smallest of villages understands what the news means to them.

The Civil Lyceum stands out for their continued willingness to travel distances short and long to make sure that these services are readily available. The Lyceum considers it their sacred duty to make sure that information is available, accurate and impartial. A few Ambassadors seek to assist only in the spreading of information, and do not impose their own beliefs or interpretations on it. The majority have come to the conclusion that understanding information requires knowledge, and so the Civil Lyceum proudly takes on responsibility for education as well. Some scoff at any Convocation trying to control education; schools should be able to teach what they will, how they will. The Lyceum sees it differently: once someone has learned their letters and numbers, they should have an opportunity. The availability of education is a strong tenet of the Civil Lyceum, though when it comes down to it, most members teach what and how they will.

Notable Descendant Convocations: Voices of Validation

This Convocation began after three people witnessed a L'Dahn deciding a case with exceptional impartiality. "Where are the voices of those who were hurt?" one asked. "There should be someone who speaks for them as well."

Anyone can speak on behalf of anyone else, but those that are called to the Voices have a passion for advocating for the weak and helpless. Those from the Voices are often called to become formal Court Advocates and Interpreters of the Law. A subset of the Voices dedicates their skills solely to the defense of children.

Forum of Excellence

If you have a question that you cannot find an answer to, you might go to a Forum for help. If you revel in finding questions and discussing the answers, then the Forum could be the right place for you. The forum is known for dispatching scholars to the smallest of towns if an intriguing question arises. They seek to find answers, interpret them, and provide education wherever it is wanted.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy political plot, negotiation, and spreading knowledge in dangerous times
- You look for plot that lurks more in court halls than wild lands

The Cycle of the Wheel Everything has its Place and Time

Patrons: Gwennara, Severrin, Eilona, Metioch, Istarum

Once long ago, in the time before purpose, the living had lives governed by Fate. Those lives had a beginning and an end predetermined by a grand orderly plan. When Fate was sundered and the living beings of the world became the Purposed, their births and deaths were still overseen by the grand cycle of existence governed by Gwennara and Severrin.

The Cycle of the Wheel evolved from the ancient Church of the Eternal cycle, but following the Great Revelation the church changed its role to encompass far more than the cycle of creation and destruction. The Cycle of the Wheel understands that all things happen when they are meant to. That is not to say they believe in the ancient Fate, but that cycles of Birth and Death, passing of seasons, harvest, and even natural disaster all happen when the Genesori need them to. Being as these things will occur on the schedule of the Genesori, The Cycle of the Wheel must be there to assist with the event or the aftermath. Most hospitals and Hospices in the world bear the sign of the Cycle over their doors, and likewise do many storehouses of grain and supplies that the nations hold in reserve for the time when such things again are necessary.

While assisting the Cycle seems as though it is a passive calling, the Cycle of the Wheel also takes up the cause to ensure that things and people that attempt to break free from the cycle are placed back where they belong. This duty calls for a much more militant expression of faith than normally expected from adherents of the Cycle.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy the concept of balance, birth/death/rebirth as a major driving force of the world, and being a stabilizing force in the world
- You look for plot that focuses on balance, ensuring that the world continues to “function” as it should.

Notable Descendant Convocations

Merciful Ones

Merciful Ones have taken the enforcement of the Cycle as their sacred charge. While they recognize the beginnings of the Cycle to be of importance, their attention focuses solely on the ending, and specifically enforcing that things end when the Cycle ordains them to. Merciful Ones seek out anything and anyone who has broken free from the Cycle and corrects this aberration, either through persuasion, negotiation, counseling, or as a last resort, by force. A notable feature of Merciful Ones is their insistence on anonymity in their religious duty. Many will never note their membership in this Convocation and nearly all swear oaths to eschew fame and renown in their lives so that not even their legend outlives the Cycle.

The Enkindlers

This Offshoot of the Cycle of the Wheel sees their duty as the fostering of life, no matter the difficulty in doing so. The Enkindlers work hardest to begin the cycle in the most difficult places, seeking blighted land to grow crops, drought-stricken plains to irrigate, and even to work magic and aid to assist with difficult conception and childbirth. To an Enkindler the Cycle cannot be a Cycle if it never even starts, and they see it as their charge to ensure that the wheel begins to roll at all costs.

The Grand Conservatory

Philosophy, Research, Collection of Knowledge, Seeking the Unknown

Patrons: Koreel, Bahadur, Jormic, Thiacris

Considered by many to be the oldest of the Convocations, The Grand Conservatory began at the end of the Age of Piety to preserve the history of that age. That time was also the beginning of the Age of Discovery, with people of different continents learning and relearning one another. Many of those same people trying to preserve records of what had come before them were also creating records of the new things they were experiencing. Moreover, those days saw the

disbanding of the individual churches. The confluence of all these events allowed for the ease with which The Grand Conservatory arose.

Members of The Grand Conservatory are passionate about knowledge and all that can be learned through exploration. Whether that exploration is through tomes in a library or dangerous new territory, they seek answers at all costs.

Many members of the Grand Conservatory also hold membership in either the Harbingers or the Civil Lyceum in order to support their ability to spread the word of what they learn.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy taking notes and sharing information.
- You look for plot that is lore and information-heavy.

The Revel

Celebration, Aid to Those in Need, Entertainment

Patrons: All Genesori

The Revel is an interesting group in that it likely has no true fixed origin, but it has a widely accepted mythology about its beginnings. Throughout the years, the Purposed of the world have developed many festivals and celebrations, from Brother Otis' Day to Kith Kindle and more. Individuals, families, and larger congregations within society have taken the steps in good times and bad to make these celebratory days feel special. In that respect, the Revel has always existed. However, the story told about the Revel's origins is one of a group of Bards, all of whom worshiped a different Genesori, who stumbled into a village that had recently been visited by terrible storms. The people of the village had little interest in sharing with strangers. But the clever bards began asking for single items from the villagers; space in the square to set up a cauldron for soup, permission to gather storm-torn branches, a match to light a fire, water from the well. A carrot here, an onion there, and before long, they had a pot of soup simmering cheerfully. Next, the Bards looked for anyone living on the street and invited them to share in the soup they had. Many tried to decline, saying that there hardly seemed enough to share, but the Bards insisted. The story then claims a miracle, that no matter how many villagers came for a bowl, the cauldron of soup never got closer to empty. And as the villagers came and ate, they enjoyed each other's company, and begged the Bards for a song. The Bards obliged, and the simple meal of soup turned into a feast for the spirit. When the Bards left the village the next day, they knew they were leaving it far richer, and their hearts were so full that they elected to travel together deliberately searching for villages in need of good cheer. And so the Revel was created.

In these times, the Revel is a more stationary group, as most communities have at least a handful of people dedicated to providing comfort and cheer. It is considered to be the most populous convocation for similar reasons, but also because members of the Revel will claim as their own individuals who carry out the Revel's mission without formally declaring membership.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy performing in front of any sized group
- You enjoy providing food for others
- You look for plot where you are tasked with aiding the NPCs through RP.

Notable Offshoot Convocations

The Order of Ayreaux

An early member of the Revel once it formalized as a Convocation, Ayreaux d'Siniste was a man whose mission was to celebrate the quiet joys of life and to bring a smile to everyone he met. He was the type to sing to crying children or point out a beautiful cloud. His calm kindness brought him many followers and he led them by his example. Members of this order become the self-appointed Aunties and Uncles of their communities, uplifting those around them through small, constant acts of acceptance and affirmation. The Order of Ayreaux will be the ones who, after a large seasonal celebration, encourage reflection on the delights of the event, counseling one to keep those feelings of happiness with them throughout the year.

The Sublime Miracle

Philosophy, Mysticism, Magical Exploration, Exploration of Purpose, Astrology

Patrons: Koreel, Thiacris, Garioch

The Sublime Miracle began as an offshoot of The Grand Conservatory, created when many of the more philosophical members of the Conservatory began to feel that they were being persuaded to find answers, rather than to simply explore questions. For example, while the Conservatory is content with the history of Fate's Sacrifice creating Purpose, members of The Sublime Miracle wonder if Fate always knew that his time of Sacrifice would come, or if he chose in the moment; they ask what meaning that has for people; they ask what drives an individual's Purpose and why some Purpose is stronger than others.

Many members of The Sublime Miracle have a hermetic bent, isolating themselves for years to ponder their questions. Still others prefer the challenge of discourse. One of the most public-facing roles that members of this convocation have established is the performance of marriage ceremonies, as a reflection that Love and why people fall for one another remains one of life's great mysteries.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy theory-crafting RP.
- You look for plot that prompts questions about the workings of the world.

The Flame Ardent

New Experiences, Games, Travel, Zeal, Dueling

Patrons: Bahadur, Eilona, Gwennara, Garioch

Unlike many Convocations, there is no single group or event that precipitated the creation of the Flame Ardent. Instead, the Flame Ardent is an amalgam of many smaller convocations that came together over time due to their intense passions and drive. What binds the Flame Ardent together is not a storied history or ancient oath, but instead is a need for the new, novel, exciting, or unique. From warriors who always seek the greatest challenge to gamblers who look for new games and connoisseurs who travel the world for new food, those in this Convocation want nothing more than to experience greatness and share it with the world.

While many in the Flame Ardent take this challenge personally, there are also those who seek not just to find personal experience but instead look outside themselves and share with the world. A chef who pushes the boundaries of cuisine and a traveling band of warriors seeking new enemies both only serve their objectives if others are present with them to either join or witness. Even when something new is done alone, most of the Flame Ardent find a second great joy in sharing or retelling the tales of these events to others.

Consider this Convocation for your Character if...

- You enjoy being a bon vivant, being an encouraging and upbeat personality
- You look for plot that allows you to both command and share a bright spotlight, engage with bravado and a positive engaging attitude.

Notable Offshoot Convocations

The Divine Society of Mediating the Influence of Corruption through Occasional Moderate Indulgence (Commonly known as "The Moderates")

This order is listed as a descendant of the Flame Ardent, when it might be better to describe this order as one that was subsumed by the Flame Ardent but then reemerged as an entity in its own right. The name for this organization says it all. They believe that the best way to the Influence that the Lesser Corruptions still exert on the Purposed is to experience these flaws in controlled ways. For example, when the Moderates meet, they are encouraged to vent about something or someone that irritates them, briefly allowing themselves to express Hatred of that thing or person, possibly doing violence to an effigy of that thing, in an effort to purge those negative feelings. Moderates look out for one another, and intervene if they believe that indulging in a Flaw is doing more harm than good.

TRAVEL AND COMMERCE

The Lattice

Under and throughout the entire world runs a lattice of magic. Where the lattice lines cross there are nodes that can be used to power great workings, especially travel. There are many conflicting theories about the origins and purpose of the lattice – of one the most notable being that it's a fundamental part of the world and has no separate origin or purpose – but no one knows for sure. What is definitively known is that it's essential to travel and communicate in a world as large as Aeledd.

Travel

Travel by Threshold

Where Nodes in the Lattice exist, it is possible to create Thresholds. Each Threshold allows travel to several specific other Thresholds in the blink of an eye. They vary greatly in size. Many are only large enough to accommodate a few travelers, or perhaps a small cart, but others are able to transport caravans, ships or entire armies.

Travel by Gate

Where there is no convenient Threshold, it is possible to travel by opening a Gate. People with certain specialized skills, tools, bloodlines or blessings can access the lattice directly without need for a Threshold. However this requires substantial skill to perform at all, and the difficulty increases greatly with the distance to be traveled or the size of the group to be moved. No known being can match even a moderately sized Threshold with a Gate.

Travel by Water

Aeledd is vast, and much of the interior of the continents are trackless. Overland travel is an arduous endeavor. Travel by water is comparatively swift, but even by ship, travel is difficult and dangerous. The best way to transport large amounts of goods or people is by combining ship and threshold, such as via the famous Myosi Sea Gates.

Travel by Air

The people of Eltiel travel between mountain peaks using a series of mechanisms and cables known as the Skyways. These devices are built in fixed places using technology known only to the Eltiel military.

Legends tell of a group of heroes who traveled the world in a flying ship. Tinkers, arcaneers and shipwrights have been trying to duplicate this supposed feat for generations without success and despair that it will ever be duplicated.

Economy

The Merchant's Guild is the crux of the economy of Aeled. This guild gives stability to the world's money and lets international trading be conducted fairly and equitably. The Merchant's Guild officially recognizes three denominations of coin, the Drakar, the Ketch and the Reel. Many places may ascribe other names to the currency, either to be more convenient, or to pay homage to their older currency, but these three coins are recognized the world over.

Different nations and organizations occasionally mint coins with varying colors and imprints, but by far the most common are the Mysoi trade coins which were adopted by the Merchant's Guild as its standard coinage. These coins are silver and embossed with images of sailing ships. Regardless of the make of a coin however, Drakar are always circular, Ketch rectangular and Reels octagonal. Ten Drakar are worth one Ketch and ten Ketch are worth one Reel.

Originally the coins were the docking fees for types of ships. Drakar was for a non-cargo ship to dock, meaning it either was passengers, privateers, fishing vessels or privately owned ships for non-mercantile purposes. A Ketch was for a cargo ship, trading goods between ports. The actual ship size was immaterial and more relied on the purpose for the ship. A Reel was a separate "type" of coin that was made after, when traders began to accumulate more and more money via trading. High end items may occasionally be sold using this currency, but it is more a currency to show off wealth, or to measure value of large sums/trade routes.

While prices might vary depending on the location, a Drakar would normally cover a night at an inn for a traveler, along with a meal that night (forever stew-type), per person. If the place you are at has a more fancy room available and/or provided a more substantial meal, they might go anywhere from 3 Drakar to a Ketch.

A Drakar would probably buy food for a person for a couple days, though it again depends on the type of food they want, and where they are. More fish could be obtained in a fishing village than the middle of a desert for the same cost, etc. A Ketch would buy significant amounts of basic foodstuffs, or could provide a few individuals a meal in a restaurant. A Reel would likely not be used as a measure of money for purchasing food, except perhaps in the MOST extravagant of restaurants.

Basic tools, such as a hoe, rake or shovel, would generally be a couple Drakar, though as with everything else, scarcity can change that price. Larger tools, like a plow to be hooked up to larger animals, would cost 5 Drakar to a Ketch. These tools usually lasted for a very long time however. A Reel would almost never be used to purchase tools.

Many places would often use a barter system between individuals in a small village, where one farmer might trade some food grown for tools from a blacksmith. Thus currency is usually used more for international trading and exchange than an everyday measure of what items might be worth.

Merchants

It's expected that the heroes of Fortunes Bend will have various items for sale, both those they have empowered using their specific skills as well as more mundane commodities. However the Merchants Guild also offers for sale a standard array of items, including alchemical concoctions, tinker constructions, arcaneered inventions and even some wholly magical and enchanted items. The basic items will almost always be available at a cost slightly above what it would take to craft them. But those looking for something more powerful, or something very specific, need to arrange a face-to-face meeting with a member of the Merchant's Guild. A single individual can only bear so many objects of power, so even the fabulously wealthy are not adorned with magic objects. The merchants' guild also employs crafters that are able to repair weapons and armor in addition to selling new goods.

Banks

A new development in the world of Aeledde is banking. The Merchants Guild stores coin for their customers, ensuring that they always have plenty on hand and that travelers and adventurers don't need to drag heavy coin purses with them. All coin placed in a Guild deposit box is absolutely vouchsafed by the guild. It can be withdrawn again at any point, but that is seldom necessary. A writ authorizing payment from the merchants' guild is accepted by nearly everyone as payment.

Money Makes the World Go Round

Throughout Aeledde, coin solves many problems. Everything from commonplace goods to exotic ritual components, from corrupt administrators to the health benefits of eating well is available for purchase if you know where to look. Sedentary nobles and merchant princes may accumulate great wealth, but adventurers know that money does more good – for them and for others – if it's spent.

THE REALMS

Aeledd

Aeledd is the physical and mortal realm. It is sometimes referred to as “the world” or “the real world” but it is no more real or fundamental than any other realm. However, it is the realm that is most physical and most comprehensible to living, mortal beings. It is also the domain of the incarnation of Magic, sometimes known as Tiesh. The regions, nations and peoples discussed in this book all exist on Aeledd.

The Shade

Just beyond the threshold of the physical world is the Shade, a shadowy mirror where perception and purpose matter more than logic or flesh. Long ago, the Shade was Fate's realm. With Fate's hand guiding it, the Shade was a place where destiny and purpose were decided. During the era of imbalance, it was a lawless frontier. Now it is drawing closer to the mortal world, and even overlapping in places.

The Void

The Void is a place of remembrance and death. The Heart of the Void is the home of Death herself, sometimes called Lesh, or the Lady of Moths. The Void is accessible to the living via both the Gate of Moths in Fortune's Bend and via the Bridge, but outside of the rare event of the Bridging, the living can travel the Void only briefly and with great hardship.

The Divine

Stories tell of a Divine Realm that is home to the Genesori. Aeledd, the Shade and the Void exist separately but interconnected and in balance with one another. The Divine realm is completely separate since the Genesori have chosen not to touch the world directly. Those of great faith or in possession of powerful relics may occasionally call on the power of the Divine, but only the Genesori and their Divine Zeniths may physically travel there. As such, almost nothing of it is known by mortals.

Noteworthy Beings of the Realms

The Gargoyles

There are beings known as the Gargoyles. These are not the grim, stone creatures of old tales but wondrous creations of Fate, bound with the substance of the Shade and Aeledd in equal parts. Once thought to be mere myth, their presence in the world has been palpable in recent centuries. Each was entrusted with the task to watch for the gifts of the living that Fate held dear and their names speak of those assets: Lorekeeper, Tuneweaver, Heartbinder, Oathtaker,

Lightseer, and Wayfinder. Now they watch the Purposed and have made it their duty to bestow blessings upon those who embodied the same gifts that Fate held dear the most.

Lorekeeper wanders through villages and cities, their ears listening for the retelling of tales of old and the first utterances of new tales that could become local lore. Their eyes watch for those who seek out the old knowledge in book and scroll and share the legends of their people. Tuneweaver, on the other hand, floats through the streets and festivals, listening for melodies that stir the heart and move the soul. Their presence is often marked by the harmonious hum of music and song.

Heartbinder moves among communities, oft unseen but ever present, their focus on those who mend broken bonds and foster unity. Oathtaker is a silent guardian of promises and commitments, recognizing those who uphold their word with unwavering resolve. Lightseer, a beacon of hope, roams the darkest corners of the world, seeking out those who bring light and optimism to others. Way Finder is the guide, they watch for those who plan, get ready and prepare. Honoring those who help others be ready for what will come their way.

The Celestials

The Celestials are the children of Death and Fate, and they are in general the most powerful denizens of the Shade. Each one has a representation among the stars, a constellation. Each celestial has 4 aspects, each associated with a different season. And each aspect has certain words and themes that represent how they influence the lives of the purposed.

Celestials of the Broken City

Celestial	Winter Aspect	Spring Aspect	Summer Aspect	Fall Aspect	Constellation
The Prisoner	The Guilty Thief often represents capture, victory of the law, or a maimed limb.	Chained by Love often represents young romance, love at first sight, obsession, or selfish affection.	The Captured Soldier often represents military defeat, a broken fighter, finally meeting someone stronger, or paying the cost of someone else's deed.	The Unforgiven often represents self-flagellation, a prison of the mind, disgrace, despair, or regret.	Pisces
Maiden	The Seamstress often represents careful planning, hard work, construction, or a solitary profession.	The Virgin often represents purity, youth, innocence, or unspoiled wilderness.	The Dancer often represents rhythm, gaeity, celebration, courthship, or discipline versus passion.	The Bride often represents commitment, a new beginning, two becoming one, passage into adulthood, romance, or illusions.	Andromeda
Eagle	Royal Eagle often represents royalty, authority by power, or the highest authority	Majestic Flyer often represents beauty, the arts, nature, or birds.	The Black Eagle represents war, violence on the battlefield, a seasoned veteran, or cold observation.	The Vulture often represents ugliness, fear, scavengers, evidence of guilt, survival, or unwanted obligations.	Cassiopeia
Arrow	Black Thorn often represents poison, thorns, or assassination.	Silver Arrow often represents riches, nobility, vitality, or inspiration.	War Bolt often represents war, order and chaos, unexpected	True Shaft often represents archery, success, competition,	Triangulum

			bad news, or methodical thinking.	painful honesty, or a vital choice.	
Lamb	Tethered Lamb often represents foreboding, pain, a dark fate, or innocent bait	Frolicking Lamb often represents children, frivolity, joy, or a carefree spirit.	The Ram to Be often represents predestination, leadership, strength, or heirs.	The Shorn Sheep often represents commerce, industry, trade, temporary loss,	Aries
Archer	The Steppes Bowman often represents archery as a way of life, a fierce nature, barren times or terrain, or a long shot.	The Ace Archer often represents competition, professional archers, victory, pinnacle of a martial craft, magic bows, or magic arrows.	A Child on their First Hunt often represents a new skill, an unfamiliar terrain, first-born children, acceptable failure, paternal relationships, or transition to adulthood.	The Assassin often represents assassination, poison, vital blows, a one-shot kill, or sudden loss.	Perseus
The Wife	The Baker often represents food, providers, celebration, process, end of hunger, or comfort.	The Mother often represents children, life, birth, nurture, nostalgia, or home.	The Slattern often represents disloyalty, loss of control, humiliation, practicality, the true power beneath a facade, or desire.	The Courtier often represents elegance, an unattainable goal, arrogance, wealth, or masks.	Taurus
Tyrant	The Tyrant's Head often represents the end of tyranny, victory for good, the inevitable failure of evil, or revolution.	The Small, Petty Tyrant often represents petty authoritarians, overbearing parents,	The Tyrant Rising often represents political intrigue, assassination, ambition, betrayal, or the power to rule.	The Tyrant Surrounded often represents fear, paranoia, loneliness, working for something to discover it was not	Orion

		minor bureaucrats, or school bullies.		worth the cost, or a harbinger of doom.	
Gate	The Iron Gate often represents a way that is closed, exclusion, or that your enemy is will protected.	The Hinged Gate often represents choice, passage from one thing to another, the possibility of return, or undeath.	The Wooden Gate often represents husbandry, family, agriculture, insufficient protection, or a warning not to assume security.	The Stone Gate often represents ancient things, no possibility of return, leaving the familiar behind, or the concept of death.	Coma Berenices
Oxen	Ox tail Stew often represents a sacrifice, a needful loss of something useful, a worthwhile death that is not your own, or a ruinous moment of need.	The Baby Ox often represents strength yet to be, fertility, birth, the cycle of rural life, or investment.	The Sacrificial Beast often represents worship of the genesori, the cost of divine intervention, costly strategies, taking undue credit, or casting false suspicion.	The Beast of Burden often represents farming, carrying a burden for others, community, growth, patient labor, diligence, or lack of ambition.	Cones Venatici
The Fortress	The Stagnant Tower often represents imprisonment, starvation, inadequate shelter, or an incorrect strategy.	The Lonely Wall often represent distance from loved ones, being outnumbered, retreading old ground, diligence, or soldiers.	The Pastoral Ruins often represents complacency, a well-deserved reward, peace, old age, or a simple life disrupted.	The Embattled Keep often represents attacks from all sides, desperation, unpopular opinions, or a danger to the homefront.	Bootes
The Rat	The Scavenger often represents cleverness, stealth, the thief who steals what they must,	The Plague Carrier often represents disease, pestilence,	Wharf Rat often represents untrained combat, pugilists, thuggish minions, or	The Vermin often represents garbage, hysteria, unsupported	Ursa minor

	and one who finds value where others do not.	unwelcome messages, or decay.	something larger than expected.	fears, fear-mongering, or carrion.	
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Celestials of the Crossroads

Celestial	Winter Aspect	Spring Aspect	Summer Aspect	Fall Aspect	Constellation
Rope	Hanged Man often represents disgrace, punishment, revolution, or warning that a past transgression will soon come to light.	Climbing Rope often represents making the impossible possible, lofty goals, transcendence, or Aeledd's contrast with the divine realm.	The Knot often represents security, expertise, long-lasting good craftsmanship, something complex made simple, or a memory.	The Lariat often represents a failure to escape, a sudden halt, a geographically distant threat, capture, or an expansion of influence.	Draco
Crow	Sootwing often represents survival through ingenuity, adaptation, illusion, and local knowledge.	The Winged Thief often represents prosperity through cunning, mischief, tinkers, or a victory of the unworthy.	The Laden Nest often represents collections, covetousness, personal weakness, or wealth.	The Mob often represents a threat reveal, harassment, victory through numbers, or protection of community.	Corona Borealis
The Road	The Dark Path often represents unknown destinations, dangerous journeys, unpleasant methods, or going astray.	The Cobbled Street often represents a market, finances, trade, civilization, crowds, expansion, a great city, or conquest through money.	The Road Untaken often represents adventure, promise, ingenuity, good times, or meeting new friends.	The Pass often represents a way through difficulty, rewards for persistence, pressure from multiple sides, or an effective idea.	Serpens

The Beggar	The Starving Man often represents hunger that does not end, the displaced, those too prideful to beg, or charity.	The Con Artist often represents thieves, lies, deception, or vulnerable prey.	The Wounded Veteran often represents maimed limbs, infantry soldiers, widows and widowers, or an overlooked need.	The Humble Beggar often represents beggars, poverty, desperate need, inequality, or an overlooked asset.	Hercules
The Flame	The Hearth often represents, home, family, homesteading, hospitality, or acceptance.	Campfire often represents safety, warmth, danger just beyond sight, or storytelling.	Burning Inferno often represents pain, uncontrolled fire, torture, arson, passion, or rage.	The Spark often represents life, inspiration, creation, or dedication.	Auriga
The Hut	Roadside Tavern often represents safety from the elements, an oasis, far travelers, traders, or rumors.	The Stranger's House often represents a warning to be wary of the open door. It can also represent insanity, perversion of home, or returning home to find it changed.	The Hovel often represents hardship, charity, destitution, moral bankruptcy, or a decaying society.	The Rangers Lean-To Camp often represents rangers, hunting for food, using natural resources, distance from home, or emotional solitude.	Monoceros
The Bear Trap/Trap	The Rusty Jaws often represents inept hunters, unusable things, an	The Bloody Trap often represents a costly escape, blood, maimed	The Large Bear Caught often represents hunters, trappers, a great	The Empty Trap represents failure, an inept hunter or thief, a failed	Gemini

	unsprung trap, or disease.	limbs, desperate sacrifice, or the prey having the last word.	thing destroyed by trickery, immobility, extortion, or circumstantial constraints.	ambush, a false victory, or the opponent having the last laugh.	
The Old Woman	The Grandmother often represents kindness, wisdom, gifts, and knowledge.	The Widow often represents grief, sadness, loss, love coming to an end, or the Cairns.	The Hag often represents punishment, arcane power, fear of the unknown, guilt, or misanthropy.	The Storyteller often represents history, knowledge, morality, creativity, bards, or prophecy.	Canis Minor
Hound	The Mad Dog often represents frenzy, bestial nature, the familiar turning on you, and feral canines.	A Boy's Best Friend often represents dogs, unquestioning loyalty and friendship, nostalgia, or the return of an old friend.	The Warhound often represents a dog of huge size, a torn throat, the bestial nature of war, the loyalty of troops to their commander, or words turning to violence.	The Drowned Puppy often represents waste, cruelty, orphans, cowardly murder, or innocence lost.	Lynx
Hunter	The Trapper often represents the patient predator, the provincial provider, making use of every resource, and	The Fisherman often represents bounty from mystery, fishermen, temptation leading to danger, or a wide-reaching trap.	The Trophy Hunter often represents disregard for others, great skill, a braggart, a legend brought to an end,	The Bounty Hunter often represents vigilantism, blood money, unorthodox justice, a lonely hunt, or a warning of danger.	Cancer

	knowing your target.		gluttony, or obsession.		
Stallion	The Stud often represents being past one's prime, noble lineage, retirement, or arranged marriages.	The Unicorn often represents the Arcanis, a healer-warrior, the power of pure emotions, innocence, curatives, or healers.	The Wild Spirit often represents speed, freedom, an unbreakable spirit, graceful strength, or the guardian of a natural place.	The War Horse often represents warfare, bravery, thundering power, unstoppable force, carrying extra burdens, or the crushing of hope.	Camelopardis

Celestials of the Faraway Isle

Celestial	Winter Aspect	Spring Aspect	Summer Aspect	Fall Aspect	Constellation
Lioness	Shape in the Grass often represents an expert, provider that risks all, rangers, and a culler of the sick or weak.	The Ousted Mate often represents maternal instinct, exile, selfless acts for the young or weak, hard living, or protecting a legacy.	The Pride often represents companies, teamwork, many hands with one mind, skirmishers, or a besieged group.	The Queen often represents inherent nobility, savage beauty, power behind the throne, or a delicate negotiation.	Leo Minor
Lion	Among the Pride often represents suspicion, familial treachery, protection, and hereditary rulers.	King of Beasts often represents kinship, natural heirarchy, divine right, charisma, the Kingmaker, or beasts.	The Lion Rampant often represents righteous rage, retaliation from on high, an unconquerable spirit, and genealogy.	The Manhunter often represents hubris, ignorance of nature, foolishness, just desserts, or being put in one's place.	Leo Minor
Stag	The White Hart often represents legends, great trophies, elusive answers, or a	The Prey often represents escape, alertness, trickery, stealth, self-preservation, instinct, or fear.	The Young Buck often represents virility, competition, masculinity, passage to adulthood, or persistence.	The Carcass often represents the concept of death, trading beauty for practicality, cycle of life, food chains, or	Ursa Major

	reward for a kind heart.			commonality after removal of status.	
The Shell	The Crab often represents risks bringing rewards, alien forms, evasion, armor, or lower societal class.	The Mollusk often represents fool's gold, basic needs, unremarkable things, want versus need, or a reward incongruent with effort.	The Oyster often represents riches, desire, hidden treasure, humility, or defense.	The Egg often represents faith in the outcome, mystery, caretakers, or that a great future requires effort.	Lyra
The Explorer	The Anthropologist often represents a foreign people, minority becoming majority, new customs, or understanding.	The Cartographer often represents order, conquering fear, evaluation of assets, scholars, or gaining a new perspective.	The Treasure Hunter often represents greed, adventure, reward at the end of a dangerous road, puzzles, legends, or chasing a dream.	The Archaeologist often represents ancient secrets, things lost being found, careful preservation, or a message from the past.	Sagitta
The Ship	The Raft often represents trade, bloodflow, heedless wandering, or acceptance of the outcome.	The Shipwreck often represents scavengers, despair, senseless loss, punishment, or loss to overpowering forces.	The Oceanrider often represents hope in the face of impossible odds, trust in the unseen, shallow knowledge, or confidence in a dangerous situation.	Coastal Skimmer often represents a risktaker, a fringe society, unstable or dangerous terrain, or danger on all sides.	Aquila

The Jewel	White Diamond often represents marriage, riches, purity, supreme toughness, or assigned value.	Green Emerald often represents vanity, jewelry, aristocracy, snobbery, or arrogance.	Red Ruby often represents blood, love, anger, killing out of passion, assigning value to life, or status by association.	A Rock often represents being cheated, an unlucky result, worthlessness, undeserved outcasts, or doting parents.	Vulpecula
The Pit	The Void often represent permanent death or self-determination.	The Open Grave often represents a doorway for those you have slain, unfinished business, the Bonekeeper, fear of death, or portents of danger.	The Abyss often represents insatiable hunger, dark urges, temptation, or corruption.	The Precipice often represents an important decision, caution, foolishness, balance, or a warning that the ends do not justify the means.	Cygnus
River	The Delta often represents imminent danger, imminent loss of control, passage into a different world, or an expansive world.	Flood often represents betrayal, danger below the surface, overwhelming circumstances, or loss of a friend to outside forces.	The Source often represents life, mountains, rain, cycles, solving a mystery, oases, or a reward for difficult work.	Meander often represents trade, following a set course, being carried along, or reliability.	Delphinus
Jackal	The Jackal in the Shadows	The Baby Eater often represents monstrous	A Pack of Carrion Eaters often represents a	The Lone Jackal often represents a thief on their	Equuleus

	often represents assassins, highwaymen, fanatics, or a treacherous end from an unlikely source.	action born of desperation, the small or the weak, thuggery, a robbery that ends in death, or the betrayal of the duty of care.	ragged assembly, a gang of criminals, scavengers, starvation, or systemic injustice.	own, a master thief, a tombraider, or standing alone against a crowd.	
Beast	Eyes in the Darkness often represents mystery, terror of the unknown, or bravery.	The Subtle Threat often represents betrayal, hidden in plain sight, lack of caution, or a misleading appearance.	Great Monster often represents strength, fortitude, terror of the unknown, or knowledge of mortality.	The Hunted Beast often represents the hunt, tracking, caution, a battle of wills, or the ends of endurance.	Cepheus
Sentinel	Watcher in the Dark often represents sinister intentions, unknown foes, becoming prey, or scrying.	The Golem often represents a dormant power, eternal sleep, hubris, enchanters, constructs, or stifled will.	The Gargoyle often represents a dangerous location, a bane to evil, night, or the Purposed.	The Night Watchman often represents fear of the dark, psychological fear, neglect of duty, terror, or weak defenses.	Lacerta

Celestials of the Killing Fields

Celestial	Winter Aspect	Spring Aspect	Summer Aspect	Fall Aspect	Constellation
The Worm	Worm in a Jar often represents biology, the scientific study of nature, specimens, childhood, or captivity.	Worm on a Hook often represent fishing, bait for a trap, prioritizing utility over life, a final service, or dread.	Worm in the Grave often represents the inevitability of death, decay, the Cairns, the undead, a spoiled bounty, or a warning of corruption.	The Worm Within often represents parasites, decomposition, transience of flesh, wasting illnesses, or vulnerability to corruption.	Pegasus
Priest	The Counselor often represents good advice, preparation, intangible obstacles, or recognizing personal weakness.	The Exalted often represents piety, humility, angels, divine magic, or a paragon of faith.	The Confessor often represents judgment, eyes of the genosori, Zeniths, torture, guilt, siege, or persistence.	The Charitable Friar often represents travel, last rites, pity, providing for the needy, or faith without arrogance.	Canis Major
Ghost	The Hallway Spirit often represents murder, treachery, family ties, or secrets behind a normal facade.	The Wisp often represents a beacon, wind, a neglected situation, attention for the meek, or fragile emotions.	The Garden Spectre often represents being watched, evil within beauty, spite, envy, or toxic family.	The Shade often represents condemnation, revenge, murderous intent, or insurmountable evil.	Puppis
Lance	The Jousting Rod often represents high spirits, festivity, glory	and Aid them in Romance often represents	To Make them Grand in Battle..... often represents	The Page's Burden often represents aspirations,	Volans

	without risk, and competition among nobility.	flirtation, physical attractiveness, wooing, foppery, illegitimate children, or romantic tales.	cavalry, nobility in war, national struggles on a personal level, glory. knights, or heraldics.	conformity, rigid structure, or societal injustice.	
Knight	The Black Knight often represents authorized treachery, broken rules, cheating, and brains over brawn.	Knight Errant often represents travel, solitary existence, integrity, honor, or being beholden to none.	The Courtly Lover often represents romance, unspoken love, courtship, chivalry, noble sacrifice, or poets.	The Guardian often represents bodyguards, martyrs, protection, the value of life, or selflessness.	Cornina
Owl	The Sleeping Owl often represents dulled wisdom, danger running amok, or untapped knowledge.	The Hatchling often represents unfamiliar territory, students, bewilderment, or beginning of knowledge.	The Great Horned Owl often represents merciless judgment, omniscience, power and dignity, or knowledge of wrongdoing.	The Barn Owl often represents compelling charisma, subtlety, silence, assassins, or an enemy nearby.	Pyxis
Witch	Snow Queen often represents cruelty, envy, relationship endings, or cold.	The Trickster often represents justice, vengeance, dark humor, or exposing flaws.	Bright Lady often represents light, compassion, joy, restorative magics, or broken curses.	The Crone often represents evil, decay, power, curses, or the warning against rigid opinions.	Vela

Squire	The Sullen Lad often represents envy, resentment, underappreciated work, or threat of treachery.	The Secret Admirer often represents unrequited love, distraction from duty, personal over national, or ideation.	The Heir often represents respect for elders, tradition, reward for duty, celebration of children, or generational trauma.	The Young Sir often represents undeserved status, insincerity, a cruel leader, a sheltered mind, or a childhood disrupted.	Sextens
Boar	The Winter Feast often represents a fall from grace, the spoils of war, or a nullified threat.	The Jolly Trotter often represents carefree joy, games, time for family, virility, or flirtation.	The Angry Prey often represents the tables turned, victory of the oppressed, underestimation, or the end of a regime.	The Burrow often represents unseen danger, a sudden attack, sacred ground, or a last stand.	Antila
Sword	The Hoarfrost Blade often represents being unprepared for battle, carelessness, something useless but pretty, or inexperience.	The Bloodletter often represents bloodlust, unwarranted violence, sadism, draining away, or carnage.	Sword on the Mantlepiece often represents inheritance, rich history, destiny, a greater purpose, or a forgotten purpose.	The Shattered Blade often represents effort for nothing, an inviable solution, impotence, defeat, or strategic intelligence.	Chameleon
Shield	One Man's Roof often represents time for reevaluation, making use of assets,	The Buckler often represents agility, overconfidence, rogues, or	Tower Shield often represents a great burden, all options having a high cost,	The Coat of Arms often represents pride, a family matter, a strategic	Crater

	determination, or wanderers.	anticipation of attack.	an army, a military defense, or a voluntary recluse.	target, heraldics, inner strength, or the strengths of animals.	
Dragon	The Frost Drake often represents overcoming weakness, mastering elements, ice, or a heartless warrior.	The Scaly Hide often represents a fierce protector, rain, an impenetrable defense, or a strategy to attack the interior.	The Great Wyrn often represents a sacrifice required, an overpowering enemy, fire, terror, destruction, or storms.	The Slain Beast often represents a great thing brought low, a successful quest, the end of a long conflict, or that insurmountable odds are better than they appear.	Hydra

The Vargoth

The Vargoth are mysterious entities that destroyed Valarmore over a decade ago and are currently attacking the Five Duchies. The Vargoth were widely considered mindless monsters, and so the world was shocked when the Vargoth Empire declared themselves a nation, peer to the others of Aeled, and expressed a desire to open diplomatic and trade relations. Some nations have opened negotiations with the Vargoth, while others support the Five Duchies and their defense of the Howling Gates. For now, most nations remain divided or neutral, either uncertain how to proceed in this unexpected turn of events or unwilling to engage with either side of a war being fought in faraway lands. But more and more peoples and nations are beginning to understand the threat the Vargoth represent.

The foot soldiers of the Vargoth assaults appear to be those who have fallen in previous attacks, reduced to empty Husks by some unknown means. Other people seemed to have Turned to the Vargoth cause with their minds intact. Alice Stormbow, now the High Herald of the Vargoth Empire was once one of their fiercest opponents. Those who have been where the fighting is the fiercest have reported bloodcurdling shrieks in the distance, but if any have seen the source of these noises, they have not lived to tell the tale. All these facts have led to a great deal of speculation about the true nature of the Vargoth and the means by which they recruit their forces – speculation which has thus far produced very few answers.

A BRIEF HISTORY

Dates

Throughout history and in different parts of the world, dates have been reckoned in a variety of ways. Those familiar with history will know of the Shrouded Age, the Age of Piety, the Age of Discovery, the Age of Breaking and numerous other named ages. However modern experts regard the Desuetude as the defining event of the modern era. Thus, most dates are recorded as the number of years since that event in the Age of Works. Dates prior to the Desuetude are recorded as the number of years before that event and called the Age of Faith.

Quick Tip

To get the year in the world of Numina, take the real year and subtract 1900.

Historical Timeline

Historians generally regard the following events as critical and age-defining. Dates on Rues prior to about 150 AF and everywhere in the world prior to about 1000 AF are approximate. The isolation of Rues and the disruption following the breaking of the Lattice makes exact dating impossible. The dates below are commonly used approximations.

Year	Major Event
124	The Vargoth Empire proclaims itself a nation and seeks diplomatic relations with other nations. Eltiel falls suddenly without explanation. Mists blanket what was once the Skyways.
123	The Farthest Star conference, called at Fortune's Bend to discuss the Vargoth threat, is attacked by the Vargoth.
116-117	Two major floods in rapid succession sweep Aluvair.
111	A Diamondback skin is found in T'barris, leading to the elevation of King Y'vain Pelle.
110-120	Heroes of Old Fortune's Bend appear throughout the world.
114	Pestilence wracks Konnigstrava.

113	Eviar Leonate is elected Crown Prince of Ophrailles
112	Valarmore is destroyed by the Vargoth invasion.
108	Valaq in Merrigor is abandoned to the forest. Lasaldi is named 7th city in its place.
81 AW	Evenia Mercurio Pentratheron is crowned Empress of the Mecurian Empire on Rues.
62 AW	Regent Berkeley Evers reveals Nira's mark and takes his seat on the Compass Rose of Spyndlemere.
0 AW	The Desuetude Pronouncement. Large churches are disbanded in favor of good-works based convocations.
133 AF	Lattice travel is rediscovered
175 AF	The Great Rebalancing. Death, Magic and Purpose are brought into balance and protected from Corruption.
182 AF	The Night of Guardian's Glory. The renegade Zenith Ravvin makes a bid for divinity and is prevented.
1400 AF	Garioch strikes Rues from the world, isolating it and breaking the Lattice
1450 AF	Fate is destroyed. Thinking mortals become purposed and the world is thrown into imbalance.